How to Get Together (With Half The World Our Witness)

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How to Get Together (With Half The World Our Witness)

by earlgreyingtea

Summary

"Can you all stop thirsting over my roommate? That's my job, thank you very much."

In which Phainon is very bad at games, surprisingly good at streaming, and somewhere between both at falling in love.

Chapter 1

Chapter Notes

A/N: There's a Vietnamese translation for this fic on wattpad and facebook by imhereforfood or e4rthb0und on Wattpad. Thank you so much for translating!

There's also incredible art by szeeyla and PikminPurplest on Twitter!

PLEASE check them out and follow them both they're amazing and I'm actually sobbing.

I can't say this enough but THANK YOU to you all so so very much, you're all so incredibly lovely

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“Chat, if I die on stream, do you think I can get a Guiness World Record?”

Phainon was nearing the end of his longest stream yet, a milestone he promised for his 10 million sub special. The streamer was sitting, head in his hands as his screen flashes ‘*You have died’,* again. His original goal was to stream until he beats *Dire Souls* in 12 hours, but 22 hours in and stuck on a mid-boss, he impulsively decided to rebrand into a 24-hour stream instead.

"You know, I do feel like I need some kind of repayment for this stream. I must've broken some kind of record. 'Most faith in humanity lost in 22 hours' has a nice ring to it, doesn't it?"

Chat, expectedly, pays him no mind

manohman : so, we beat f.reaver yet?

nightosphere : bro has been on for 22 hours and is STILL stuck on nikador :icant:

LowBloodSugar : pretty sure ive seen ppl actlly die on stream js saying

carbonatedtea : what is bro yapping about 😭😭😭

Kirarawr : fyi GoldenWeaver beat dire souls in 10h total lolololololol

KylXStars : so far hes died 23 times against nikador. were never beating this game.

gldnwvr’sscissors : @ Kirarawr well obviously aglaea is superior to this fool in every aspect

realunreal: mr streamer dont die you havent finished streaming yet TTTT

small_fries: @gldnwvr'sscissors have faith in the goat

Sup4Sup: dying on stream wld be good content tho LMAO

“My audience doesn’t even care if I die," he laments with a sigh, "What good is this parasocial relationship now?”

His audience replies with a flurry of shrugs, with donations to cheer him up few and far in between.

*[@AddICKted has donated **23,000** credits: “There, there Mr. streamer. I'll donate 1k for every death vs nikadaddy”]*

Phainon squints at the screen, "Your username may or may not get me banned, but thank you, AddICKted. I hope you know chat expects me to wring your wallet dry."

While he wasn’t exactly known for his gaming prowess, he’d like to believe that he wasn’t *that* bad at games either. Streaming started off as a side hobby, something fun to unwind and play with post-campus to de-stress. He began all the way back in college, using it as an excuse to be chatty to strangers outside of the Psych department. Four years later and with a level of fame he couldn’t ever have expected, Phainon is still (partly) streaming full-time.

“Chat I’ll just have you know that I was NOT dying this much at the beginning of the stream. Try doing this for over 20 hours! It’s a wonder I’m alive right now, truly,” he whines as he fails to parry Nikador’s lance once more. His character falls in a dramatic display as his screen flashes red. Seriously, why the hell does every attack do so much damage anyway?

KylXStars : well. thats 24 deaths.

realunreal : dudeee rip

Ivory_dreams : his eyebags…

*[@AddICKted has donated **1,000** credits: “my wallet is ready.”]*

Sup4Sup: 25th times the charm frfr

S2h1fx : has he really just been doing this for 20+ hours?

*RiceToCas ✔️ : Pretty much ^^*

thatonecatchling : should we be concerned?

“Castorice!” he says, scrolling through chat. Doing anything but continuing with the game. If he hits 30 deaths against Nikador he might actually just uninstall. “I’ll have you know I’ve beaten *11* bosses before this. 11!”

RiceToCas ✔️ : 23 hours now for 11 bosses. Seriously? There are 30 in-game.

Okay, sure. 11 out of 30 in over 20 hours for a game Aglaea only spent 10 hours on was, admittedly, slightly embarrassing. But it wasn't his fault that Aglaea was scarily good at all the things she did! It was an unfair comparison from the start. Surely most *normal* people struggled just as much as he did!

RiceToCas ✔️ : before you say anything. It took me 18h to 100%.

manohman : oh this is embarrassing

Thanatoes : queenstorice don't eat him up like that ToT

thatonecatchling : and casto isnt even a gaming streamer oh,,,

l1ngl1ng : just tuned in why is he half dead?

KylXStars : Please…at least beat nikador before the stream ends…

*[@StrawberEE has donated **30,000** credits: "Betting a million credits he doesn't beat Nikador today"]*

manohman : oh thats FOUL

LowBloodSugar : have some faith in our deliverer ajajajajajjaa

RiceToCas ✔️ : how do I bet as well?

*[@small_fries has donated **50,000** credits: "betting a million he does. imma be a rich man today."]*

"Legally," he starts, apprehensive, "I should advise against illegal betting. Because I'm pretty sure this is illegal." While certainly he did not major in law of any kind, the mixers he'd joined while on campus taught him a thing or two about gambling. "My lawyers would advise against this, but *personally* I-"

"Have you not finished yet?"

A gruff, deep voice sounds from off screen. Phainon stills immediately.

'*Oh shit,'* he thinks, '*my door was unlocked.'*

Now, Phainon has a system. It's one that ensures there are suprisingly few things that go wrong in his streams. In his four, nearing five years of streaming, he has only had technical issues twice. First, when the power in his building cut off because a downstairs neighbour was doing some wacko science experiment. And second, when he'd accidentally left his stove on, burning his mac and cheese (and almost burning his building down in the process, but that's besides the point).

Locked doors mean he's streaming, and unlocked doors means Mydei can enter anytime he needs something. It's a good system. Five years of cohabitation, four and a half years of friendship. They've been roommates since both of them were at Okhema's State University,

and have been close ever since. He had told Mydei, of course, that he was streaming today. What he had failed to tell him, however, was that his stream was extended.

Case in point: Phainon is (usually) a surprisingly thorough person.

“HKS, are you so useless that I must remind you to eat dinner?”

This is, obviously, not a good representation of that trait.

“Oh! My- um, wait, don’t come any closer! I’m still-”

small_fries : HELLO SIR???//

l1ngl1ng : WHO IS THISSSSSS

KylXStars : is that kremnoan?? Wtf????

RiceToCas ✔️ : cut the stream

RiceToCas ✔️ : NOW

Thanatoes : castorice ????

realunreal : omg whats going on

Phainon’s stream ends at 23 hours, 34 minutes.

Uninvited Guest: Mystery Man Spotted in Deliverer's 24-Hour Stream!

Published XX25 | By O. W. L. Bert

Beloved gaming and generalist streamer, Deliverer (real name: Phainon) was seen conversing with a yet-to-be named man at the tail end of his 10 million subscriber special.

Only half of the man's torso was visible, revealing an arm tattooed brightly with red, swirling figures. The man was well built and seemingly familiar with our favourite streamer's eating habits, inviting him to dinner as the stream quickly cut off.

Fans were quick to speculate on the relationship the two have, some speculating them to be no more than roommates, while other suggest there could be something beyond mere friendship!

Currently, a whopping 18 hours after the stream had ended, our usually energetic streamer is yet nowhere to be found! No activity has been spotted on his StarTube nor TikTok accounts. His Tweeter, as well, has been radio silent, which fans have expressed is a jarring change from the usually rapidfire announcements and engagement Deliverer (who will be referred to as D) is known for.

Fans are up in arms about discovering *who* this Mystery Man is, and *what* is going on with our beloved streamer!

First, all that we know of our Mystery Man (who will be referred to as M, moving forward):

1. M had slipped into a foreign language halfway while addressing D. The phrase used was 'HKS', which was quickly identified as being *Kremnoan*, a little known native language of an Amphorean tribe.
2. While many speculate M's heritage, many have dismissed him as a local, noting the rather outdated usage of 'HKS' to refer to a person.
3. The term itself was noted to translate as '*hyena'*. Yes, that's right, the animal.
4. 'HKS' itself was traditionally used by scholars and royalty to *belittle* warriors at the time. Scholars at the time believed hyena's to be the opposite of Kremnoan values, noting that...

...Read More

#Deliverer #TikTok #StarDom # StarTube #Streamers #MysteryMan

Comments:

user9883 *commented*:

Mayb its just me or is it kinda weird that there are ARTICLES written abt this dude? he clearly didnt mean to be on stream :/

> ***user8164****replied*:
>
> this is harmless. srsly, the guy probably doesnt even care.
>
> ***user692****replied*:
>
> the articles r SOOO tame like this is litrly nothing compared to what streamers go through on a daily basis
>
> > ***user9883****replied*:
> >
> > Ever thought that the way they treat streamers isnt ethical either?

user7778 *commented* **:**

lowk was so shocked to hear kremnoan of all things lol.

> ***user1293*** *replied*:
>
> OP cld u explain why?
>
> > ***user5566*** *replied*:

not op but kremnoan is p widely viewed as a dead language bcs not even ppl frm castrum kremnos speak it anymre

user7778 *replied*:

^^ exactly. some scholars / historians still learn it tho. kremnoan writing is surprisingly well documented.

Show 319 Replies

< < ***1*** *2 3 . . . 39 40* > >

#1_Phainon_Stan *@DailyDeliverer* - 14h ago

Can we?? Talk about?? Deliverer's?? Latest stream???

2.1K **10.7K** **11.3K**

StrawBEREE *@beriberi* - 13h ago

Ya'll i was THERE i saw that shit go down LIVE

1 **14** **18**

relrelrel *@MozaRella* - 11h ago

and THIS is why i sub 2 deliverer <3

1 **3**

BIGFRIES *@nahstillsmallfries* - 14h ago

Can we talk about the MYSTERY MAN?? IDEK WHAT LANGUAGE HE SPOKE IN BUT I WOULD HITTTTT

98 **698** **1.7K**

#1_Phainon_Stan *@DailyDeliverer* - 12h ago

He spoke in Kremnoan! It's the language of a tribe in Amphoreus. I saw an article about this morning, I think its still trending atm.

4 **75** **392**

Sister of Hyles *@pomeGRENADE* - 11h ago

kremnoan here. he had an accent so prolly not native, but he did use an ancient kremnos insult. which was neat.

5 **12**

2 Days Till Graduation *@HyacinthTears* - 13h ago

no this is so valid because WHY WAS HIS HAND SO BIG ???

17 **98** **504**

Eri *@helloandgoodbye* - 10h ago

idk what he was talking abt i was drooling tho like boy no one paying attention to your lunch 😭😭😭

3 **8** **19**

BIGFRIES *@nahstillsmallfries* - 8h ago

omfg im licking my screen actually tHOSE TATS

1 **6** **11**

Phainon is a great many things. He was a model student (according to everyone but Prof. Anaxa), he is a fine roommate (though Mydei would disagree) and he'd like to believe he is an upstanding citizen (and ignores the fact that Aglaea still helps him do his taxes, even now).

What he, apparently, is not so great at, is being a streamer.

The night of the incident, Phainon had so hurriedly turned off stream that he had no time to bid his chat goodbye, or actually end his milestone broadcast. Who could blame him, though? When his *roommate* had stumbled into his room in nothing but a tanktop and sweats, he knew that he had to protect his chastity. Just Mydei showing his arm on stream was bad enough, because it would be downright *unfair* if Mydei were to show off more of himself just in that one clip.

Phainon is very aware of how the internet works. He knows that at least a quarter of his fanbase is there for his looks and he's not ashamed to admit that he *does* play into the fanservice, but it's an entirely different thing when someone like Mydei were to be subjected to such a thing.

Mydei was probably the type to still get his news by newspaper. The man had no social media that he knows of, and he just does a confused grunt and head tilt whenever Phainon or Castorice reference anything that isn't history, literature or combat related. What unholy

things has the internet cooked up at the expense of his sweet, innocent, grandpa of a roommate? Just thinking about it made him shiver. Because while Phainon might be dull at times, he is, at least, more than familiar with Mydei's intrinsic...charms.

From the deep cut shirts he preferred to either the compressed t-shirts or sleeveless tanks Mydei wore, it increasingly felt like he had no decent clothing in his wardrobe. '*But even then,'* he thought, *'a well dressed Mydei would surely send half the internet into cardiac arrest.'*

He remembers the first time he saw Mydei dressed up. It was for some red carpet event Aglaea was invited to which she had, of course, declined to go. She had however sent Phainon and Mydei simply to use up the invites. And of all the things Mydei could or does agree to, Phainon will never understand *why* he had agreed to this.

Maybe it was to taunt him, or maybe this was some sick torture method he used because he knew that Phainon simply would not survive the image of Mydei, golden hair slicked back and muscle taut even under the layers of a sleek, black suit. '*By the gods,'* he wondered, at the time, '*why does his suit have to be fitted?'*

The gold and red buttons and patterning matched his red eyeliner, *eyeliner* that Aglaea had put on him. That dastardly woman.

Because Aglaea knew of the huge, embarrassing crush he had on the stupid, beautiful, disgustingly attractive man that was his roommate.

She must have orchestrated this as payback for something Phainon had done. He sighs, dragging a hand down his face. That night was beyond embarrassing.

Most of it, he spent tripping over himself at the mere *sight* of Mydei. He knows, at least, that some of it was justified, even without his own affection. Mydei was objectively beautiful, after all, and he's merely a mortal man, nursing attraction that he's kept hidden for over four years by now. He doesn't think he'd survive if he had to see that same thirst reflected in the internet.

He'll make sure to keep himself off Tweeter, just until this all blows over.

"Don't doze off," Mydei scolds, wacking him on the head with a spatula which he swiftly avoids, sticking his tongue out, "Go take a piss, wash your face. Do whatever. Just don't fall asleep yet. Your food's almost done."

After the stream, Mydei had dragged him to the dinner table and intimidated him into waiting by their counter until he finished reheating his dinner.

Phainon liked to believe that it was out of thoughtfulness that Mydei always made him his own portion, though part of him admits that it might just be because he's generally banned from kitchens. Still, he's grateful for the comforting view of Mydei's back towards him, humming softly as he tosses meat and veggies into his pan.

Mydei looks peaceful like this, he thinks as he yawns, stretching his back. The smell of Mydei's surprisingly delicious cooking wafting through their apartment.

In a moment, Mydei drops what must be a triple portion of beef stir-fry, noodles and steamed broccoli onto the table, unceremoniously shoving it towards him, not unlike one would treat a dog bowl. Phainon couldn't even complain, though. You never bite the hand that feeds you.

Well, not unless that hand was formed in a fist, pointed straight at him, as it so often was during their weekly boxing sessions. It was only then that he would not be opposed to biting.

Still, the food tasted heavenly. It was like he's never eaten before.

"By the gods, Mydei," Phainon says, "I think I just might be in love with you."

Mydei recoils in what must be disgust, and replies, "You're delirious. And disgusting. Swallow before you speak, have you not learned any manners?"

Phainon sighs, but swallows his food anyway. He's half asleep once food finally enters his system, and he almost passes out immediately on the dinner table. "My heartfelt praise met with insult to both my character and wellbeing. Truly, no one appreciates my talents."

"At least you know that much," he deadpans, "You're dead on your feet, though you've only been sitting playing video games. When did I start rooming with a child?"

"Well excuse you," he says, yawning, pointing a fork at him as a chunk of beef hangs on its end, "this *child* is also your only sparring partner at the gym. Pray tell, who else would box with a madman like you?"

Mydei sighs, "Sing praises of your physicality when you're not half dead, HKS. And eat your food, *properly*."

"Aha!" He exclaims, "So you're saying that I *am* your match at my best? Is that right?"

"What I'm saying is that you are far, far too self-satisfied," he shakes his head, in place of an answer, "you've been awake for nearly an entire day. Any more and you might truly keel over and die, and I do not wish to have to find another roommate." Mydei says as he flicks a dangerously strong finger towards his forehead. Phainon dodges with a grace that does not translate to his gameplay.

"Is this your way of saying I'm irreplaceable, Mydei?" Phainon goads, eyebrows inching even despite the exhaustion, "If so then I must admit, I'm quite flattered. To think you cared so much for me!"

Mydei mouth opens, instinctively to deny it, if only for the sake of being contradictory. But he pauses for a moment, then two, before sighing. "And if I say yes," he starts, "would you listen to me and rest, Phainon?"

Phainon stills immediately.

It's unfair, really, the power he has over him.

Mydei doesn't *imply* things, not in the way any others would. He does not ask, he makes demands. Not unlike a prince and not unlike a god reshaping the world to what he sees fit. That isn't how Phainon always views him, not all the time, but it certainly is a description he would often find apt.

Mydei doesn't admit things, either. Not that he does not apologize, or does not realize things, no (he is surprisingly sensitive to etiquette in that regard). It is just that he does not spell things out.

Most often, what he'll get is the faint twitch of an eyebrow and a sigh that means more than it might for others. Because Mydei expects him to keep up. To understand, somehow, the complexities of the walking enigma which is himself.

Yet sometimes, he does not make demands with the authority that seems almost natural to him. Sometimes, he speaks with a certain cadence. With a desperation, almost, that is so very vulnerable and human yet so much *like him*, that Phainon wonders how he'd ever mistake him as a god.

This, this is one of those times.

"I- Mydei-"

"You're running off fumes, Phainon," he says, with a subtle worry even Phainon rarely sees, "don't argue with me. Not on this."

And Phainon does not fight him, when he speaks this way. Because Mydei does not demand things he deems unimportant.

"Okay," he answers, settling back on his chair, "I'll rest, after this. I promise."

So he finishes his dinner and isn't immediately annoying for the sake of it, and washes the dishes afterwards.

He stumbles into his room and barely misses switching off the lights, groaning because he can't be bothered to get up again. He flops onto bed with an overwhelming tiredness he only now feels come all at once, and he passes out immediately, just like that.

(*If he were awake, for just a moment longer, he would catch his door creaking open. He would notice the light switching off and gentle hands, unexpectedly so, covering his frame with a blanket.*

And would notice the faint twitch of his lips, and would hear the whisper of 'hyena', fond as anything. A word now only meaningful to the both of them. He'd see fingers, twitching, itching to reach out and card through tangled yet soft white locks.

Alas, he is not awake. And so the man bids him good night in a foreign tongue and slips out, another promise tucked away in his chest.)

#GodGamer (THANK YOU FOR 10 MIL!!) ✓ *@PhainonOElysiaeee* - 1h ago

You have questions. I have answers (and a stream in 2 hours). We ride at dawn.

11.2K **32K** **103K**

GoldenWeaver - [Commissions Closed] ✓ *@ladyaglaea* - 30min ago

Stop the theatrics, it's 2pm on a Wednesday.

2.4K **19.7K** **34.9K**

Chapter End Notes

A/N: The brainworms are REAL

I've noticed there is a distinct lack of both socmed and general fluffy aus for this ship. Which, is valid, but also I need to cope with the impending doom of this ship, so!!

I'm planning for around four chapters but it might be longer! I do hope you find this somewhat entertaining though, it was so much fun to write~ Future chapters will also have this sort of split between IRL stuff and general socmed content, I hope it wasn't too weird to follow!

The next update will be sometime this week, but no promises. Thank you so very much for reading! <3

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"You're streaming again?" Mydei asks, raising an eyebrow.

After years of living together Mydei has, inadvertently, memorized Phainon's streaming schedule. He often streams in the evenings, a habit picked up from his time at university, and does about four streams a week.

The man almost always streams while Mydei is out, streaming all throughout the weekends while usually only streaming once during the weekdays as well. Oftentimes, he finishes just around the time that Mydei comes home, so the two can have dinner together.

'It's convenient!' Phainon had reasoned, back when the two had only just moved in together. Mydei thinks it was just a ploy to have someone else cook for him, because Phainon was an absolute *menace* in the kitchen, but he agreed anyway.

They were broke college students who simply wanted to save money on groceries and dishes. The routine made sense, at the time. Mydei would cook and Phainon cleaned up after, and they'd split the bill for groceries, every month. It was efficient.

But four (nearing five) years later, they've long outgrown the necessity of the routine. However, Mydei finds himself unwilling to part with it. The habit's grown on him. Much more than he'd like to admit.

"It's a short stream this time!" Phainon smiles, "Last stream was- uh, irregular in a way. I just have some things to clear up today, that's all!"

Mydei rolls his eyes. " *Why* you're streaming is none of my concern. I was only affirming that it will not go for as long as yesterday, will it?

Phainon chuckles awkwardly, he's pretty sure he's never doing a 24-hour stream again. "It'll be a while until I reattempt such a stream. Why?" he goads, clearing his throat, "Worried about me?"

"Nonsense," Mydei huffs, but he's smiling anyway, "I'll be off. Don't order takeout- I've made lunch in the fridge. Just microwave it. I don't want you near the stove."

Phainon cringes at the memory. "Hey, that was *one time!"*

"And in the *one time* I took a trip out of town, you quite nearly burnt our complex down, boiling boxed mac and cheese. I will not hear any protest." Mydei replies, glaring at him.

"Okay, okay," Phainon raises his hands in surrender, "whatever you say, your majesty. Now go on, your clients are waiting for you."

Mydei shakes his head and huffs what would've been a laugh on anyone else. "You have nerve to lecture me on punctuality, HKS," but he grabs his keys and heads to the door anyway.

"You better not run away today," he says, flashing a smirk before he goes. "I'll be seeing you tonight, Phainon."

Phainon gapes.

He doesn't even have a chance to respond before he's off, the door clicking shut behind him.

Silence.

Only the faint steps of Mydei's combat boots out the door echoes in the hall.

One step, two steps, and another, and another.

And then, truly silence.

Phainon crumples to the floor.

"*Fuck,"* he says, to no one in particular.

His face is burning and he's so giddy he's going to trip up over himself. "He can't just say my name like that,*"* he mutters into his arm.

Mydei is straightforward, impossibly so. Yet at the same time he never fails to say things that just *don't make sense.* How could he say that? How could he say it so easily?

It's like it's intentional, almost, but in no way can he picture Mydei talking like that on purpose.

'Does he know?' he thinks, rubbing a hand over his face, '*Is doing this to taunt me?'*

Four years together and sometimes, he still doesn't understand Mydei. The man is as straight-laced as he is an enigma. The way he commands respect yet never demands it of anyone. He's the most ruthless and yet caring person he's ever met. *Fuck*, he really is in love with him.

Dealing with the affection he's harbored for his roommate and best friend for *years* is a far more daunting task than he expected. It's gotten so bad that most interactions with him ends in either him blushing or making a fool of himself. More than usual, at least.

Because his feelings have never faded. Not since the day that they first met and not now, either. He's gotten no closer to neither confessing nor getting over him.

And he's not so foolish to expect anything to come out of this crush. What he wants is simply to maintain what they already have. This cozy, surprisingly domestic, life they've built together is beyond anything he could've imagined having with someone like Mydei. With someone who's far, far too good to him already.

The only thing he's learned from his years of yearning is that rooming with Mydei will always be very, very bad for his heart.

He stays on the floor for a little while longer to collect himself. Breathing in, and out.

Today’s going to be a long day.

"Chat for the last time, I do *not* have a boyfriend!"

The stream had started off fine. It had started off good, even.

Most of it was discussing the stream, harmless questions he was supposed to answer to end off his milestone. Like: " *why did you start streaming?"* And " *how are you so bad at games?"* And *"is your hair naturally that white or do you bleach it that often and that's why it looks so dry?"* Normal questions.

It was then that *someone* in chat had mentioned the *'Mysterious Man'* caught on stream last night. Like piranhas to blood, chat snagged onto it immediately.

Phainon huffed, "Come on, if I were dating anyone, which I'm *not*, I'm sure you all would have found their identity already. You all are terrifying."

thatonecatchling : well. true.

gutsyballad : yeah i bet u want one tho

emma! : the way he has to deny it LMAO WE KNOW WHAT YOU ARE

neetFREAK : stream?? on a wednesday??

*[@ DittoDitto has donated **10,000** credits: “couldn't join yesterday but congrats on 10 mil!!”]*

9xDje : yall this is so gay

Sup4Sup : this is NOT my streamer 😭

StrawberEE : oh yeah? then who was on stream yesterday?

"Okay, you know what? Yesterday? Yesterday doesn't exist," Phainon says, nodding thougtfully, "No stream happened yesterday. Nope, nothing comes to mind. You must be hallucinating."

The first step to manipulation: gaslighting yourself.

It was one of the few things he remembered from college, and one of the many things he applies in his day to day. As usual, he thanks Professor Anaxa for his (largely) positive impact in his life.

"No Mystery Man, no stream. Yep. Nothing happened yesterday. *This* is the ten mill special."

StrawberEE : he deadass rn

thatonecatchling : YOU WERE LIT TALKING ABT HIM?? 20 MINS AGO??

weonnnth : guys is he playing dumb or is he just stupid

bokebeany : both.

ivory_dreams : both.

thatonecatchling : definitely both.

raytori : can u js go back to gaming i wz invested yesterday

emma! : u were talking to him ON STREAM BRO

StrawberEE : literally caught in 4k

"Ooh '*raytori'* requested we go back to gaming, how about that?"

Step two: divert the topic.

"I think we've answered enough questions today," he chuckled shamelessly, "I'll just boot up *Dire Souls* , we're beating Nikador if it's the last thing we do."

Sup4Sup : what the hell, sure.

raytori : yoo lets gooo

StrawberEE : noo omg i need answers

un1t3 : U CANT JS LEAVE US HANGING LIKE THIS??

thatonecatchling : ngl we alr got so much incriminating footage of this man tho LMFAO @ StrawberEE

ivory_dreams : we're gonna be stuck here for the whole day, aren't we?

Phainon squints at the rapid-fire chat, smiling to himself at the successful diversion. "I watched a guide yesterday, I swear. Have some faith in me!"

Mildly suspicious but overwhelmingly fixated on teasing the streamer, chat voices its distrust.

Step three: keep up the lie.

The game boots up as Phainon cracks his knuckles, "Get ready, chat. We're not ending stream until Nikador dies today!" He says excitedly.

That was three hours ago.

bokebeany : guys…

bokebeany : how many deaths are we on…?

‘*It’ll be a short stream’* he said. ‘*We’re not ending until Nikador dies’* he said. Exactly 3 hours and 18 minutes later and he remains not a single bit closer to actually clearing the boss.

Phainon grips his hair as the screen taunts him, flashing red.

[@ AddICKted has donated 1,000 credits: “plz...no more...”]

“One more round chat I *swear* I’m close!”

KylXStars : @ bokebeany this is death no. 178

9xDje : how is this even possible…?

Sup4Sup : THIS IS A FUCKING MID BOSS

un1t3 : @ AddICKted your wallet is cooked. please stop.

emma! : he is NOT built for this omg

GoldenWeaver ✔️ : Don’t you have something else to attend to today?

emma! : byrOBGAFCM HUH

gldnwvr’sscissors : LADY AGLAEA????????

weonnnth : holy shit?

It was well known that many Amphorean content creators were familiar with each other offline.

Deliverer and Castorice, for example, were popular for their frequent meetups and IRL streams at various conventions. The Amphoreus region itself was decentralized, but its most populated region was Okhema, and so it was fair to assume that most content-creators lived in the holy city as well.

“Aglaea…?” Phainon questioned, “Is there something going on today?”

GoldenWeaver ✔️ : Phainon.

raytori : they know each other???

neetFREAK : MOTHER

StrawberEE : WHAT IS GOING ONNN

gutsyballad : oop he just died again

GoldenWeaver ✔️ : It's wednesday.

"It- it is indeed Wednesday," he agrees instinctively.

There's one thing he knows: when Aglaea talks to you, you agree. Even if she said the sky was green and the water yellow it's safer to assume that your own definitions of colour have been wrong your entire life. That's another thing he's learnt since his time in Okhema.

"Um, Aglaea," he asks, tentative, "were we supposed to meet today or…?".

GoldenWeaver ✔️ : Idiot.

"Rude? What did I-"

His phone pings. He freezes immediately.

Phainon usually keeps his phone off and muted during streams. Mainly because his gaming skills suffer even without the added distraction, but also to avoid leaking any information about himself accidentally. There are only two contacts he has unmuted when he streams. One is Aglaea, for obvious reasons, and the other-

GoldenWeaver ✔️ : Don't you have somewhere to go today?

He pauses for a moment. And then realizes.

Oh. It's Wednesday.

"Chat," he clears his throat, "I just remembered I have an…appointment, today. A doctor's appointment- yeah. So I'm ending this stream early. Next stream's this Friday and we'll be playing something that *isn't* this cursed game. So-"

Phainon's eyes widen as his phone pings again. In a moment he opens his phone, typing quickly. He glances at his webcam, chat, and the phone in his hands. His fingers fly across the screen with dexterity that's never present when he plays.

weonnnth : yall im worried

l1ngl1ng : lowk scared whats going on

realunreal : @ GoldenWeaver is he ok?

neetFREAK : that's twice this week…

StrawberEE : is he sick??

GoldenWeaver ✔️ : It's fine he's just stupid.

Finally, after a minute of typing, Phainon sighs as he puts his phone down, looking slightly out of breath and flushed. “Uh- sorry! I’m okay, thanks for the concern! I do have to go now, though. Haha- see you on Friday!” He slurs.

The last of the chat floods as they bid goodbye. Phainon slumps on his chair.

His phone pings again.

Mufasa *(Mydeimos.)*

You surely can’t expect me to read that mess of an apology.

Just come quickly.

You

MYDEI

IMV

SRY

IM

OMW

RN

Mufasa

Type properly.

You have five minutes.

There are a number of routines Phainon's created over the years. Ones he hold like tradition.

Habits define a person. Commitment defines a relationship.

For Phainon, it’s routine that defines trust. A lunchbox pre-made for him, the trash can wordlessly always emptied, the fridge always stocked with exactly what they need. Habit, routine, whatever it is; it’s because of the little things that you’re alive. They build your home and your day-to-day. They’re personal, almost sacred, in a way.

And so he likes to stick to his routines, in doing what is comfortable and what is needed in the way and cadence he has trained himself to do.

(*And when you allow someone else into these routines, that itself is love.)*

This, running down the stairs of his apartment, out of breath and in grey sweats and a hoodie and t-shirt he yoinked off a chair, this is also a routine.

Phainon streams once every weekday, but he rarely streams on Wednesday, and almost never on Wednesday evenings. Because every Wednesday, at six, Mydei finishes training his clients, and he works the closing shift that night. Every Wednesday, he spares a little over an hour to close up the gym, as Phainon makes his way there.

Because Wednesdays are when the gym is finally, truly empty, and they have the boxing ring all to themselves.

It's nothing too fancy, and Phainon himself doesn't often visit, but it was Mydei who initially suggested they box. It wasn't too far-fetched of a suggestion. The both of them had taken different forms of martial-arts in college, just as an extracurricular.

Mydei, specifically, had joined sports clubs all throughout his high school years as well. So Phainon *had* actually considered getting back into the sport.

When asked, Mydei had reasoned that Phainon needed the exercise because his *'weak gamer body will keel over if you don't start moving.*' Phainon had rejected, of course, because the thought of going to a gym with *Mydei* might actually send him into cardiac arrest, but the other was surprisingly insistent on him going.

He remembers the first time he stepped into the gym, around the first time Mydei took a PT job.

He didn't have any expectations- hell, he didn't even know what a personal trainer did. But nothing could've prepared him for the sheer *magnitude* of what he saw.

Because the thing is, most people can't even handle Mydei *normally* .

Back in University he was so popular among both the men and women that he was voted as hottest faculty member despite barely even participating in any events. The library's foot traffic increased by 61.57% (he'd know, because he wrote a research paper about it once for a project) since Mydei started working as assistant librarian.

Point is: Mydei is unequivocally *hot* .

Imagine then, the sight of him. Six foot four, sweaty, shirtless and leaning on the rails of a boxing ring, muscles taut and tattoos spanning over well-defined shoulders as he stretched. His golden hair shining under harsh, artificial light, making his red-tinted ends glow.

'*Shirtless,'* he thought, as he gaped, because he really couldn't think of anything else, not in the moment. '*Holy shit.'*

At the time, it felt like half the gym was staring at him, too. While the man in question was uncaringly giving advice to his client in the ring, who was nodding far too enthusiastically to only be thinking about *boxing* .

Phainon scowled. It was indecent for his (crush) *roommate* and *best friend* to be so blatantly ogled like this! While it wasn't uncommon for acquaintances- *strangers* even, to be rendered speechless by his mere presence, isn't seeing him *like this* just a bit too much?

(If he weren't fuming, he would've noticed the triumphant smirk Mydei had thrown him from across the room, and the subtle shake of his head as he dismissed his client).

That day, once the gym had been properly cleared out for the night, Phainon sat him down by the ring and tried very, very hard to speak seriously.

"Mydei," he started.

The other raised a brow.

"I'm going to hold you hand while I say this-"

"Please do not."

"But you need to wear a shirt. Please."

The look in Phainon's eyes was dead serious. Like the idea of Mydei being shirtless in a *gym* where over half the people were either shirtless or wearing minimal clothing was something to be worried about. The whole situation was so absurd that Mydei was at a loss on whether he wanted to laugh or cry.

He punches him instead.

"What the fu- I'm being serious!" Phainon whined, nursing his bruised cheek. The purple bloomed across his pale skin and Mydei immediately felt guilt bubble up in his throat.

"*Shit*- I thought you would've-" he sighed, running a hand through his hair, "it's my fault. Reflex, sorry," he mumbled as his eyebrows pinched.

"I'll…find something to treat it. Stay."

Phainon was about to tell him not to bother, but the other had already stood up to go find a first aid kit.

He watched as he looked around stumbling, almost, in a haste to find the supplies.

Mydei fretted silently, so unlike the rest of him. His care had always been through his actions. His worry in the form of hurried hands and quickened footsteps. He always tended to fret when it came to other people, and he always took it to heart, even if it didn't show.

But Phainon didn't want to be a source of worry. Not to Mydei.

"It's not even that bad," Phainon whispered once he returned. He said it quietly, as if saying it too loud would make it untrue, "it looks worse than it is, promise."

Mydei scowled, unbelieving. “We haven’t even boxed yet you’re already injured. And it’s my fault.” He said again, holding out an ice pack as he gently rubbed salve on the bruise, his hands grazing the others cheek.

“...does it hurt?” he mutters, tentative, eyes fixed on the blossoming purple and blue.

From here, he could barely see Mydei’s expression, shadowed by his hair, backlit by the lights. All he could feel was the faint tremor of his fingers, calluses barely touching the warmth of his skin.

Phainon gulped, heart leaping into his throat. “No,” he answered truthfully. “Not at all.”

It was a weird night.

While it was supposed to be their first boxing session, Mydei had for some reason refused to even entertain the idea of stepping into the ring after the punching stunt. Instead, Phainon was just told to sit and wait as he finished closing out the gym.

They had takeout that night, a rare occasion where Mydei didn’t feel like cooking. He even let Phainon pick the restaurant and offered to pay as well. Thinking back, that might’ve been the start of their *‘loser pays for dinner’* tradition. One that Phainon has overwhelmingly been disadvantaged by.

Because in around the 2 years since they’ve started, he's only won *three* fights against Mydei thus far (current tally: 99 to 3).

So now Phainon goes to the gym once a week to get beaten up for half an hour. And it's fun, for the most part, and surprisingly good stress relief (*and a good reason to spend time together)*.

That is, when he actually remembers to show up.

"Mydei!" Phainon huffs, a bit too eager, a bit too excited. "I’m sorry I’m late!" He says as he catches his breath, leaning on the gyms glass doors.

“Four minutes and twenty-eight seconds,” Mydei notes, not looking up from his phone. “You’re on time,” he smirks, "How commendable.”

Chuckling, Phainon takes the time to recollect himself. “You know me,” he says, breathless, “I don’t make promises I don’t keep. And I’ve got a good feeling tonight. It’s about time you treat me to dinner isn’t it?”

Mydei laughs now, amused and excited, his eyes glinting like a predators. “We’ll see about that. Come, don’t keep me waiting, *Phainon.*"

Stepping into the ring, he cracks his knuckles, “100 wins, counting tonight. Quite the milestone, isn’t it?”

“You haven’t won yet, Mydei!” Phainon slips into the ring as he takes his hoodie off, settling into a familiar stance.

And it doesn't take long before Mydei *lunges* .

Like with all things he does, Mydei fights with *intensity* . Every blow and every shift in his legs is intentional. Almost deadly. He fights, for lack of a better word, like a *beast*.

They trade blows and jabs and he feels his muscles strain from the exertion. He's sweating and his fists are bruised, and it's like the whole world has narrowed into this ring, into just the both of them. It's electric.

Phainon side-steps a jab straight to his jaw, retaliating with a hook that Mydei brushes off with a grunt. "And when did you become a thief? Stealing my shirt without permission?"

He smirks, caught. He hadn't even noticed. Throwing another punch, he taunts, "Distracted now, aren't we?" Phainon ducks as he aims an uppercut, straight to the underside of Mydei's jaw, which he blocks without even glancing.

"Hardly."

The fight goes on like that, equally matched, neither of them giving an inch. It's addicting, how they fall into a state where nothing else matters. Nothing but the next step, the next punch the other throws. It's by this point that every muscle in his body is *screaming* for a break, and yet he can't stop. Not when he's confronted with Mydei, the lines of his body carved with unadulterated might.

It drives him insane, how *different* this side of him is. Untethered and fiery, like a lion stalking his prey. Phainon feels a shiver run up his spine, excitement thrumming in his bones.

This is a side of him he very rarely shows to anyone else. Not to his clients, not to other gym-goers, and barely even when he's alone. *Just him,* Phainon thinks greedily, *just for me.*

Mydei steps forward, winding up for another punch which Phainon ducks, earlier than he has before, and sweeps his legs from underneath. Mydei falls with a grunt, his long legs causing Phainon to stumble as well.

He barely catches himself, inches away from the other's face. *But he's down,* he thinks, *I win.*

"Hah-" he pants, high from the euphoria of it all, from *winning.* "Ninety-nine to four. It's my win tonight."

Mydei looks dazed, blinking blearily. His mouth hangs open in measured yet erratic breaths, his eyebrows lax and eyes so *alive.* Every breath makes Phainon all the more aware of how sheer the other's black tank-top is. Slick with sweat, the droplets disappearing into the deep cut of his shirt, running down his collar and pecs. The red of his tattoos glow against the tan of his skin and all he can think is that red really is his colour.

It's so unfair, he thinks, *how good he looks like this.* His cheeks red and exhausted, and his usually fiery mane now even more disheveled. His braid, the one Phainon himself often weaves in the morning, starts to come undone from the exertion.

He reaches out instinctively to run his fingers through the strands. Mesmerized, as gold mixes with red.

Mydei's eyes flicker, satisfaction settling into the lines of his face. The hard of his muscles unwound not into submission, but simply an admission of defeat.

"Cocky," he mutters, mouth curling into a slow smirk, "but a win is a win. Congratulations."

He reaches a hand out, as if expecting Phainon to help him up, and it's only then that he snaps out of his trance, realizing the position he's in.

One of his legs is between Mydei's thighs, his arms on either side of his face. He feels the heat radiate off his skin. They're so close he can *smell* the honeyed soap Mydei always uses. The one Phainon recognizes by scent after buying it so often when it's his turn to do the groceries.

The inside of his mouth goes very, very dry.

"Ahem-!" he looks away, suddenly embarrassed, "I- let's go for dinner! Yeah!" He springs up, willing a smile on his face, "your treat?"

Mydei blinks, running his tongue over the white of his teeth.

"Yeah," he breathes, "whatever you want."

'*Whatever you want'* turns out to be dingy American fast food from a restaurant Mydei *refuses* to step into.

"Come on!" Phainon whines, "You said *anything!"*

Mydei's nose wrinkles in disgust, "This hardly counts as food, idiot. Could you not have picked anywhere proper?"

For some reason, Mydei hates fast food. His obsession with health and fitness is commendable, truly, and Phainon respects him all the more for it but come on? How could anyone *hate* fast food?

"It's cheap!" He reasons, "It opens till late and it's convenient! Now come on, don't be a sore loser." Phainon drags the other's hand into the relatively empty restaurant. Mydei's feet are planted firmly by the door.

"You act as though you do not already have enough money to buy out this franchise," Mydei groans, but he eventually gets dragged in anyway, body exhausted from a day's work.

Phainon smiles, satisfied, "There's nothing wrong being frugal, Mydei."

And truly, he does believe in his words. His parents always reminding him to spend wisely even while living in the big city. But generally, he just *likes* the novelty of fast food. There weren't any locations like this back in his hometown.

“You ought to be grateful for this kind of convenience, your majesty,” Phainon says, thanking the tired-looking waiter who brings their food over, “we certainly didn’t have this back in Aedes Elysiae.”

Mydei mutters something under his breath as he nods to the server as well. “Have you called them recently? It’s the start of the month, is it not?”

“Yeah,” Phainon nods as he digs into his burger, “I called mom yesterday. Dad told me to call again tomorrow though, Cyrene wasn’t home at the time.”

His parents own a ranch out in the countryside, their family having a longstanding history with textiles and garments and such. While Phainon wanted to move out into Okhema for university, his sister Cyrene had stayed to continue the business.

He hums, he really should visit soon.

Mydei huffs, “That’s good. Tell your parents I said hi.”

Phainon rolls his eyes, muttering '*I did that already. They ask about you more than me.'*

They settle into silence afterwards. The restaurant’s fairly empty, only the cashier standing behind the counter to accompany them. The warm, yellowish light flickers above as if struggling to stay awake. *It’s comfortable,* he thinks, *this is nice.*

“Is that really all you’re eating?” Phainon asks, pointing to the single chicken wrap Mydei had ordered.

It's comically small in comparison to Mydei's relatively large hands. The bulk of him curls up just to pick it up properly.

He sighs, “I do not trust the ‘food’ here. I’ll eat a proper meal at home.”

Phainon tuts as he wags his finger. "We can’t have that. Come on," he gestures, "let’s order something. Why don’t we split some ice cream to go?”

Mydei pauses at that, contemplating.

Bullseye, he smiles.

Despite Mydei’s generally low tolerance for unhealthy habits, he *does* have a soft spot for sweets.

It used to surprise him, just how often the other baked to fulfill his sweet tooth. Back in college Mydei had fans just because of the baked goods, candies or chocolates he brought to the lectures he was in. Hell, even Professor Anaxa liked his food.

“That is…not too bad a suggestion,” he relents, “but we are not purchasing any here. There’s a gelato shop down the road I’ve been meaning to try. We’ll walk.”

“Your wish is my command,” he bows with exaggerated flourish. Mydei rolls his eyes.

“You’re making a fool of yourself. Eat, and stop the theatrics.” Phainon chuckles as he settles back into his seat, quickly finishing his meal.

The two walk out not long after.

It’s a bit too cold a night for ice-cream, and they’re both a bit too underdressed for a night walk, but if they were uncomfortable, neither of them comment on it. They’re standing side to side, shoulder to shoulder, and if Mydei huddles closer, he reasons it’s just for the warmth.

It’s nights like this that he’s grateful for his habits. It’s times like this that he’s glad for routine. Because it’s only in the night, once both their days are over, that truly, they may exist with each other.

The street lights are bright in the holy city, making visibility high even late at night.

Yet if anyone were to have spotted their hands brushing close, he’d argue it was a trick of the light.

Daily Deliverer Clips @ *DeliveringDeliverer* **-** *3h ago*

Ya’ll. What the fuck was that stream man.

[A clip of Deliverer’s Q&A stream. His cheeks are dusted pink as chat badgers him about ‘Mystery Man’.

“React to the ‘Mystery Man’ edits?” he reads, “The fuck? What edits?”

The chat explodes in a fit of hysteria, much to the confusion of the streamer.

“Why is he trending? Why are there so many TikToks of him?” He says, gripping his hair but he's blushing, “He was there for like three seconds, dude! Three!”]

6.8K **22.2K** **43.9K**

> **Sobs4Snobs** *@redactedcineph1le - 3h ago*
>
> this isn’t even the worst clip yet. there’s a part right after this where he fucking ZOOMS INTO THE IMAGE OF MM’S ARM.
>
> **89** **1.9K** **11.3K**
>
> > **Tired. @** *iDIxa98* **-** *1h ago*
> >
> > You mean this one?
> >
> > *[A clip of Phainon sitting with both his legs up on the chair, knees tucked into his chest as he wheels his chair closer to the screen. His eyes are wide as he zooms into a pixelated image of Mystery Man’s arm. He mouths a silent ‘damn’.]*

31 **362** **3K**

rei *@HanrEi - 2h ago*

GROWN ASS MAN straight up BLUSHING at the mention of his roommate WE KNOW WHAT YOU ARE

21 **1.3K** **15.2K**

StrawBEREE *@beriberi - 45min* ago

I can't defend him anymore pls he's never beating the allegations

3 **90** **274**

ddandellion *@Cosmick - 30 min ago*

what allegations hes just GAY

2 **34**

Can I Dropout *@AssCrackofDawn - 15 min ago*

literally so embarassing to watch omfg

8 **26**

Avary's Going to Comic Con!! *@LowlyFan - 3h ago*

yall oomf made a compilation 😭😭😭

https://www.youtube.com/nd918Yvq...

9.4K **37.2K** **71.9K**

GoldenWeaver - [Commissions Closed] ✓ *@ladyaglaea - 2h* ago

@PhainonOElysiaeee

11.2K ***54.3K*** ***38.2K***

Daughter of Death 💐 HoloEN ✓ *@Castorice_CH - 2h ago*

@PhainonOElysiaeee

8.7K ***19.7K*** ***8.7K***

LOLA (Going insane) *@i_around_you - 45 min ago*

DONT CALL HIM OUT LIKE THAT

💬 **23** 🔁 **91** 🖤 **287**

tribios' hairclip *@snytetete - 30 min ago*

deliverer where r u ur getting cooked 😭

💬 **9** 🔁 **72** 🖤 **103**

---

5 minutes of deliverer being gay on stream ✨
4.7M Views | Posted XX March XX25 | 1.5M↟ Dislike↡

All clips belong to Deliverer from his latest Q&A stream! TBH I could've added more clips LOL. Also, I take no credit for...

...Show more

The video starts with a clip of Phainon, in his usual setup, wearing a red hoodie which doesn't seem to belong to him.

"'*What were you doing after the stream last night?*'" he reads, "I don't know dude, maybe I was doing your mo-"

The video freezes, cutting to a title screen, '*Deliverer being caught in 4k'* written in sparkly font.

"Someone asked, '*who is mystery man?*' Like. In general?" Phainon squints, "Who the hell *is* mystery man? Why are you guys treating him like some Slenderman?"

The chat replay zooms as an onslaught of comments and chatters spam a mix of exasperation and untethered degeneracy.

"'*It's the guy with nice arms?*'" Phainon reads. Out of the hundreds of chats, this was one of the few without unintelligible keyboard smash.

"Oh-" he freezes, as if recalling a particularly pleasant memory. "Well," smiling, his cheeks are noticably pink, "I guess his arms *are* pretty nice."

Phainon is gong down a TikTok rabbit hole of edits, all of the three seconds his roommate is on stream.

"This one- this one really captures his essence, honestly," he says to a video looping of the Mystery Man saying "*useless."*

"Believe it or not, chat, it's a lot less fun when he says it in real life." He adds solemnly, "I'd know. I live with the guy."

" Do his tattoos extend to further than his arm?' " Phainon reads.

"Hah-" he scoffs, "wouldn't you like to know?"

*[@fatebeuponye has donated **20,000** credits: "why u getting defensive like he ur boyfrnd or smth"]*

"Oh, thank you for the dono." He smiles, serenely, "Just for that I'll be nice enough not to ban you. Because I'm not getting defensive, it's just indecent to ask about such a thing! It's not *my tattoo,* I don't know why you're asking me! You should ask *him* about it if you care so muc-"

The video cuts to a muted, sped up version of Phainon's rant. The subtitles read, '*I wouldn't have sped this up. But this whole clip is, no joke, 8 minutes long.'*

"Chat, you know, I'm something of a feminist myself," Phainon says, nodding in agreement to himself.

The chat has no idea what's spurring this on, but the streamer continues anyway.

"Personally I think men belong in the kitchen. Except me, for many reasons." He says, "I can't cook. I've tried. I simply cannot."

gutsyballad : dw we remember the mac n cheese incident

Sup4Sup : what even was the question?

3PeasInAPod : we know

dFEEgree : where is he going w this

KylXStars : @Sup4Sup there was no question someone just called him a loser

*[@UnknowaBility has donated **30,000** credits: "he just like me fr"]*

"Which is why then my *roommate*- because he's just a *roommate*," Phainon pauses, "not that he *could* be anything else, because we're just friends."

DeathRealm : BOY

palmsoffury : this is so embarassing actually

WailWhale : lit no one believes ur straight pls

"Out of concern because he's a good FRIEND," he emphasizes, "offers to cook me dinner. Because I can't cook. And because he's a good guy. That's all!"

He exclaims, putting his hands up, "There's a heterosexual explanation to everything."

*[@GeniusSociety77 has donated **1,000,000** credits: "brother the yearning in your eyes is present only in gay men and europeans. ur not fooling anyone."]*

Due to it being such a large donation, a text to speech bot reads it out loud. Phainon stills immediately.

Silence.

Not even the chat moves.

He opens his mouth once, then closes it, seemingly out of words.

"Mods, perma-ban them."

3PeasInAPod : RIP

figgot : RIP

KylXStars : RIP

StrawberEE : RIP

*[@GeniusSociety78 has donated **1,000,000** credits: "he tried to silence me but IM RIGHT."]*

The video ends abruptly.

Comments:

HandsOfGold✓ 📌 [*Pinned by Creator]* :

Thank you for the video. Truly insightful.

Crystalene :

LADY AGLAEA WHY R U EVERYWHERE BUT COMIC CON

HandsOfGold✓ :

Rest assured, I will be present.

Deliverer✓ :

AGLAEA WHAT THE FUCK

TriTriTribbie :

good video we're sure snowy will agree! ヽ(｡>ᴗ<｡)ノ♡

Deliverer✓ :

TRIBBIE??? GET OFF YOUR SISTERS PHONE??

TriTriTribbie :

I'm sorry...was I wrong? (╯ ‵ □ ′)

Deliverer✓

No I'm sorry I'm in the wrong forgive me.

GenArbit :

My favourite streamer is a loser what does this say abt me 😭😭😭

lannotLan :

nah no one ever comes close to deliverer levels of boyfailure

sipsipstolen :

dw he's half of the internet's favourite streamer

Castorice_Official✓ :

Absolute cinema.

Chapter End Notes

A/N: I wrote this like a man possessed.

Ya'll I lied abt the sosmed like 3/4 of this chapter was IRL yearning sorry LOL. I THINK next chapter should be more social media stuff tho!!

This chapter single handedly made me rework my tags because there is no way we're getting through this fic in 4 chapter lmfao. Just this chapt alone was so long I was contemplating how the hell I got to a 4 chapt estimate. 6 is where we're at rn but we mightt have more.

REAL TALK THO pls do not get used to this speed of updates!! The next one will take some more time but it should be up next week? Maybe!

I hope you liked this chapter and stick around for the next one! Good luck to everyone pulling for our prince, I love you all!! <3

Chapter 3

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Explore:

1. Streaming · Trending

Deliverer

Trending with # Castorice , # ComicCon

2. Entertainment · Trending

ComicCon

Trending with # OkhemaNationalMuseum

3. **Streaming** · Trending

Tribios

Trending with # GoldenWeaver and # HolyLady

IRL STREAM THIS WEEK ✓ @ *PhainonOElysiaeee - 6h ago*

Very very excited to announce that I will be streaming # ComicCon with the lovely *@Castorice_CH !!* Be sure to catch us on her channel this weekend :))

23.4K 47.2K 154K

Daughter of Death 💐 HoloEN ✓ *@ Castorice_CH - 6h ago*

Okhema's biggest clout chaser mooching off of MY channel.

9.7K 32.3K 62.1K

IRL STREAM THIS WEEK ✓ @ *PhainonOElysiaeee - 5h ago*

I'm paying for your tickets ????

3.2K 10.1K 20.9K

Attending Comic Con <3 ✓ *@Holy_Maiden - 3h ago*

See you two there~!

4.1K **27.4K** **48.3K**

eye4aneye *@horrorof_mind - 2h ago*

LADY TRIBOS AJJAJAEFKNJEGAVOCBA

773 **2.3K** **7.2K**

IRL STREAM THIS WEEK ✓ *@ PhainonOElysiaeee - 1h ago*

CAN'T WAIT!!

921 **3.8K** **9.4K**

threadbare *@ UnspoolingYarn - 5h ago*

Ya'll don't understand this is my fav streamer duo EVER <3 looking forward to an incredible stream # Deliverer # Castorice

6.4K **10.5K** **31K**

Mina <3 *@atlas_l0ve - 4h ago*

literally i still think about their aniexpo collab pls 😭

1.8K **3.7K** **9.4K**

mt? *@physicsHIT - 4h ago*

that one clip of him STEALING her fucking purple dog will never not be iconic

325 **1.3K** **6.2K**

Kale *@butnotthevegetable - 3h ago*

nah but this duo PLUS golden weaver? unmatched

2.3K **5.1K** **10.3K**

dropping out?? *@AssCrackofDawn - 2h ago*

The way everyone still uses that gif of her picking both of them up by the collar

670 **988** **4.7K**

ladyaglaea'sneedle *@wakey_wakey - 2h ago*

did someone say MOTHER??

422 **701** **2.8K**

V.19 - moving! *@android18 - 2h ago*

I hope they meet at the con!

105 **239** **1.2K**

"And everything's going well? Are you sleeping well? Eating well? Ah, wait I shouldn't have asked, you can't cook-"

Phainon's moved out to Okhema almost 6 years ago, yet his parents still constantly fret over him. It's touching, really, and they only mean well. That's why every month, without fail, Phainon calls back home for a long chat to catch up.

"I'm doing great, pa, don't worry," he chuckled.

His parents have gotten good at video calling, over the years. His dad's sitting now in the living room of his old home, squinting at the camera. He's just gotten a new phone. The camera's better quality, so he can make out the new pictures on the wall now. From the multitude of family photos hanging on the wall, just barely out of view, he recognizes a only a few of them.

Vaguely, he recognizes a photo of Cyrene and him horseback for the first time when they were kids. His mom had snapped the picture, his dad holding the reins of their horse, firmly with a smile. Honestly though, he never liked the farm nor the ranch, really. This picture in particular, though is what he has set as his laptop's home screen, in rotation with a whole folder worth of old family pictures.

The pictures are nostalgic. He's seen them hundreds of times on his laptop. But from here, he can also tell that some of them, at least, are new.

The birthday party of a younger cousin he hasn't seen in years and Cyrene's hair, dyed pinker than he ever remembered. They're framed and hung next to familiar pictures and figures. Unrecognizable ones mix with the old. He tries to ignore the pang in his chest at what it implies. It's been so long since he's visited.

"Hah!" His dad huffs, snapping him out of his reverie. "Tell me that to me when the fire department doesn't call to tell me my son is burning an apartment down!"

Phainon slumps in his seat, nostalgia suddenly forgotten. No one's ever letting him live this down.

“Do you know how hard it was to explain why my 25 year old son wouldn’t intentionally commit *arson*?” He rambles, “People go to jail for less!”

Phainon was about to argue, because the extent of the damages really wasn’t *that* bad. It’s true that he did burn the mac and cheese. And he did burn part of his carpet. And that *maybe* the fire was visible out through his window and that he was *slightly* panicking. But he had the fire under control! (Eventually).

But, he reminds himself, Mydei *did* indefinitely banned from the kitchen now because of The Incident. And he *did* have to pay a couple thousand credits worth of damages. Though the worst part was, of course, that he couldn't have any of Mydei's cooking for weeks as the kitchen was being renovatted.

So on second thought, maybe the incident *was* slightly severe.

“...Mydei keeps a fire extinguisher in the kitchen now,” he relents, finally, “he refilled it just last week.”

He remembers the incident well. The fire department was able to put out the rest of the fire but it left most of the stove downright unusable for weeks. Mydei had cut his trip short to get back to the city and he was, understandably, pissed at the state of his beloved kitchen. The blackened carpet and stench of smoke that just did not go away but also-

“Why the fuck is there *tar* in my pot?”

Phainon chuckled guilty, “...would you believe that’s mac and cheese?”

Mydei stared, unimpressed.

He wasn’t supposed to be home for at least three more days. As Phainon’s first emergency contact, he was the one first urged to come back to Okhema once the incident happened. He’d just gotten back from Castrum Kremnos, his home town, apparently to collect some of the things his mother had left behind when they first moved to Okhema.

Phainon doesn’t know too much about his roommate’s family history, but due to college drinking competitions that got out of hand and his own blessedly high alcohol tolerance, he’s learned bits and pieces over the years.

He knows that Mydei’s father was…deplorable, to say the least. A man who did not deserve a wife and one who shouldn’t have ever had a son. And he knew that his mother, Gorgo, had divorced him and brought Mydei out of Castrum Kremnos and into Okhema when he was young. Mydei doesn’t really talk about it, but he knows that his homeland is a touchy subject.

In this regard, he can somewhat relate.

Phainon himself had first moved out to enter university in order to escape his village and the overwhelming closeness of it all. It's not like he felt he was destined for something greater or anything cheesy like that, but he simply felt *wrong* out in the grasslands. It's why he started streaming in the first place. He'd wanted an escape, of some kind. Someone to connect with, a

purpose outside of himself. The internet, streams, whatever it was- that was that outlet for him.

Aedes Elysiae and everything it was and is couldn't be described as a chain or anything holding him back. It just was and *is* a part of him. One that he neither wants to embrace nor reject.

(*He wonders, then, perplexed by it all. When he is neither Okheman nor Aedes Elysian, what is he now?)*

A cough brings him back to his senses.

“Lil’ bro, you’re zoning out again~”

Ah, he forgot that he was on call.

Phainon blinked twice, a dazed expression on his face. Cyrene’s melodious laughter floated through the screen. She’s leaning on her hand, where his dad was sitting. She seems to have swapped with him while he wasn’t paying attention.

“What’s got you so distracted, hm? Your boyfriend?”

“What? No! Mydei’s not my-” he paused, suddenly. “Wait. Is pa-”

“Ah, don’t worry,” she chuckled, “pa’s not in the room anymore.”

Phainon lets out a sigh of relief. “No, I haven’t confessed yet. And I’m not,” he caught himself, “I’m not confessing. Not planning to.” The admission stung more than he’d like to admit. It wasn’t that he didn’t want to confess. He wanted to, so desperately he wanted to brave himself and spill his heart out.

But he hasn’t. And Mydei deserves better than someone who couldn’t face their own feelings.

Cyrene hummed thoughtfully, idly playing with her faded pink hair. “But you were thinking of him, yes?” She smiled.

Phainon decidedly chose not to answer that question, shifting his focus to the white roots on the top of her head. The roots were growing back, he noticed, she should dye it again soon.

Despite his best efforts, a total of two people have noticed his long standing crush. One of them, of course, being his own beloved sister. Even when not physically here, Cyrene is a force to be reckoned with when it comes to sniffing out secrets. For some reason, his sister has eyes and ears everywhere, even in Okhema.

“You’re still worried about him not liking you back?” She questioned.

That’s not it, he thought. His hesitancy couldn’t be summed up that easily.

He’s been in love with him for *years* . There’s been so, so many moments when he’s wanted to confess. But he can’t bring himself to.

Because the worst case scenario isn't even Mydei rejecting him; that much is a given. No, the worst thing that could happen would be him packing his bags and leaving their apartment. It would be Mydei cutting contact and never talking to him again. It would be not having someone to box with on Wednesdays and coming home to eat frozen, instant meals once again.

It would be Phainon, losing one of the few people he's come to truly build a life with, one of the few people he can truly say he *loves* .

It's a risk he cannot take, not when so much is on the line.

Cyrene huffed, almost sensing his despair. "I was teasing! Don't push yourself, Phai. Your pouting is making *me* feel bad."

He cringed, "Sorry." He really should get better at controlling his emotions. It's starting to become a problem.

His sister hummed, "Well it's just too bad. I was hoping you'd bring him over once you confessed. Mom's been looking forward to meeting the man who's helping keep her son alive."

"I'm perfectly self-sufficient, thank you very much!"

She snorted, yet somehow remained graceful doing so, "Sure, I'd love to see you try cooking when you come back. The sheep miss you too, you know."

His heart panged at the reminder but he smiled anyway, "They only miss their favourite live target." He snarked. Cyrene's laugh eased some of the homesickness, even when reminiscing about the deadly accuracy his parents sheep have.

"The sheep are tiny, Phai. I can't believe you can't dodge them."

"They're relentless! They miss over half the time, anyway!"

"Ah, but you know, you really do need better spatial awareness," she smiled, amused.

Phainon's been described as many things over the years, but never had he been called a *klutz*.

He laughed, simply. "Now where is this coming from? My instincts are perfectly fine."

Sure the sheep love to ram into his shins, and ever cat and goose he meets is hell-bent on destroying his ankles, but he thinks that's more the universe playing tricks on him than it is a lack of *awareness* of all things.

Cyrene simply chuckled to herself, quietly gesturing behind him.

Phainon tilts his head, not understanding, but turns around, slowly facing behind him-

"Boo."

And he promptly falls off the couch.

On the phone, Cyrene is having the time of her life. “Oh, oh my *stars-”* she wheezed, swiping the phone to take at least a million screenshots, “I’m never letting you live this down. De, that was incredible! Nice teamwork!”

Mydei smiled, self-satisfied, as he waved to the screen.

Phainon pretends the blush on his cheeks is purely from being flustered, and *not* because he couldn’t handle the sight of the other’s face so close to him. “It wasn’t that funny-” he grumbled, “Cyrene stop- stop *laughing-”*

Cyrene, of course, ignored the threats from the man who fell flat on his ass on the floor. Okay, his blush was *definitely* from the embarrassment now.

Her laughter doubled when Mydei offered his hand, only to pull back the moment Phainon reached out to him. “It was kind of funny,” he interjected, laughing as Phainon fell face first to the carpet.

“*Not! Helping!”*

Despite never actually meeting, Mydei had taken a liking to Cyrene. The two seemed to get along best when working together to make fun of him from the few times he pops up on calls. He should’ve expected this, really, Cyrene’s wit becomes downright deadly when matched with Mydei’s dry humor. Individually, they were terrors. Together, they were downright *menaces.*

(He tries, unsuccessfully, not to think about why the thought of them getting along makes his stomach flip.)

“De,” Cyrene pants out, noticeably tired after laughing so much, “I think you just broke my brother.”

“I see,” he hummed, “all his wit must’ve fallen out his ass.”

Phainon groans as Cyrene gives the other a fistbump through the screen. One that Mydei reciprocates almost almost gleefully.

Yeah, he’s pretty sure these two should never meet.

Mydei leaves for the day not long after, and Cyrene ends the call as well.

Once he bids his goodbyes to the both of them, he hears a knock on the door. Two knocks, and a distinguished final one. He already knows who it is.

“Good morning, Phainon,” Aglaea greets.

“So *this* was when we were supposed to meet,” he says almost dazedly.

She's standing on his front door wearing a smart business-casual burgundy coat, and is carrying a full-looking bag. Aglaea chuckles, "I was waiting for your roommate to leave, you know. I just happened to be in the area."

"Huh? How did you even know he's left?"

The other points to her phone, raising her eyebrow. "Cyrene told me, of course."

Algaea's been a long time friend to his family. As she works with textiles, she's scoured all of Amphoreus for garments and clothes alike, and is a faithful customer to the fabrics his family makes as well. And thus, since Phainon's moved into Okhema, Aglaea's been Emergency Contact No.2 in case anything were to go wrong. She's helped him settle and build a new life here.

While he's grateful, truly, for all she's done for him-

"Cyrene's also told me that my matchmaking schemes remain unsuccessful. Why, pray tell, have you not confessed?"

She's also the only other person who knows of his crush.

Phainon flops face down onto the couch next to her. Aglaea scoots slightly further away from him. "I want to! I swear!" He groans, muffled by the couch.

Aglaea is…enthusiastic about romantic affairs. Thus far she's been the one to orchestrate two dinner 'dates', that nightmare of a red carpet event, an entire duo-only trip to the Luofu and far too many 'coincidental' meetups to count. *Yet somehow* , she muses, *the two still haven't put a label on their far-beyond-friendship relationship.*

"Phainon, please do not be an idiot. Mydeimos treats you far better than a friend."

He raises his head, muttering, "He's just nice like that."

The words 'Mydeimos' and 'nice' don't really compute in most people's heads. But Aglaea, after sadly having to deal with them for far too long already, simply sighs. "It seems your mind's still impossibly made up. No matter," she gets up, dusting herself off, "I have other things to attend to today."

"Come," she gestures, beckoning Phainon to get up as well, "we're paying your roommate a visit."

It turns out Aglaea had a fitting to get to today, one in preparation of Tribios' appearance for the upcoming Comic Con. With the both of them busy and occupied for the day, that leaves Tribios' triplet sisters unattended.

And thus, there is only one alternative in times such as this:

"Snowy! When can we arrive to see De?"

Phainon simply chuckles from where he's sitting in the passenger's seat. "We're arriving at the library soon, don't worry."

Tribbie smiles, satisfied, as she whispers to her sister beside her, "Did you hear that, Trianne? We're going to the library~!"

The other girl huffs, "I'd rather go to De's house! I want his honeycakes!" She crosses her arms. From off to the side, Trinnon simply looks out the car window, daydreaming.

It's not uncommon for Phainon to watch the triplets for the day. Though oftentimes, he always has Mydei to aid him. The triplets are good kids, really, but even he can tell that they prefer his roommate over him. The man has inexplicable charm with kids of all kinds. Another aspect that is *unfairly* attractive on him.

"Now, now, Mydei's working today," Aglaea chides from the driver's seat, "he must be busy, so be sure not to bother him too much. Bother him, instead." She says, gesturing to the seat beside her.

Phainon pointedly ignores the slightly disappointed look the triplets have on them for the rest of the drive.

They arrive not long later, at Okhema's District Library. It's a big building, surprisingly, and grand for a library. It's one that holds fond memories of late night study sessions and being dragged to accompany Mydei on the Weekends. He's had a lot of good times with the building as a student. And now, it's where Mydei works part-time as well. Time flies.

"It's De's second house!" Tribbie said, pointing excitedly at the building.

"It's just a library," Trianne muttered. Tribbie tugged on her sister's hand as she sluggishly trailed behind her, Phainon quickly following suit, taking both their hands in his.

Even if not for babysitting duties or studying, the library remains one of Phainon's favourite places in all of Okhema. Well, mainly on Mondays and Thursdays, because those are the days that Mydei's working as assistant librarian.

He's complained before about how truly limited his roommate's wardrobe is, but being honest Mydei wearing just about anything sends him into cardiac arrest. When he's out and in places of importance, Mydei often dons a black button up and slacks. Casual, form-fitting and proper. Dangerous for his heart, yes, but not quite deadly yet.

No, what's *truly* fatal are his *glasses* . His dark, maroon framed, rectangular reading glasses.

They perch just above the high of his nose and frame his molten gold eyes in red so dark you'd swear it was black in the library lighting. The dark colour somehow makes his eyes even sharper, golden flecks reflecting in each iris. Phainon believes that eyes must truly be the window soul, because Mydei's are so deep and all encompassing that there simply couldn't be any other explanation as to why they are so profound. His dissenting eyes feel like they pierce anything: with might, yes, but also with unfettered wisdom and tenacity.

Something else he's noticed is that Mydei is often so engrossed in his reading- eyes enraptured in history, fiction and philosophy or whatever other topic piques his fancy, that he usually doesn't realize the glasses slipping off his face. Phainon's watched one too many times as the frames slowly glide down the slope of his nose, unwittingly lowering his eyelids to match the low hang of his glasses. Until finally*, tantalizingly* , he pushes them up again with practiced grace.

Like this, amongst old books and low lighting and the scent of age and history that accompanies each and every shelf, he exudes the kind of quiet elegance that should almost be impossible for such a large, often standoffish man. Phainon's lucky Mydei had only gotten them after they'd both graduated from college. He wouldn't have been able to pass most of his exams with a distraction like *that* .

A sigh, "And here I'd heard you weren't in love with him."

Phainon's head snaps to Aglaea, a forlorn expression on her face. Suddenly, he realizes that he'd let go of both Tribbie and Trianne's hands.

"Where is-"

"Shh," Aglaea signals, pointer finger to her lips as she points to the children's corner.

All of Phainon's natural teasing instinct vanishes at the soft expression Mydei has on. He's sitting on the floor with the triplets, Trinnon drowsy in his left arm as he softly reads a book in his right. The other two sisters watch, entrapured. Tribbie softly tries to match the braid on the right side of his head as he reads to them.

Like this, his voice carries a quieter tone. Not like a prince and not like a God, but more-

"Fatherly, isn't he?" Aglaea prods.

He gulps, steadying himself. "Yeah," he breathes, shakily. He feels himself nod. Phainon doesn't trust himself to say anything else. He simply drinks in the sight.

Mydei's eyes no longer look molten- searing hot, with intensity burning everything he so much as gazes upon. No, the gold's mellowed now. Cooled into the shimmer of an heirloom handed down through generations, like the warmth of the first dredges of dawn: warming the wind, heart and the home.

The softness in his face rounds off all the hard edges; makes his tattoos curl and dance on his skin. The sharp lines of his palms almost protective as they cradle the girl in his arms. His hair exceedingly fluffy, spilling out of Tribbie's little hands. Even his fingers, calloused and brutish, thumbed mindlessly by Trianne, who slowly traces the red that crawls up to his forearms.

This looks right on him, he thinks. Family, warmth, *fatherhood* - or however else you would phrase it. He truly would debate of Mydei's virtue to anyone who dares challenge it. A man so inexplicably *kind* yet so easily misunderstood. The most gentle man he's ever known; the

most fearsome one he's ever met. An enigma, through and through, yet so rewarding to understand.

Beside him, Aglaea huffs at the smitten expression on his face.

Gently patting his shoulder, she makes way for the exit. Her job here is done, for now.

Phainon doesn't often take pictures.

Mainly because he doesn't really have a use for pictures.

Unlike most other streamers he doesn't usually update his Astrogram, he likes to keep his private life *private,* but also because there really isn't much he'd want to post. Most of his life and outings are done either with other streamers (who are much better at taking pictures anyway) or with Mydei himself, who is even *more* of a private person than he is. Besides, he's always had the philosophy to live in the moment.

Sometimes, however, life plops an opportunity into his lap so perfect that he cannot help *but* snap a picture.

In this case, the absolute *sight* of the cat in Mydei's lap is making him have a heart attack.

After Mydei's shift, the triplets had requested to visit a cat cafe nearby. Mydei, despite disliking eating out and his general disinterest to gimmick cafes, had agreed immediately. He was sitting on the floor in a corner, crowded by kittens and adult cats alike, while Phainon was (unsuccessfully) trying to get their attention from the middle of the room.

Sensing his plight, Mydei had scooped up one of the older cats next to him, walking over to sit right next to where Phainon was on the floor. He snorted as the cat, docile as it was in his lap, *hissed* the moment Phainon brought his hand to its nose. Traitor.

"It seems not even the cats like you," he chuckled.

"Now that's just plain rude."

Phainon was sulking, obviously, a pout on his lips as he tried once again to pet the feline. Only to be met with a huff, and the cat burying itself into Mydei's abdomen. *Rude ass cat.* He says as much.

"He's just like you, then," Mydei says, lifting it up to Phainon's eye level. "White fur, big dumb blue eyes and an insufferable attitude."

Phainon narrowed his eyes. The cat followed suit.

"I don't see the resemblance, nope," he shook his head. There is no way he's recognizing a *cat* as his Doppelganger.

"Really now?" Mydei said, examining the cat who preened under the attention, "I think it looks quite cute."

He proceeds to boop the cat's nose, smiling to himself as it nuzzles into his hand. Phainon's brain promptly short circuits.

"I'm taking a picture," he urges, whipping his phone out

"What. now?" Mydei asks, confused. His hands are full of cat and his clothes are full of white fur, yet somehow, this feels like the perfect time to document this. scene A moment kept in time. If he wants to preserve anything, he'd like to preserve this.

"Please?" He pleads, "I won't even include your face, promise!"

Mydei sighs, turning his face away. "Make it quick."

With haste, he snaps the picture.

Phainon isn't much of an artist, let alone much of a photographer. But he must admit: the photo turned out exceedingly well. Even backlit, the faint sunset still highlights Mydeis own striking features- the high of his cheekbones and the harsh slope of his nose not dampened, no, but almost blurry in the light. Like a portrait or a painting. He feels timeless, not unlike art and not unlike a masterpiece, well preserved yet still proudly showing its history. His tanned hands even warmer, contrasting the shock of white and blue of the cat in his arms.

Not to mention the downright *adorably* awkward expression he has on, evidently avoidant of cameras and group photos. God, he loves this man. He could wax poetic all day.

But what he says instead is this:

"Dude, you *totally* look constipated."

Mydei does not sputter, he's far too dignified for that, but he does make out an affronted half-grumble. "Delete that image. Now." He reaches for the phone but can't fully extend his arms with the cat settling on his lap.

Truthfully, he would rather die than do that.

"Hell no!" He says instead, "I don't have any bad pictures of you!"

The growl he lets out would be attractive in every other context, but sadly Phainon is too preoccupied being chased by a six foot Kremnoan. He's thankful the cat cafe is largely empty, both for his and Mydei's dignity, though he does catch the teenage cashier by the counter looking bewildered and slightly amused. He'll make sure to tip after this.

"HKS! Quit running like a coward!"

"I'm running like I value my *life!"*

Off to the side, the triplets are huddling together, Trinnon slipping on the milkshake they'd split for three while Trianne is gently petting the sleeping kitten in her lap. Tribbie mumbles as she attempts to keep track of her babysitter's chase.

“Two laps…no, is it three already?” She counted.

“Mm, I think they’re at four now, Tribbie,” Trinnon muttered. While Mydei was mindful enough to slow down near the cats, Phainon was running so fast that the cats steered clear away from him anyway. “Do you think Agy would get mad if she knew about this?”

“At Snowy, maybe,” Trianne interjected, “he’s really kind of stupid.”

“Who’s kind of stupid?!” Phainon exclaimed as he was tackled to the ground by the other. It turns out Mydei had won out in the end. Trapped, Mydei flicked his forehead as he scowled.

“You are. Idiot.” He bit out. “You better tip the waiters for having to clean up. There’s cat fur everywhere.”

Phainon grumbled as a cat stepped over him, its tail swishing onto his face. “I was gonna do that anyway!”

The other rolled his eyes, kneeling next to the triplets. It really has gotten quite late.

“Sorry you had to see that, kids.” He whispered, voice soft as he ruffled their hair and Trinnon gestured to be picked up. “Oi, did Aglaea say to keep them for the night?”

“Huh? Oh,” Phainon whipped out his phone, checking his notifications. Sure enough, Aglaea had sent him one mid-chase. “Yeah, she just told me the fitting’s gonna take a while longer. We’ll keep them for the night.”

Mydei nodded, “Call a taxi. I don’t want them to have to walk the way back.”

After an excruciatingly awkward car ride, they’d finally gotten back to their apartment.

(*“You two are so young to be fathers to such beautiful girls,” the driver rambled. “Who’s the mother? Is it you, Red Hair?”*

Phainon choked on his spit. “Ah- um-” he glanced at Mydei for support, who decided watching the street lights was more productive than whatever this conversation was. “They’re not our kids,” he finally says, “they’re my friend’s little sisters. I- we’re babysitting.”

Mydei huffed. “And we’re not married, either.”

“Yeah!" He added hurriedly, "That too!”

The driver hummed. He seemed a bit too old to be a taxi driver, brown hair with a shock of white in front. He couldn’t really see his face, but his eyes from the rear-view mirror seemed weary, with a scar crossing over one of them. That must’ve been some kind of taxi driver violation, but Phainon couldn’t really judge.

“Is that so?” He asked, “Sorry, but ya' could’ve fooled me.” He shook his head, chuckling to himself.

Phainon doesn't know what expression he made during the whole conversation, but he simply hopes the car was dark enough for Mydei not to notice whatever was going on on his face.

The rest of the drive was blessedly silent.)

Mydei huffs as he walks through the doorway, Trinnon in his left arm as Tribbie holds onto his pant leg, Trianne trailing behind. “So,” he starts, “what’s for dinner?”

“Honeycakes!” Trianne says excitedly. “De’s ones are the best!”

“Woah hold on there,” Phainon interjects, closing the door behind him, “if we feed you guys any more sugar Aglaea’s gonna have our heads. Why don’t you try something else?”

Trianne grumbled, discontent, but thankfully her sister’s there to placate her. “Snowy’s right, Trianne,” Tribbie says, gently pulling on her sister's dress, “we can have sandwiches, can't we? De makes them really cute!”

Trianne huffs as Mydei puts Trinnon down to lay on the coach. Gently, he approaches the girl, kneeling in front of her, “We can have honeycakes tomorrow, but we need some dinner tonight," he says. "I'll make them first thing in the morning, promise."

The girl's eye glints as she heartily sticks her pinky finger out. "Promise it!"

Mydei laughs, intertwining pinkies. "This way, you have something to look forward to tomorrow as well.”

“Alright!" she grins, "Tomorrow it is!”

"So we're getting sandwhiches today?" Tribbie interjects, smiling.

"I want ten!" Trianne says. "I'm gonna eat so much I'll be sleepy! Then tomorrow can come faster!"

Mydei shakes, fond and soft and thoroughly amused. “We don't have enough for ten, but we can start with five. How ‘bout that?”

A chorus of cheers accompany the man as they make their way to the kitchen. Phainon settles by the counter with a sigh, thankful most his babysitting duties are over. In truth, he most greatly prefers nights like this. When it's the both of them babysitting or cooking or whatever it is they're doing together. It’s all achingly domestic.

It's in moments like this, in the quiet of their home and in the time between what they spend together, that he truly feels like he's walking on eggshells. A part of him he doesn't want to recognize as himself whispers that this is what he has to lose; what he *will* lose if he chooses to confess haphazardly. Not the fear of rejection, but of what will come with it.

A house of cards is what he's built. Grand and beautiful yet deceptively fragile.

Phainon's not an insecure man, not really, but he cannot *help* but feel incompetent when he's done nothing but receive help. He'd moved to Okhema to pursue a degree he barely cares

about simply to escape a life he ended up dooming his sister to. Even *after* the move he's basically been handheld by Aglaea up until Mydei had entered his life and more or less acted as his caretaker.

He wants to confess, he *knows* he does, irregardless of what happens after. But can he? *Should* he?

Even if Mydei were to accept, would it truly be better if they'd gotten together?

(*He doesn't know. Doesn't know if he wants to find out, anymore.)*

His musing is broken by Trinnon tugging softly at his pant leg, blinking blearily as she gestures to be lifted up. Phainon gently settles her down in the chair next to him.

“It’s alright if you wanna nap, Trinnon,” he smiled, slightly tired, “the three of them are gonna be busy for a while.”

In lieu of a response, she merely places her little hand over his. “Snowy, you're thinking a lot.” She mumbles, “Like Agy. But not like Agy. You're thinking bad thoughts.”

Of the triplets, Phainon could confidently say that Tribbie was the most outgoing, but Trinnon was the most observant. She’s quiet: more so than Tribbie and definitely more than Trianne, but she was quiet by normal standards as well. Yet somehow, she makes up for it through sporadic bursts of wisdom. Words that somehow strike harder than any normal criticism, imbued with the innocence of a child and said frankly with a heart that truly cares.

Phainon sighs. “They’re not bad thoughts,” he mutters. “It’s just. Adult thoughts. I’m alright, Trinnon, don’t worry.” He doesn’t want to worry her, really. Enough people are already burdened by his love life.

“Hm,” she tilts her head. “but Snowy, I’m still worried.”

Fuck , he thinks, and doesn’t say, because he knows better than to swear in front of a child. Now he can really tell why kids often prefer Mydei over him.

Despite his (mainly useless) degree in psychology and the hundreds of thousands of words he’s churned out in University, his mouth grows dry when confronted with such honesty. What could he say to placate her, when he cannot make sense of his own thoughts?

“Sorry,” is what he settles for.

“It’s okay,” is what she replies.

She's silent for a second, before continuing again. "Tribbie's favourite colour is blue," she starts.

Phainon stays silent, waiting for her to continue.

"But Trianne likes red. And I like both," she says. "We share things, though. Plenty of things. Do you know what our room is?"

"Um," he pauses, "either blue or red?"

"Both," she says, instead. "Our room is purple."

Phainon doesn't really understand, but he nods anyway. Trinnon shakes her head, almost in disappointment, but she drifts asleep not long after right on the stool.

He sighs, frustrated- not at her, or at anybody else for that matter, but merely at himself. His emotions have gotten so obvious that the kid he's *babysitting* noticed. Sweet as it was for her to comfort him about it, even he knows that he's being pathetic. He's a grown man with a puppy crush and too much fear to act on it. His friends know about it. His *sister* even, a hundred miles away, knows how simply gone he is for his roommate. It's gotten to a point that it's so, *so* much harder to ignore than it once was.

It might've been a crush, or plain attraction, or even simply loneliness, at a point. But he's gotten so used to living this life, has gotten greedy enough to want it for himself. Because he's gotten a taste, and now he wants seconds, and doesn't know how much more Mydei will give him.

(He knows, deep down, that there's no backing out. He knows he doesn't want to ignore it.)

Phainon feels like a fool. A lovesick, helpless, fool.

He groans into his hands and thinks of red and blue, and he wonders how the hell he'll reach purple.

He feels like he's going insane.

Chapter End Notes

A/N: I lied ya'll this chapt was like 90% IRL yearning

I dragged you in with a goofy premise now you're stuck with introspection. Sorry (?)

In all seriousness this chapter is mainly to setup for a few more things down the line so I'm sorry that we're not getting any crack or humor just yet :(

We're at the halfway point now! I'm sorry again if this was a bit slower or more disjointed than the other chapters, I struggled with writing this one a lot more than i did prev ones.

I PROMISE the next one actually has more social media stuff and hopefully crack. Phainon just needs to suffer a bit before that. Next chapter should come in about the same amount of time as this one!

As always, thank you so so much for reading, I love ya'll <3!!

Chapter 4

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“Phainon.”

“I know what you’re gonna say. But-”

“Respectfully, what the fuck are you *wearing.”*

Phainon’s in a trench coat and a pair of party glasses complete with a fake nose and black mustache. The outfit somehow makes him stand out even more among the brightly colored cosplayers and event-goers. The coat is wrinkled and clashes horribly with his white hair, and Castorice feels like she’s going to be sick.

“I can’t believe this is live . This is going to be on the internet forever. *”* She mutters, disbelieving as she holds her tripod up. Her eyes are wide and she looks close to tears. “I should’ve stayed home. Gods *damn it all* I should’ve known.”

Castorice is, of course, dressed like a normal person. A plaid violet vest and white skirt, paired with white sneakers and her usual floral accessories. With the addition of her dark purple glasses. She’s well dressed and comfortable, obvious signs of Aglaea’s influence and casually elegant fashion. Words of advice that Phainon, evidently, does not apply.

“It’s not that bad!” He whisper-shouts.

Mydei hadn’t been at home today. This morning, he had taken the triplets to school and left breakfast and a tupperware of cookies by the counter. He added a droma sticky-note on top, reminding Phainon not to be stupid because Mydei would be out for the day.

He’d texted him thanks for the breakfast, and informed him that he also wouldn't be at home. He’s almost grateful his roommate hadn’t been around to judge his outfit.

Castorice and Phainon haven’t even entered the museum, because for some reason the convention this year was being held in Okhema’s National Museum of all places. Something about celebrating a renovation or new installation, he heard.

Point is that a fashionable younger woman is arguing with a man in a trench coat. The many people walking past stare worriedly.

c3ntur_1on : yall are we not gonna enter the con orrr

AbducTea : they been here for 10 minutes omfg

ssomsom : WHAT ARE YOU WEARING

Gloria_PD : bfr embarassing

LETmeTOIL : btw gldnwvrs panel is starting soon

Sleezee : CLOCK HIS ASS CCASTO

S2h1fx : you do look terrible tho

The last time they'd streamed in real life together at a convention, they got banned by the organizers for causing a ruckus. They'd only been allowed to attend *this one* through insistent begging, their fans rioting against the organizers and a few streamers (Aglaea, begrudgingly) advocating for their good behavior. As a result, they were prohibited from holding fansigns or meetups, but they *were* still allowed to attend.

So in a rare act of foresight, Phainon had decided to be 'inconspicuous' for this convention, as to no longer draw attention. Castorice, mildly impressed, had agreed to it at first.

Though she hadn't thought of what exactly Phainon meant by *inconspicuous.*

"Aglaea is totally disowning us," Castorice sighs mournfully as she twists Phainon's ear.

For someone way shorter than him, she has surprisingly strong hands. Phainon doesn't reply immediately, still stuck in the death grip Castorice has on his right ear.

"Ow- *shit* man why are you so strong-" he whimpers as he nurses his reddened ear.

She laughs the kind of laugh Aglaea does when she finds something particularly amusing or pathetic. "I think you're just weak, Phainon."

Castorice only lets go once Phainon resorts to tickling her out of her grasp. She glares at Phainon as he sticks his tongue out, backing away, before her eyes catch on his *sneakers*.

They're neon yellow with cartoony purple suns drawn on. And they glitter in the sun. Purple, chromatic, glitter. Her eyes burn.

"Hasn't Aglaea threatened to throw those out?" She hisses.

Aglaea has, multiple times, made comments about it. In fact, she does so consistently every couple of visits. The only reason she hasn't thrown them out yet is because Phainon's been keeping them in their shoebox, tucked away in his closet. For some reason, he's weirdly attached to them.

"These are perfectly good shoes!" He gasps, affronted, "I only wear them on special occasions!"

"Please," Castorice's head is in her hands as she groans, "never subject anyone to these shoes."

LowBloodSugar : cant dress himself, cant cook, cant play games boy u useless as shit

azealwags : im sorry yellow and WHAT

manohman : can we address the shoes first

M_D3pp : BYEEEE LMAOOO

KLEPTkept : CASTO STAY STRONG MY GIRL

KoptStranger : my niece has those shoes 😭

“Hey- quit panning to my sneakers!” Phainon whines as he tries side-stepping out of frame.

Castorice narrows her eyes as she follows him, readily exposing his horrid taste in fashion. “Suddenly embarrassed now, aren’t you?” She snides.

He backs up continuously until his back is to a tree and Castorice is about to get the clearest shot yet of his shoes. She’s about to pan to the happy little faces of the suns near his sole.

And Phainon can handle a lot, but *nobody* mocks the smiley suns on his shoes.

“That’s it!” He threatens, whipping out a tupperware from his coat, “Any closer and I’m docking your pay!”

Desperate times call for desperate measures.

Castorice stops immediately, affronted.

It’s pretty well-known that whenever Deliverer collaborates with GoldenWeaver, Castorice, Lady Tribios or any of the streamers from the Astral Express, he’ll always be seen with a tupperware of cookies or other sweet treats. He offers them as a gift, or as ‘ *payment’*.

Once, he brought a stack of teddy bear shaped honeycakes for Lady Tribios and a whole citrus pound cake for Aglaea. Another time, he’d bought five completely separate desserts for each member of the Astral Express, even bringing an angel food cake for their guest and *handmade dog treats* for the crew’s pet, Pompom.

Many speculate that streamers will collab with him just to have a taste of the aforementioned confections, the source of envy and numerous comments begging for the recipes. This tradition is, of course, an anomaly.

Fans don’t know when or why it started, or even *who* is making such confections when Deliverer himself is known for the chaos he causes in kitchens.

“You will do no such thing,” she says. A statement. A *threat.* “You are not taking away the one thing that makes *this* bearable.”

“And what’re you gonna do about it?” He taunts, holding what seems to be a container of white chocolate chunk pomegranate cookies.

“You didn’t even make those you *thief-”*

“Yet *I* have them regardless!”

Phainon skids away as he cracks open the container, taking a hurried bite of the other's specially made confections as he parades it in front of her.

It's sweet. Sweeter than he prefers but he knows it's just right to Castorice's tastes. Figures. Mydei is an excellent cook.

She scowls, rolling up her sleeves and pushing her glasses up the bridge of her nose. "You'll regret this."

She takes a step forward.

What follows is a series of bad decisions that Phainon can only attribute to adrenaline.

Because she steps just close enough for him to steal her prescription glasses, temporarily blinding her. And in a fit of truly bad decision making, he replacing them with his own dollar-store ones.

The black is flaking off from where he pulled them off so fast, and the mustache and nose look *ridiculous* paired with Castorice's dyed violet and purple ends.

She's stunned.

The paint chips onto her face as Phainon snaps a picture.

Castorice gapes.

The exchange lasts for five seconds. Castorice stops for two. Phainon runs for his life immediately.

Now Phainon is not a small man by any means. He's tall, at least about six-foot, and the trenchcoat obscures his figure just so he looks very slightly bigger than he usually is.

And thus, the sight of him being chased around and *terrified* by a girl a whole head shorter than him is one that undoubtedly turns heads.

"Your crimes will not go unpunished," she mutters, deadly serious.

The tripod in her right hand looks like a scythe, the way it cuts through the air with sheer *force,* capturing the chase with shockingly steady hands. "His cookies are the one line not to be crossed. Whatever happens now is *penance* , Deliverer."

Forget *inconspicuous* , he thinks, they haven't even entered the convention and are already making a scene.

He truly wonders how Aglaea deals with the both of them. She might be a saint, or simply a very terrifying woman. He considers calling her just to get this madness to end.

"Casto, work with me here!" He chuckles nervously as Castorice continues hounding him, "It was a joke! I'm sorry, I swear! I'll never wear them again! I won't touch your cookies! I'll throw those glasses out! No, I'll wear them for the entire day! *Ack* - Just stop chasing me!"

Phainon yelps as he slips through a crowd, muttering apologies as he narrowly avoids con-goers. “Please *?”* He adds on, because he’s polite like that.

Castorice, of course, ignores him. For some ungodly reason, she manages to keep up with him. Fueled by sheer *disgust* at his fashion choices and retribution for the glasses and cookies he’s stolen, she catches up to him while being weighed down by a tripod in her right hand.

Well , he thinks as Castorice tackles him to the ground, *at least it’s good content.*

If he had a nickel every time he’s been tackled to the ground this week, he’d have two nickels. Which wasn’t much, but it’s weird it’s happened more than once.

Castorice pushes the glasses up, and she really has no right looking somewhat *cool* while wearing the most ridiculous glasses known to man. “The cookies,” she mutters, because *that’s* the most pressing issue right now, “hand them over. Or *else.”*

Phainon doesn’t need to be told twice, quickly shoving them into her hands as he holds both his up in surrender. “Truce?”

Castorice eyes him as she takes a bite of the cookie, finishing it in one go. She glares harder before taking another, and shoving the sunglasses back on Phainon.

“Truce.” She says gets up, and the relief Phainon feels would be embarrassing if he hadn’t just watched his life flash before his eyes.

They finally make it inside the convention.

As in, they finally start queuing for the convention.

Because the thing about getting banned is that you get most of your privileges rebuked as well. Including but not limited to not having creator passes and not being scheduled a panel, two things which Phainon is generally fine with.

He’s a streamer, not a celebrity. And anyways Aglaea has told him before that he’s a PR nightmare. It’s a good thing he’s self-employed.

It doesn’t help the boredom, though.

“Cas are you sure we can’t call Aglaea to pick us up?” Phainon groaned as he peeled off his trench coat.

He was wearing one of Mydei’s band shirts underneath, a black one of course, that he yoinked out of his closet and forgot to return. It was loose, looser than it would be on Mydei. He sighed in relief at the circulation. Wearing a trench coat in the middle of the day really wasn’t one of his better decisions.

“Mm, I texted her,” Castorice replied, still nibbling on the cookies. She’s yet to put them down since they started queuing.

They'd paused the stream at this point. Lining up wasn't very exciting, and they couldn't talk much in line anyway. Phainon sighed as he opened his phone.

Mufasa (*Mydeimos.)*

You

Mydei

Mydeii

Mydeiiiiii

Have you dropped the girls off at school yet?

My friend enjoyed the cookies btw she said thanks

Mufasa

Yes.

Ok, good.

You

Instant reply? How rare!

What's got you in a good mood?

Mufasa

Nosy, arent you?

You

:(?

Mufasa

…Quit it.

I'm visiting my mother today.

You

:O

Wow!

She’s in okhema?

Mufasa

For the moment, yes.

You’ve eaten?

He was just about to reply when he hears the signature clacking of Aglaea’s heels. Parting the crowd not unlike she was parting the seas, she stride over not the least bit tired nor sweaty even while wearing a dress and outer coat.

Phainon, in contrast, is sweating even through the black shirt. Aglaea silently snaps a picture.

“W-What! Hey!”

“One moment,” she holds up her hand as she types something on her phone, before quickly pocketing it. She glances Castorice, smiling, before turning to Phainon with a cold expression. Specifically, at Phainon’s footwear.

“You hid them from me.” She states.

The way she has no infliction in her voice sends shivers down his spine. “...I did.” He admits, because there’s no use lying to Aglaea.

Her eyes shine with disapproval as she turns away.

“Come, the VIP entrance is this way.”

The VIP creator’s lounge is *much* nicer than what he initially imagined. Especially because he technically wasn’t supposed to be here.

The last couple of years he’s been attending, he was of course allowed to enter lounges and such, but never had he seen something so…plush?

Inside, the room was air-conditioned with complimentary snacks and all kinds of other creators just lounging about. The sofas, he swears, look better than what he had back in his apartment. Phainon gasps as the waiter by the bar offers (*offers!)* him a slider.

Castorice looks hesitantly at Aglaea by her right, “Are you sure we’re even allowed in here?” She winces as Phainon locks eyes with the Trailblazer, Astral Express’ newest and most chaotic member. The two immediately start running circles around each other. Like children. Overly excitable children.

She waves politely at Tribios who sits off to the side and smiles back.

Aglaea hums, “I’m sure it’s alright.”

It isn’t just the question of whether they are allowed in considering their less than stellar track record, but also the question of whether they are *qualified* to be here. She feels almost silly, in a way, being in such a lounge with creators she’s watched for years. Aglaea watches her hesitation and huffs gently.

“If it makes you feel better,” she starts, “no one should be quite as embarrassed as Phainon is. His sneakers truly are dreadful.”

She chuckles. “I knew you wouldn’t approve of them.”

“That I don’t, indeed,” Aglaea smiles.

Wordlessly, Castorice golds up the tupperware, offering the still plentiful cookies inside. Aglaea’s eyes shine in approval as she takes a bite.

“From Phainon?” She asks.

Castorice nods in response.

Aglaea glances at Phainon, making an utter fool of himself in a lounge he technically shouldn’t even have access to and shakes her head, snapping another picture.

[Unknown]

You

[4 image(s) attached]

Your roommate is having fun.

[Unknown]

…Thank you.

Is that the convention?

You

Yes.

Will you be picking up the girls today?

[Unknown]

Yes.

I’ll drop them off at the library.

My colleagues offered to watch them.

You

That will do.

Thank you, Mydeimos.

For the cookies as well.

[Unkown]

You've tried them?

That's good.

"Are you texting him?" Castorice asked as she leaned over.

Aglaea laughed tiredly. "The illustrious roommate, indeed I am."

Mydei was a sort of boogeyman figure for the streamers within Phainon's circle.

They all know about his, quote, *"stupid hot brute of a roommate".* Yet Phainon himself had denied romantic (or sexual) attraction to said roommate.

But Aglaea knows the truth. That he was neither stupid nor a brute nor merely a *roommate* . The description was wildly inaccurate, even by Phainon's standards.

Personally, as the only person to actually know the two, she finds the whole thing ridiculous. Aglaea's been working tirelessly for the better part of a year to get the two together, yet nothing seems to work. From the dates and the red carpets and that ridiculously expensive Luofu *couple's trip.* She'd planned each attempt extensively, fronted the costs herself and for what? No progress. Nothing at all.

Tribios has seen the extent of her romantic endeavors. As in, her endeavors in making the two *see the romance* that was so plainly in front of their eyes.

The other woman has accompanied her through coffee breaks turned therapy sessions, and late-night dress fittings fueled by caffeine and rants.

"There's no way," Aglaea muttered, her third cup of coffee of the night once Tribios' gown once again had to be adjusted. "There's no way they don't know. They must be joking. They're secretly dating and are using me to plan their wedding. There cannot be any other explanation." She said, manic.

Aglaea is proper. Elegant. Almost inhumanely so. But she is also wildly passionate about the strangest endeavors, Tribios thinks as she laughed.

Aglaea sighed as she simultaneously started trimming and weaving fabric once more. Her talent for multitasking truly was a marvel. Tribios chuckled once more as she comforted her, gently patting her shoulder.

“Now, now,” she tutted, “your friends’ romantic troubles aside, I think it’s better you get some rest, Agy. And some dinner. Their love life *and* the dress can wait.” She said, gently prying the scissors and thread away from her hands.

Aglaea simply sighed, long-suffering.

Back then, she vowed that the two *will* end up together before she finished the dress (or before Comic Con arrived).

That was weeks ago.

And evidently, they are not together yet.

She’s told herself then to simply to ignore the two. That she has much, *much* more important things to handle.

And yet, their romance (or the lack thereof) is simply a travesty she can’t look away from. It’s an insult to her very nature as a romantic everytime she sees them so painfully in love and so painfully *unaware of it.*

Cyrene, her partner in crime, had even started giving up on the two. Their situation is simply that hopeless.

Just the thought of it is stressful enough. Aglaea puts her head in her hands and tries very hard not to scream in public. Castorice rubs her back soothingly.

Phainon is, despite the annoyance, a family friend.

He is someone she’s regretfully come to care about even through the periodic heart attacks he causes. He is good to a fault, a purity that would be naive on others but just earnest enough to be sincere on him. And it is undeniable to *everyone* that he would be happy with his roommate, and that in fact he had only *started* being happy once he’d met him.

She remembers his first weeks in Okhema.

When his family had first reached out about her watching over their son she was…hesitant, to say the least. She was capable enough, sure. By then her career had already allowed her a comfortable living. Yet, she didn’t know where the boy would fit in her life.

It’d already felt so full. Everyday she had a new project to do or an old one to revisit. If Aglaea could be described in a word, it would be that she is dedicated. Devoted, even. To her passions yes, but also to her missions. Whether that be taking care of the triplets or styling the mannequins around her home in whatever outfits she fancied at the time.

She was content. Perfectly so.

And so she didn't know *what* exactly came over her when she accepted.

It could've been attributed to Cyrene's constant begging or perhaps Tribios' gentle encouragement to know more people. It could've even been on a whim, maybe of the need for a male figure for her garments, she wasn't quite sure.

But if there's one thing Aglaea *is* sure about, it's that Phainon was absolutely *miserable* the first time he arrived.

He was smiling when they first met, a hollow, surface thing she'd seen through immediately. One for appearances, for being polite. Yet it didn't quite fit on his face, with the almost dejected eyes he had. It was like he was missing a home he'd only just left.

He was wide-eyed but unsure, almost hesitant of the city, like it would eat him whole.

Aglaea sighed. It was just like Cyrene had said. That Phainon had always felt just slightly out of place.

She didn't understand then *why* Cyrene thought sending him her way would do him any good.

"Phainon, was it?" She greeted.

"Ah- yes, Miss Aglaea."

She didn't usually mind the overt respect, Aglaea *was* a highly sought after woman after all. But the dejected puppy stare Phainon had coupled it with made her queasy.

"Just Aglaea," she shook her head, "you must be hungry, your journey's been long. Come."

Aglaea had brought him to a fast food joint that day, not quite sure what men his age might like. Phainon's slightly brighter smile when ordering on the touchscreens was well worth the few hundred credits she spent.

He ordered a relatively small meal despite Aglaea offering to pay. A burger and meal set that seemed more fit for a child. That couldn't nearly be enough for a man of his height, especially after such a long trip.

And so she excused herself to buy two more sets, both to go, that she slides over to Phainon without a word.

"I- Aglaea it really is quite alright," he muttered.

Hesistant to accept help. She raised a brow, "Well," she answered, "I've already bought it, no? I'd rather not have any. Feel free to do what you wish with it."

Phainon hadn't replied, so Aglaea took it as her own personal victory and steamrolled on.

"Your parents have arranged that you stay in my apartment until the academic year starts," She said.

Phainon nodded listlessly.

"So, have you decided what to major in?" She opted for casual conversation, refusing the fries Phainon offered. Pleasantries were much easier than showing concern, even if they were a bit awkward.

“Not really,” he chuckled, a little sad, “my parents told me to take agriculture. Or animal sciences. The useful degrees, y’know? For the farm, or something.”

“I asked if *you* have decided, Phainon. Not your parents.”

And Phainon simply blinked at that, before eating the rest of his meal, which was alright. Silence meant that he was thinking about it.

Aglaea knows the burden of choice well. Choosing what fabrics to use, which commissions to take and how her garments must be designed. They feel monumental despite its entirely subjective importance.

So she lets him think, even as they walk home and Phainon asks with the most hopeful eyes she’s ever seen on a man whether or not he could *“feed the stray dogs a burger.”*

She’d told him no, of course, fast food would probably actively be worse for whatever animal eats it. But his dejected expression was potent enough that she considered going back on her word.

That night, Phainon slept in the living room, despite the guest room Aglaea offered. He scrolled through majors and landed on whatever would let him meet the most people, and help him fill up his time.

When he finally decides on psychology, late in the first night he spends away from home on the couch of someone he’s never met before, he wonders, still, if the choice he made was right.

“Aglaea, I appreciate you, you’re great, but If there’s one thing I cannot compromise on, it’s that I *cannot* do panels!”

Aglaea rolls her eyes.

“You can’t do a lot of things, Phainon. But they’ll kick you out of the lounge if you don’t participate, and the staff have already called for arrangements.”

“Sorry, the staff has *what?”*

Phainon never fights against Aglaea.

In fact, he agrees to a lot of things. Half-dates with his roommate? Sure. Random home visits? Sure. Stealing his coffee machine for weeks at a time? No big deal. Even *throwing out* most of his clothes (which is why he steals Mydei’s so often) is something he’s learned to live with!

But never. *Never* has or will he do a panel live.

“Oh come on. What difference is a panel and a stream, anyway?” Aglaea challenges, once Phainon refuses for the upteempth time. “You answer questions in front of a live audience, just as you do on your streams. I don’t see why a panel would somehow be any worse.”

“It’s *live* , Algaea, that’s exactly why it’s worse!”

The thing about streams is that *he* picks the questions. Which also means *he* chooses what he wants to ignore. That includes spam questions, personal questions. The ones he generally avoids answering for his safety and privacy .

Because the reason why he started streaming in the first place was as an escape. As a way to blur the lines of where he ended and the Deliverer started.

The difference with panels, however, is that questions are shoved in his face. That he *can’t* do Professor Anaxa’s patented three-step diversion technique. And considering his fans *and* his own pattern of answering questions, he already knows what his panel is going to be full of.

“They’re gonna make me talk about Mydei, damnit!” He groans, falling to his knees. The embarrassment is going to eat him alive, he knows. On a panel with mics shoved in his face and reporters itching to know about his *love life.*

Aglaea raises a brow almost in confusion. “You’re most worried about addressing the *mystery man?* ” She questions.

“ *Fuck* - yes! I’m worried about addressing my *mystery man,”* he wails.

Phainon is ugly sobbing on the floor and Aglaea considers it a grace that she is only slightly disgusted. She has half a mind to step back, chastising him for being dramatic, before she pauses.

A panel. Where he’ll be forced to confront the topic of his mystery man. His *roommate.*

And suddenly, in a motion too faint to be noticed by anyone who isn’t watching, she smirks, a gently cunning upturn of the lips.

“I have a proposition.” She starts.

“What’s this now?” Phainon says, muffled from where he lies face down on the floor.

Aglaea kicks him, just gently with the tip of the heel, to get Phainon’s attention. His head lifts up red from where it was glued to the ceramic. Gross.

“I’ll schedule a three-way panel,” she says, pulling at Phainon’s cheek to get him to sit up completely. “You, Castorice and I will panel together. That way, the both of us can take over in the case that your questions go awry *,”* she adds, “ *and* to top it off, you’ll be able to get your collab content. All at once. Convenient.”

It’s a good plan.

One that she herself is quite proud of.

The catalyst for failure, as she's observed, is that they both too easily deny their feelings for each other. Somehow, there is always a convenient emotional or physical mishap that stops them from confessing.

Yet this, *this plan* might finally be foolproof enough to handle it.

She smiles.

Maybe the two won't be so hopeless after all.

"Phainon. If you lose to me you're paying for my cab back home."

"That's not fair!" He groans.

They both know he's going to lose.

pspswashere : poor guy is being extorted

AdaBoy_Bat : NAH U CHALLENGE THE GUY W 372 FAILED ATTEMPTS AT NIKADOR??

LEAVEN : CAS FUCK HIM UP

carbonatedtea : HES COOKED

[@ dylMCahel has donated 30,000 credits: "i'll donate 10k if this ends in under a minute lol."]

Kirarawr : WHY THE HELL DID YOU PICK ROY??????

SonOfFlowers : why does he agree to bets he's gonna lose on…

"You picked *Roy?* Are you trying to lose?" Castorice narrowed her eyes.

"He's a swordsman! I like swords!"

Roy was a character with a relatively simple playstyle. His kit really only had a parry and the generic types of hits. He wasn't meta, and he was slow, but relatively easy to play. Castorice smiled. The character did feel quite fitting.

"Then it seems you simply like losing."

The two had resumed streaming once the Astral Express and Lady Tribios were called on for their panels. Aglaea had shooed them from the lounge anyway, claiming the two were better off enjoying the con.

And so they've been roaming for a while, currently engaged in a (not-so) friendly match of Smash.

"What the hell-" Phainon gasps as Castorice smirks, juggling his character and knocking him out immediately.

"That's not fair! You play with no items, dude, who plays Smash with no items??"

socialite : ...tournaments play with no items

YeahRight : EVERYONE PLYS W NO ITEMS

Kloudzz : did the bleach fry his brain or is he naturally like this?

_catLADY : im actually embarrassed i watch this guy

specialSstarfish : @Kloudzz that's the worst part. his hair is natural.

Phainon groans and walks away as he drops onto his last stock, the game decisively ending. The ending was wholly expected, but it was a blow to his pride nonetheless.

[@ dylanMCahel has donated 10,000 credits: "...48 seconds."]

"Don't be too sad now," Castorice smiles as she puts down the controller, "you got one hit in. Congratulations."

When asked, Phainon will say that he did *not* in fact rage quit and leave the moment he lost. That would be an exaggeration.

No, he simply wanted to walk around the convention. And anyways Castorice is far too excited to beat down random people on Smash. She's having fun, he supposes. Really though, it was just an excuse for him to be alone for a bit.

Now, as a rule, Phainon shouldn't really be left alone.

His friends would say that he needs a keeper to watch over him in the event that he gets into trouble, but personally he doesn't believe that's quite the case.

It wasn't so much that he *needed* to be watched over , just that he does better with company. Especially in the case that he starts overthinking.

But this was a special case. Even despite his distaste for solitude, Phainon had to be alone, at least for a bit, just to process himself.

The thing about crushes and having a crush on *Mydei* specifically, is that he is, quite literally, the only one to suffer through it. It's not quite like University, where even in the lowest pits of exams we could rant as much as he liked to Mydei. Nor was it like streaming, where he had confidants in Aglaea and Castorice as well.

The issue with love was that there was no other way to process it except ruminating on *why* he becomes a mess whenever in the proximity of his roommate.

He sighs, walking through the con, the remnants of last night's worries lingering.

The con was loud, crowded and full of people in every sense of the word. But maybe his inconspicuous disguise worked too well, because still he felt invisible to the world. Without a camera on him, without easy banter to go off of, it was all too easy to get lost in thoughts of…

Mydei.

He feels his heart thump. He could swear he'd just spotted a familiar head of strawberry blonde in the crowd.

There's no way. Is there?

He had half a mind to call out, to so familiarly reach out and snark about how *"I didn't know you were into this sort of thing."*

But he doesn't. Because it shouldn't even be *Mydei.*

Mydei should be out. At the library or at the gym not here, not at this convention, not now.

Streaming is his escape from reality.

His escape from the Phainon who is caught up and in love and impulsively ran away from his old life in Aedes Elysiae.

Because when he streams, he is the Deliverer. A man who's bad at games and knows way too many people in the streaming industry. Who collabs with small streamers and doesn't answer personal questions and does charity streams more often than he does Q&As.

Mydei shouldn't be here. Shouldn't be where *Deliverer* is.

All his friends only know of his 'mysterious roommate'. With the exception of Aglaea, they only know Mydei as the guy who bakes and insists that Phainon bring gifts for his friends. As the guy who's shirts Phainon always wears and the reason why he shows up on stream limping (because of *sparring)* or bruised (because he got punched in the face).

But they don't know more than that. They *shouldn't* know more than that.

He makes it a point to separate his real life from anything on the internet. Because it's easy to confront his issues and talk about the *Mystery Man* when he's behind a screen and streaming. But it's an entirely different issue for *Phainon* to confront the feelings he has for his *roommate.*

Mydei being here doesn't even make any sense, he rationalizes.

He hadn't told Mydei his plans for the day, and Mydei himself has his own set of plans.

Either whoever he saw *wasn't* Mydei (unlikely) or Mydei just *happens* to be here completely unrelated to him (even more unlikely).

Phainon groans.

He could hope for the best and very easily just go back to Castorice and mind his own business. Assume it was just a blip in his imagination, something caused by Mydeimos withdrawal, or something.

But then he remembers his *panel.*

The one with three of the biggest Okheman streamers around. The one where people are, inevitably, going to bring up the Mystery Man. The one maybe-Mydei might watch at and see exactly how inexplicably in love he is with his roommate. The one where people will no doubt reference the *online documentation* of him *ogling* at his roommate's arms.

Phainon's legs catch up quicker than his mind, eyes dead set on finding him again.

The possibility of Mydei seeing *any of that* is downright terrifying.

Fuck, he thinks.

Panels really are the worst.

Chapter End Notes

A/N : Silly chapter because it's still April Fools somewhere!

We only have two left to go~

Honestly I started off the fic with mostly humor but I slipped and fell into yearning. I'm getting impatient myself BUT we'll have some resolution soon so that's something to look forward to!

The next chapter should be around next week as usual.

Thank you all so much for stopping by! <3

Chapter 5

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Mydei is a conspicuous man.

Be it his tattoos, his eyes, eyeliner, jewelry, his *body,* or a combination of his features, Mydei is someone distinct, *especially* to Phainon.

While others could recognize him by his chunky golden earrings (the ones he'd only wear when at events or gatherings), Phainon could recognize him by his ears alone. The jagged sort of puncture they'd done back in college on his lobe, the tremor of the needle in his hands, a tacit confidence in him to do something potentially dangerous to him.

"Get on with it, already," Mydei growled from where he settled on Phainon's lap.

"Oh, hush! The last time I checked, I'm studying psychology, not learning to become a body piercer."

"Yeah? And I'm not a paying customer. Now hurry *up, it stinks* ."

Their cramped two-person dorm was made into a makeshift studio, the scent of disinfectant and their one-burner gas stove turned up high to quickly heat the needle. Phainon's cinnamoroll desk lamp (a gift Mydei had gotten him on a whim) shone straight into his eyes from where it hung precariously off his shelf. They'd huddled their beds together because they didn't have a couch and Phainon refused to do it on their floor.

"If it stinks for you, it stinks for me too! At least take me out for dinner after this!"

Mydei snorted, "And risk an ear infection by going out? I'd have thought you were against such dangerous prospects."

Phainon groaned, placing the needle back off to the side. His hands were still shaking, he couldn't risk it. "This whole thing is risking an ear infection. Remind me, why couldn't you just go to your tattoo artist again?"

Mydei shrugged, "They're closed for the week."

Phainon's eyes narrowed at the deadpan response. Most people think Phainon is the annoying one. That Mydei puts up with him with growling and barely contained anger, that everytime Phainon eggs him on, Mydei is just that much closer to snapping.

He's heard the whispers of when they're together on campus. Mydei's popularity is a given but he isn't so blind to think that he doesn't have his fair share of admirers as well. However they only like him in passing, in his smiles and the way he greets classmates and remembers people's names. He knows they find him insufferable, sometimes.

And so the moments when Mydei *doesn't* act that way– when he's all snark and sarcasm, instead of growling and pissed off as people say he should be, when he plays with the punches thrown at him instead of just shutting him down, Phainon finds himself at a loss on what to say.

"And you couldn't just wait a week to get your ears pierced? You'd rather risk your underqualified best friend to do it?" Phainon sighs, shaking his head.

Mydei's head is still on his lap, the rest of his body relaxed on the conjoined beds. He cracks his eye open and raises an unfairly defined brow. "Self-consciousness is a bad look on you, HKS. Where's your usual bravado?"

"Confidence is for things I can either do or bullshit my way out of. Possibly amputating your ears is *not* the time to be blatantly confident, Mydei."

"My ears will be fine. I can handle it." Mydei's body does not move, but the infliction of his tone already indicates a shrug.

Mydei settles back, somehow relaxing even further to lay against his thighs. Phainon's wearing sweatpants, the thick material of it one of the few good pieces of loungewear that he owns and Mydei seems to agree, the way he's nuzzling into the fabric. Mydei often did that on soft fabrics and such. It was cute, not that he'd admit it.

They're sitting in what feels like a nest of their combined blankets and pillows. It's soft, comfortably warm, a satisfying sort of silence that makes even the smell of disinfectant almost cozy.

Phainon resists the urge to card through his natural hair and undo the braid that's starting to come undone. Yes, natural, because Mydei's hair isn't dyed (he's checked– none of his hair has ever discolored or faded), an earth-shattering realization he's been forced to come to terms with ever since they'd become roommates. The strands naturally fade into blonde and gold up from where his scalp is, darkening into auburn red. It's miraculous.

A marvel of nature, really. All of him is.

"Quiet tonight, aren't you?

Phainon realized, then, that he'd unconsciously been leaning down with how closely he's staring. Mydei's eyes are blessedly still closed. He clears his throat. "I'm simply pondering how anyone's let you study for a medical major. Home-piercing goes against every health and safety rule I know of."

"And *you* would know all about health, wouldn't you, philosopher?" He huffed, and from here he can see his faintly pointed canines, the slight crookedness of his smile. His breath smelled like the on-sale litre of mouthwash they share, and the remnants of diet soda, the only fizzy drink Mydei lets him consume.

Phainon feels an overwhelming urge to kiss him.

It was not the first time he's felt so.

"Rude," Phainon says instead.

Mydei is all hard edges and stoned stares, the sharp flick of his eyeliner unforgiving in the same way his gold necklaces hang heavy on his neck. He smells of rubbing alcohol and smoke from the stove, but so close like this he can smell expensive pomegranate soap– one of the few things Mydei always splurges on, and scent of cinnamon leftover from the snickerdoodles he brought to class this morning. He smells like the shitty college dorm that he gladly calls home.

Mydei is all hard edges, and Phainon is glad he has thick skin.

Phainon lightly pokes his cheek, marvelling at how the barest hint of baby fat still clings to his cheeks even despite the sharp jawline, before lightly dragging his finger down the length of his tattoos. He trails lower until his hand slips under Mydei's loose shirt, eliciting a gasp as he tickles him in the he knows will get the other to laugh, so hard that he falls off the bed.

Mydei laughs all the way down and up, even after he stops tickling. "Stubborn," he huffs, breathless as he grins, hair disheveled from the floor.

Mydei settles back on their beds, and Phainon walks over to the kitchenette to reattempt the piercing. Yet, after a few more attempts of Phainon heating and reheating the needle, the metal starts to blacken and there Phainon decides to take a break.

"If you can't bring yourself to do it, just admit that you can't. But *you* are taking *me* for dinner after wasting my time." Mydei says. He's sat down now after getting bored of lying and waiting for the needle that would not come.

"*I'm* wasting your time? Are you not the one who dragged me into this on a Friday night? A million things, Mydei. A million things I could be doing instead. I could have been out— partying, or something. Networking. Yes, that's the word."

Mydei stared at him blankly, leaning to sit up against the wall. "We both know you'd be spending your weekends with me either way. It was either this or the library."

It wasn't untrue, but Phainon is nothing but a contrarian.

"You never know that! I could be switching things up occasionally! I'm a young, healthy college student, I can do whatever I please. I could go to a bar right now, and prove you wrong."

"*Switching things up* means going to Okhema's museum instead of the sports center. You *doing something different* means us getting ground turkey instead of chicken." Mydei emphasizes with a roll of his eyes.

"Oh shut it," Phainon shuffles closer just to elbows his side, settling in the space next to him, "I have a youthful spirit! You just make us sound like we're boring."

Mydei pushes his elbow away, huffing an amused half-laugh. “Are you not? How ironic when grocery runs and Nietzsche are where *you* find most enjoyment. You yourself seem to be quite the ‘ *boring’* person.”

“Oh? Speaking of philosophy now, aren’t we? Who’s overstepping into whose field of study, now?”

“Still you.” Mydei elbows him back, eliciting a groan. “Do not make it my issue that I happen to be better read.”

Phainon rubs at his still sore side as he glares. “And here I would have never thought that *you’d* be an existentialist.”

“Calling me a brute again? It seems you’ve run out of insults.”

“Well perhaps my *boring* day to day has dried off my capability of creative comebacks. You should be celebrating. Aren’t you always complaining that I’m annoying? That I’m a scoundrel?”

“A Hyena,” Mydei clarifies, because *that’s* what he focuses on, “I call you a hyena, and a scoundrel, because it’s true.” He pushes up against him, closer, so close their thighs stick to each other and he can feel every flex of his muscle even through his shorts.

Phainon huffs, looking away.

“Then why stick around? If I’m so annoying and you’re so tired of me,why trust me to pierce your ears or spot you at the gym? It’s not like you to be so undecided about things.” He feels himself exhale sharply through his nose. He doesn’t mean to be confrontational, nor unpleasant.

This is hardly anything to be offended about– a strange nickname, of all things, is tame in comparison to quite literally anything else people have done to him, Okheman or Elysian alike. But it’s Mydei calling him such things, and he finds it difficult to be so unaffected.

Phainon startles suddenly as Mydei presses his cheek against his shoulder. The softness of his cheek digs into Phainon’s bare shoulder after opting to wear a tank top for the night. Like this, the slight height difference between the two is noticeable, Mydei just barely shorter than him, able to rest his head without spraining his neck. Phainon goes very, very still.

“Mydei-”

“*Shush,* for once in your life, can't you listen? ”

Mydei’s voice drops, huskier than his usual baritone. Commanding in the way it wishes to be heard, oppressive in that it takes up his whole body to do so.

“Look at me. *Look.* Do I *seem* like I’m tired of you, Phainon?”

Phainon’s backs away like he’s been burned, then around, then facing him again, only to stare. The harsh light of his lamp only further frames his silhouette, half lit in shadow. It

brings out the gold of his eyes, the gold of his hair, the gold of his necklace.

And *oh* , he realizes, Mydei would look *really* good in earrings.

Two earrings, gold and chunky, with a gemstone embedded inside. He doesn't even need to think about what colour the gem should be. It was only natural that it'd be blue.

Mydei's mouth pulls back into a slow smirk to reveal the white of his teeth, the slight glint of his canines. "What's spooked you now, HKS?"

You. He thinks to himself.

The thought of him, the memories of him, the future he wishes to have. He wants more of this, of Friday nights doing unimaginably small, new things together. He wants the grocery runs and arguments on how spending more on turkey for less meat is worth it. He wants to get him earrings, wants to watch him wear them, wants to trail his tattoos further down than just on his arm.

He wants to be roommates after they graduate. He wants this shitty college dorm to be an apartment, wants to travel and visit old libraries so Mydei can see the original texts of the books he loves.

A sharp intake of breath, shaky, then immediately, he starts wheezing.

"*Ohfuckohshitohkephaleourburnerisstillon-"* He says in one breath.

Mydei's head snaps as he roughly stands from the bed, rushing to their kitchenette. " *Shit* that's why it smelled so bad! Damnit, HKS!"

Phainon laughs as he coughs, hacking the smell of disinfectant and gas, quickly rushing to vent open his windows. " *Damn* ," he laughs, slumping over the window, "my bad, my bad! I didn't realize it." The strong smell of rubbing alcohol must've masked the scent of gas. He really hadn't noticed it until then.

He hangs off from the outside of their dorm on the first floor, and when Mydei comes back with a cold water bottle in his hands, pressing it straight against his cheek, Phainon thinks that might've been when he first fell in love.

Maybe it was the fumes, or the delirium, but he'd worked up the courage to finally pierce Mydei's ears afterwards to be met with the most deadpan "*that wasn't so bad now, was it?"*

And when the earrings he'd commissioned (with over two years of savings, plus whatever money he got once he started streaming) finally arrive, Mydei wears them and immediately decides they're far too heavy, yet he keeps them and uses them as often as he can, anyway.

Phainon could recognize him anywhere. From more than the curve of his waist and the strong of his back, but from the jagged piercings he'd done and the wonky braid of his hair. He'd recognize the marks of the life they've built, the history of what they now have.

And so even before they turn around, in a sea of people he doesn't know, he can already tell that *this* is not Mydei.

Similar nose but brown eyes, the same shade of blonde hair but missing the braid and kept much longer without the red tips, the same cut of jaw and brows, but without the slight crook of his nose and tattoos on his skin.

But maybe most obvious of all, was that the person standing in front of him is no man at all. It was a middle aged woman, staring very funnily at him.

"Hello? Did you need anything?"

The roar of the crowd is deafening, loud and overbearing all at once after he finally snaps back and refocuses on what he's doing. Phainon blinks once, then twice, and before his brain shuts down from embarrassment he remembers that he is An Adult and should thus be respectful to his elders.

"Oh! Hi!" He blinks innocently, like he hadn't just stopped a random woman at a crowded convention after hallucinating that she was his roommate. "Sorry ma'am, I'd just meant to warn you that your shoelaces were untied!"

She blinks, then looks down on her flats, sleek and black and decidedly without shoelaces, and stifles a laugh. "Right. Of course. Are you concussed?"

"What makes you say that?"

He wishes the earth would swallow him up whole.

"Oh, nevermind me," she waves him off, "But that's okay, I need some help. Are you familiar with this place, dear? I've been trying to find the museum but I've been walking in circles. That directory hasn't been much help, either." She points at the map of the convention, jutting her thumb out.

Phainon looks over at the map. The museum itself was split into two– a convention center and the museum with a conjoined common area for headlining events. She must have gotten lost in the convention center, he realizes, maybe she was heading to the exhibitions area.

"Did you mean to head here?" He pulls out his phone, scrolling through a few images of the area, "That's the permanent exhibitions center, on the other wing of the complex. This here is for exhibitions."

The woman squints, before nodding to herself. "That sounds right, yes," she mumbles, taking out her own phone, "do you mind if I take a picture?"

Phainon has more decency than to judge technical inabilities, but sometimes he gets truly close to crossing his own morals. *Even seeing someone bad with technology is making me miss Mydei. Damn* . Withdrawals were hitting hard.

It wasn't even the first time it's happened. The last time Mydei worked overtime at the library after they'd received a new shipment of books, Phainon had to stop himself after spending five whole minutes on the sidewalk talking to an orange cat.

He'd only truly realized he'd been talking to an animal after the cat had scratched him once he'd finished his long-winded rant about why red was the obvious compliment to purple. Now, everytime he walks past it, the same cat with a scar under its eye and the most judgemental yellow eyes known to man, Phainon (scornfully) nods his head in acknowledgement. Its name from then on was Meow-dei.

"If you don't mind, I could instead walk you to the other wing? I wouldn't want you to be lost," he offers tentatively.

The woman hums contemplatively as she checks her phone and huffs. "That would be ideal. I'll be meeting with my son soon you see, he'd wait for me for hours, here. I haven't visited in a while."

Her admittance is coupled with a smile, slow and fond as she looks at her phone. It's an old thing, one camera, still with the chunky sides and her clear phone case yellowed, but there's a polaroid in the back, stained from its age. He can't see the picture from here, but he can tell it's a cherished photo.

"He sounds lovely," Phainon smiles as he pulls out his map, "the walk there isn't too far, so we can meet up with him soon, how's that?"

"Go on then," she says, prompting him to walk.

They make it for about three minutes before she starts again. "Ah, but he really is quite lovely. Sweet boy, loves history. He got our tickets, months in advance, and planned the whole thing. Isn't that cute?" She laughs, soft and bright.

Phainon's heart warmed. It was clear just how much the two loved each other, an infectious pride in how she carried herself, not worn with her age but truly living it. She seemed content– radiant, even. She must really love her son.

"I'm sure he is. He's picked a great spot. Okhema's National Museum is excellent– I've been here a lot with my roommate. You see, I quite like history, too. This place is a gem for artifacts, they've got them from all over Amphoreus!"

"Do they now? I wouldn't count myself a history buff, but I do love my tales. We better hurry up, better too early than late."

Phainon was deliberately slowing his pace, he didn't want to tire out the sweet middle-aged woman he'd just met, but in an instant she walked fast, fast enough to *outpace him* . Phainon looked in disbelief as he broke out into a jog to catch up to her.

As they walked, the crowd faded past as he kept track of the small of her back, and her shoulder length hair from behind, careful not to lose sight of her. She wasn't nearly as tall as him, nor did she have the same presence in each of her steps, but there truly was something

similar between her and Mydei. The same confidence in each step, the conviction for those that they loved.

Fuck. He's really pushing it. That was a stretch, even for him.

Phainon shook his head, waving the thought away. What mattered now was ensuring the sweet lady he just met doesn't get lost in the sea of convention goers, and gets to the more peaceful museum side safely. What matters even *more* though is being able to catch up, because even in flats and a long skirt, the woman manages to outpace him effortlessly.

When they finally make it past the booths and displays, the woman finally stops, waiting for him to catch up.

She laughs, almost to herself, "Trouble keeping up?" She says playfully.

"Hardly," Phainon laughs, though slightly out of breath, "Sorry I lagged behind, it seems you're much faster than I, ma'am."

"Oh stop it, a young man like yourself should have no trouble keeping pace. My son did the same as a child. And stop with calling me ma'am, boy, and stop apologizing. You remind me of my lawyers."

Phainon chuckled, rubbing the back of his neck sheepishly. "Habit! Sor-" he cuts himself off as the woman glares at him. He clears his throat, "Alright, what should I call you then, instead?"

The woman grins, like she's been expecting this.

"Why don't you hazard a guess, Phainon?"

Mydei doesn't often talk about his family, though Phainon's been able to piece together why.

His mother moved with him to Okhema, but these days she often lives in Castrum Kremnos a few hours away. His mother works with artifacts, and preserving their local culture, and is also, apparently, a better fighter than Mydei is.

Mydei's love of jewelry is from his mother, who has a collection of all their family's heirlooms. Her necklaces, rings and bracelets, the only things she'd gotten out of the divorce, along with custody of Mydei himself. He speaks of her fondly, his habits of cooking and gifting are remnants of how fiercely he's always been loved.

Once, on Phainon's 21st birthday, just around the time they'd moved in together, Mydei had introduced him to honeycakes and pomegranates.

Kremnoan culture was hard to come by in the Holy City. You'd see plenty of Janusapolian cuisine, Aidonian clothing and travel guides or even Styxian delicacies here and there, but little was known of Kremnos– only the persisting stereotype that Kremnoans were brutish, somewhat. Maybe that's why Mydei himself was so protective of his culture.

Despite this, the moment they'd moved out and after the little get-together they'd held with college friends, Mydei was the one who proposed to celebrate with his region's delicacies in the comfort of their new home. Handmade pomegranate juice, made with the fruits his mother had shipped straight to their apartment and the tallest stack of honeycakes he's ever seen in his life.

Mydei had laughed vindictively as Phainon's mouth soured, immediately trying to fix a shaky grin as he took a sip of the juice. "Wow- wow! *Cough,* that- that sure is something," he said, wheezing.

It was sour, floral in the way it felt like someone had shoved you face down into a field of them, overbearingly sweet while also not quite being sweet enough. It had a distinctly alcoholic taste to it that he's sure was more than just from the pomegranate. "What did you put into this?" He asks, groaning as he rests his head on their countertop in defeat. He really couldn't take another sip. There's no way that was just juice.

Mydei shoves him playfully eliciting protest as he finishes off the cup Phainon had drunk from, barely a reaction from him. "What a weak man you are, HKS. To think you'd be so easily defeated by juice."

"That's not fair," he groans, "you must've spiked my drink!"

Mydei scoffs, "So now you accuse me of being dishonourable?"

"I'm accusing you of being a *sadist,* that's what it is. What was in my cup? Don't tell me it's just juice, I don't believe you. It was alcohol, wasn't it? Whose? We don't keep liquor around the house."

"We've quite literally *just* moved in."

"And I packed over half those boxes. No alcohol, I can assure it!"

Mydei hums, topping off a different glass with the juice, but now adding a heaping pour of milk and ice cream and topping it with a bright pink twisty straw. He takes a sip, before nodding, satisfied, and sliding it back over to Phainon, who drinks it with a satisfied smile on his face.

"You packed *exactly* half, Phainon. I counted, don't get ahead of yourself. If you are concerned about alcohol around the house, I *had* received some, from my mother, she'd sent it along with the pomegranates."

"Aha!" Phainon exclaims, snapping his fingers as he gets up triumphantly, "So there *was* alcohol!

He slides dramatically over to Mydei's side to rest his head on his shoulder. If Mydei's played tricks on him he might as well get something out of it. It's his special day, surely he can get away with this much.

"Oh, dear Mydei, don't you know? My alcohol tolerance is painfully low. Any bit of alcohol would make me an inebriated man. Is that what you've gone for? To get me drunk? To see me act a fool on my birthday?"

Mydei shoots him a look, (gently) pushing his head away as he goes over to a cabinet and takes out a fine bottle of wine. One that is pointedly unopened. He shoves the bottle into Phainon's hands as he sighs. "Stop the dramatics, I *know* you dislike alcohol, but I'd asked my mother to send some anyway. It is traditional, in Kremnos, to gift such a thing to those you-" he cuts himself off, clearing his throat, "to those you care about." He finishes.

He coughs once again, averting his eyes, uncharacteristically shy. "I had not put any of this in your drink, no. The bottle should only be opened by you. It is your birthday after all."

A moment of silence. Mydei's words reverberate in his head, and he feels dizzy at the implication. A piece of Mydei's culture, a gift– more than a gift– *acknowledgement* from his mother. Phainon looks down at the bottle as he feels his cheeks warm.

"You got this for me?" He mutters.

"My mother wanted to gift you some other things as well. She's been meaning to meet you but…I haven't seen her in a while, either."

Perhaps that was the second time that Phainon wanted to kiss him.

The second of the hundred little times he'd felt like he'd found where he belonged.

He rests his forehead against Mydei's collar, noticing that he doesn't even have to strain his neck, since Mydei had tiptoed to meet him halfway. "...And *what* are you doing now?"

Phainon smiles against his sweatshirt, breathing in. Pomegranate, honey, wine and the bit of leftover smoke from their grill and potluck. He thinks of their old dorm and new apartment, and he thinks he's always been home.

"Nothing, I'm just thinking, can't you tell?" *I'm thinking about you. Always thinking about you. You haven't tired of me yet, right?*

Mydei scoffs. "Do you truly need me to answer that?"

Phainon laughs, shifting his head to rest his cheek, "Indulge me. It's my birthday, don't you know?"

"And if I were to say yes, then what? I pack my bags and move away?"

" You can't do that. Our lease isn't up until another half-year." *And you've already built a home here, anyway.*

“ I can move back to Kremnos. I’d live with my mother.”

“Kremnos doesn’t have Okhema’s libraries.” *And Kremnos doesn’t have me.*

“How full of yourself,” Mydei whispers, slow and teasing, sweet as pomegranate, as honey. The words shoot into his ear, through his veins and into his heart. It jumps around its caverns and makes it swell, and he feels entirely too small to contain it. “You must be drunk. Was the rum truly too much?” He mutters to himself, concerned.

Rum?

“Yes, rum. There was some of it in your drink. I hadn’t mentioned it because it should’ve been tame enough that even children could drink, but it seems I underestimated just how weak you are to alcohol.”

How weak I am to you, maybe.

“I will not deign that a response.”

But I love you. I really do. Won’t you say it back?

“It would not be the first time that I have. In words, or in actions. It’s just a shame you never remember when I do.”

I’llremmbr. I promise. Say it tome, please?

His words slush together. Phainon feels lightheaded, like all the queasiness had just hit him all at once, and he feels his eyes slip closed.

He hears a sigh, and feels himself get picked up. He feels his back hit the soft of his bed, and the sounds of the lights switching off. And he hears, infinitely far away yet just beside him nonetheless, a whisper, a promise, “*I love you too, idiot.”*

When he wakes up the next day, tucked into bed and with a glass of water by his bedside and a killer headache, Mydei shrugs and tells him that he’d passed out once they’d gotten home.

“Miss…Gorgo.”

“Oh please, Gorgo is fine. Haven’t I told you to drop the formalities?”

Phainon rubs the back of his neck, sheepish. “Gorgo, then! It’s an honour to finally meet you! Mydei– well, Mydei doesn’t talk that much as a whole, but he speaks of you fondly!”

Gorgo chuckles at his eagerness. She could imagine a tail wagging behind him, excitedly speaking of her son, “Likewise. I’d recognize you since you stopped me. Mydeimos had

often spoken of his roommate– white hair, blue eyes, sun tattoo. That wasn't quite how he'd described it, but that much is what I'd remembered." She smiled.

"He spoke of me?" Phainon's eyes glinted.

It was obvious he did. He would not have received birthday wine or well wishes if Mydei hadn't, but the affirmation was always nice.

"All good things. Well," she stopped herself, "mostly, at least."

There were a million things Phainon wanted to say to her. To tell her she'd raised such a wonderful son. To speak to her about Mydei, to find out about what makes him the man he is now. To exclaim how he was grateful that he was allowed to live with him, to have this infinitely small but incredible place by his side.

To thank her for the wine, for her words, for the man who reminds him of how much love there is and how much love you could feel from just being, from just *living* with someone else. Like sweets, like pomegranates, like earrings, unpractical but treasured.

Phainon was happy for all but five minutes, before the crushing realization dawned on him.

Wait. Mydei actually is here?

He was here for his mother. Or, He *will* be here for his mother. But that also means he'd be here. During the panel. He'd be here, while Phainon's being grilled for questions about the Mystery Man. He'd be here while he and his *Mother* could see Phainon sputter and blush and make a fool of himself trying to divert away questions of his not-lover and not-quite-roommate.

Oh.

Oh *fuck.*

The thought dropped on him heavy like a rock. No, like the world dropping on Kephale themself. Pre-orders for the museum must've been done weeks in advance. He couldn't have known, could he? There's no reason why Mydei would bring his mother if he'd just wanted to catch Phainon acting up. He could get away. *Mydei doesn't know yet.*

"Gorgo-"

"Oh, hold on, he's calling," she says as her phone rings softly, still set to its default ringtone, "I think he's arrived, now. Would you-"

"Sorry, Ma'am- Miss- uh, Gorgo! You're lovely and your son is lovely but I have to go now! Have a nice visit *andpleasestayoutoftheconventioncenterthankyou-"* Phainon says, all in one breath as he started running. He wasn't running from his problems, no, his running was *solving* his problems. That being of exposing his (very well hidden) affection.

He ran, fast as he could, to blend in back into the crowd and back to the VIP lounge.

He really wished he had his disguise right now.

The lounge was locked. Of course it was, because the universe loved playing tricks on him.

Phainon groaned as he banged his head on the door in a strange attempt at a knock. To whom? He doesn't know, either. Maybe the gods would unlock the door from the other side. The staff looked at him with a confused expression.

"...Deliverer? Are you trying to access the lounge?"

"Yes, actually," he said cheerily, immediately fixing his best Polite Streamer Persona. The large red mark on his forehead the only indication of his impromptu head-banging. "Good sir, could you let me in? I left my camera there."

"The lounge had already been emptied by security, any personal belongings should be over there," he narrowed his eyes as he pointed at a shelf, packed with carefully labeled tubs of items. Even from here, it was clearly visible that his name was not on any of the tubs.

"You must've missed my camera, then. It's quite small you see, I'd left two in there– one under the couch and another up on the dressing room mirror."

He knew how deplorable he must sound with that description. But he was getting desperate, okay?

"Sir…why were those cameras left in unreachable places?"

"It's for content, I promise!"

The staff seemed to consider calling security on him, hand halfway to his walkie talkie, but decided against it, sighing. "Look, man, I don't know what to tell you but the lounge is closed, okay? I'd get fired if I let anyone in."

"Even if it's me?"

"*Especially* if it's you, dude. Miss Aglaea would kill me."

"Not even for five minutes?"

"Just get out." He said, before tacking on, "Please."

Phainon sighed. He might be cooked.

CASTORICE AT COMICCON!! *@DailyCastorice* **- 2h ago**

My goat BODIES everyone (even GoldenWeaver) at the impromptu smash tourney iktr 🤭

[Attached clip: Castorice, on her last stock, playing as Sephiroth against Aglaea's Princess Peach. Castorice seems to pull off an impressive combo, racking up 151% damage immediately as she links into a stun, ending the game.

Aglaea sighs, smiling as the two shake hands and their audience erupts into cheers. Castorice is given a paper crown as she's heralded champion by an excitable crowd.]

41K ***13.5K*** ***87.4K***

> **PerKali.** *@V1beLvr* **- 1h ago**
>
> No bcs how did she beat MKLEO ON JOKER 😭😭😭
>
> ***651*** ***2.9K*** ***21.3K***
>
> > **seasonednotcooked** *@SaltLord* **- 1h ago**
> >
> > His byleth is better btw he went easy on her
> >
> > ***728*** ***1.3K*** ***5.2K***
> >
> > > **PerKali.** @ V1beLvr **- 30min ago**
> > >
> > > Dude stfu
> > >
> > > ***81*** ***923*** ***3.8K***
> >
> > **seasonednotcooked** *@SaltLord* **- 20min ago**
> >
> > why r yall booing me im right
> >
> > ***137*** ***1.1K*** ***2.7K***

BUTTERKIXnFLIPS *@kixxykissy* **- 1h ago**

YOU DROPPED THIS QUEEN 👑

542 ***2.2K*** ***10.5K***

> **WITH MY YUME** *@fuyumeyumi* **- 1h ago**

THE BURGERKING AAH CROWN

203 ***1.1K*** ***4.9K***

ThonyIsCool **@***ThonyIsntCool* **- 1h ago**

Castorice your talents are wasted vtubing PLEASE go pro PLEASE

620 ***3.8K*** ***16.1K***

rosemarryme? @*rosemary* **- 15min ago**

Staged. They js ended fast bcs their panel is starting.

419 ***2.3K*** ***1.8K***

KerisGQris @*CowokGergaji* **- 2h ago**

YALL I FOUND THIS RLLY HOT GUY AT COMIC CON ANJIR JUST LOOK AT HIM

[Attached image: Taken from afar, slightly standing above the crowd, is a man in a black facemask and tattoos wandering around the convention center. He is wearing a fitted black t-shirt and white pants tied at the waist. His hair is in a bun.]

49K ***29.5K*** ***131K***

KerisGQris @*CowokGergaji* **- 1h ago**

omg a. hit tweet.

290 ***451*** ***1.1K***

JackofnoTrades @*callmejoker* **- 1h ago**

IS THAT-

124 ***2.1K*** ***15.3K***

CRACKMYBACK @*scoliosisqueen* **- 30min ago**

THE TOJI FIT?!

817 ***7.2K*** ***19.6K***

FAILING MY EXAMS YOO *@trelelelelel* **- 1h ago**

WOOFWOOFWOOFWOOFWOOWFWOOF

199 ***8.4K*** ***21.3K***

Working this Summer!!! *@F3nF3ss* **- 1h ago**

Jan?? why r u tweeting this in class??

1.5K ***10.3K*** ***32.4K***

“Are you *sure* I can’t-”

“No.”

“Just once?”

“No.”

“Are you going to say no to everything I say?”

“No.”

“Aren’t you creating a loophole?”

“Yes.”

“What the hell?”

“You’re still going on the panel.”

“It seems Aglaea has outsmarted you, Phainon.”

“Oh, shut it already.”

Phainon groans, head in his hands as the two laugh, Castorice motioning for a high five which Aglaea reciprocates. The sound reverberates as his face falls, affronted. “You never high five me,” Phainon mutters in betrayal. Aglaea always leaves him hanging.

Aglaea simply shrugs. “It’s much funnier that way.” Phainon responds with a whine. It seems the universe wasn’t done throwing him through the ringer.

They were 10 minutes off from starting the panel, readying up backstage as the crew of the astral express were still continuing theirs. They were talking about something serious, he thinks. About their recent hiatus when one of their members had fallen ill. It was quite

saddening, really, he'd heard about it from Stelle a few months back. But she was back and on her feet and the Astral Express couldn't be happier that she was alright.

He'd be glad too, of course, to have a dear friend back and by his side again.

And then he remembers the situation he's in and half feels like he wants to cry. *I just wanna go home, damn.*

Castorice shuffled to Aglaea's side, watching Phainon crouch to his knees, holding his head in his hands, unprompted. "Do you wager he's thinking about his roommate again?"

Aglaea smiles, excited and satisfied. Which means her right lip ticks up slightly more than her usual placid smiling expression. "I know so. He's having withdrawals."

"Withdrawals?" She echoes.

Aglaea nods, "After over 15 hours (including time asleep) without meeting Mydei, Phainon starts magically associating everything he meets with the man. A wonderful mind, truly creative once he gets like this."

Castorice's eyes widened. "Could this be the origin of Meow-dei?"

"Indeed. As well as Blub-dei, Yourdei, Seal-dei, and even Bird-dei."

"*Yourdei?* His gamer tag on Roblox?"

"That very one, yes."

"His naming sense is…appalling."

Aglaea does not snort, but she comes very close to doing so. She gets closer to Castorice, whispering like she's sharing some dirty secret. "He's even named those hideous shoes of his. He calls them his Wario shoes."

"Are you making fun of my *children?"* Phainon gasps.

Castorice grimaces, a little disbelieving, a little cringe as she silently nudges Aglaea by the shoulder for support. Aglaea rests her hand on the small of her back, reassuring. "Phainon, how old are you this year?"

"No personal questions, please."

"He means to say he's closer to 30 than he is to 20."

"Aglaea??? That's uncalled for!"

"But it is not untrue. Though there is nothing to be ashamed of. I'm sure your partner will love you even in your old age."

Phainon shakes his head furiously. Perhaps if he shakes his head fast enough, the red of his blush might not be visible. All that it does now is make him look like a dog, though, shaking to rid itself of water when soaked. “There is no partner! I have no idea what you’re talking about.”

Aglaea looks unimpressed. Castorice, too, gives him the signature Judgemental Eyebrow. Phainon has long gone past the point of shame, but he is not *immune* to judgement, either.

“You do not know the man I am referring to? The one who bought you a wine that costs over 500,000 credits? The one who babysits with you? The one you ogle on a regular basis? The one you box and go on dinner dates with? Tell me, Phainon, does none of this ring a bell?”

“Oh, you mean my roommate! Yeah, okay, we do that. Who says that means we’re dating?”

“Phainon. I know, for a fact, that you are not this stupid.”

“You might want to reconsider that, Aglaea. This might be his truest self.”

“Alright, damn! I’m right here, you know!”

After a few soundchecks and the panel being extended for longer than expected, Phainon excuses himself to brush off his nerves. He *could* go to the backstage bathroom, private for all but the staff and other panelists, but he’d rather go somewhere truly alone for what he’s doing next.

Aglaea had shoved a black face mask and hat towards him just to be sure that the staff wouldn’t catch him sneaking out backstage. Though his shoes were probably the most noticeable feature of him at the moment, he’d thanked Aglaea for her insight anyway.

And so he reaches the bathroom by the common area, thankfully empty as everyone had headed inside for the panels, and sighs as he stares at himself in the mirror.

Despite graduating with a major in psychology, Phainon can’t say that he was a truly *scientific* person.

Sure, he knows the facts and the theories and that sleep and exercise and healthy social contact are the best ways to manage stress. But they’re also honestly the most boring ways to handle stress. Personally, he prefers an alternative method.

Phainon looks in the mirror. Really, truly looks at his reflection, and starts:

“I am worthy, I am capable, and I am *not* going to make a fool of myself on that panel.”

Externalizing one’s thoughts through mirror-talk was, in some ways, also a scientifically backed method. While it might sound like pseudoscience, Self-Talk actually was researched quite some time ago.

Wherein participants were hooked up to electroencephalographs and told to narrate themselves. Interestingly enough, the brain had recovered faster from negative experiences through narration. The paper was a point of research that stuck with him.

“I am kind, I am confident, and I am only half an idiot.”

And really, it was quite rational to be speaking like this to oneself. Shame was the bane of all those who wished to improve themselves. And thus, there was no shame in speaking thoughts in any way at all.

“I am *NOT* the worst at smash, I am *NOT* cooked, and I trust myself to act accordingly up on stage.”

…He really was glad that the bathroom was empty, though.

He sighed a final time, splashing his face with water as to thoroughly rinse the embarrassment off his face. He hadn’t done this in a while. Not since his finals at college all those years ago, and not since he was caught conversing with Meow-dei by the real Mydei himself.

“Could you move over? I’m trying to reach the tissues.”

“Oh, of course, sorry,” Phainon replied instinctively, reaching towards the tissues and back, before dropping them on the ground.

The paper towels dropped like his heart did, like the decisive ring of a midnight bell, like the slam of exam papers on a desk. It felt final. The last nail in a coffin.

Staring back at him, wide-eyed, mirroring his own expression, were the golden eyes he’d recognize anywhere.

The braid, still neatly done, because he wasn’t the one to do it this morning, and the same, jagged holes on his lobes.

“ *Mydei?”*

Here, in the flesh.

“Aglaea, are you *sure* he’ll be back in time?” Castorice mutters worriedly, pacing.

Castorice must be worried about the panel missing one of its main stars. Aglaea, however, was worried for an entirely different reason. ‘*Would this plan fail, once again?’*

The plan was done on a whim. A fortunate combination of a myriad of little factors.

Firstly, that Mydei and Phainon were both to be present in a reasonable distance, though the two were unaware. Phainon was, of course, to join Comic Con and spend his day there, but it was Mydei who was the surprise.

He'd contacted Aglaea months prior, asking for recommendations on where his mother, a relic appraiser, might be interested in visiting in Okhema. Aglaea, already working on Tribios' appearance at Comic Con at the time, knew the opportune moment was right then and there.

And thus began the first stage of her plan.

The finer details would be tuned in time. It just so happened that neither had told the other about their day plans, and where exactly the two were headed. From then on, it was simple just to orchestrate when they'd meet and how. This panel? The perfect stage for their finale.

Of course, that's only if and when the *both of them* finally show up.

"Call it off! Please, Aglaea, I swear– *call it off."*

Speak of the devil.

"Phainon. You know I don't have the authority to. The event is in place, already. The Astral Express is giving its closing remarks. We, quite literally, cannot call it off."

"Aglaea," he huffs, staring straight at her, "you don't understand. He's *here."*

'Of course. I'd told him to come to the common area.'

"Who?" She tilts her head, feigning innocence.

"You *know* who."

Aglaea met his gaze head one, unflinching. "Phainon, despite what you believe of me, I am not omniscient."

It was at that moment that the crowd cheered, waving goodbye as the Astral Express' crew headed back stage, staff already cueing them to get ready as their MCs called upon the three of them.

"Aglaea," he mutters, "I am *not* going on that stage."

StrawBEREE *@beriberi* **- 1h ago**

Obligatory thread to talk about the panel

2.3K ***6.5K*** ***20.4K***

> **#1_Phainon_Stan** *@DailyDeliverer* **- 1h ago**

I felt lied to bro DELIVERER WASNT EVEN THERE

1.8K ***2.9K*** ***10.1K***

Avary's Going to Comic Con!! *@LowlyFan* **- 1h ago**

“Emergency matters” WHAT EMERGENCY…girl

213 ***1.1K*** ***7.4K***

justheretbh **@***pj_1864* **- 1h ago**

deliverer aside. castorice’s innocent smile while explaining ssbu mechanics is driving me insane shes so ????

201 ***3.4K*** ***8.2K***

> **StrawBEREE** **@***beriberi* **- 1h ago**
>
> FR MY GAY ASS WAS NAWTTT LISTENING
>
> ***89*** ***1.2K*** ***5.1K***

BIGFRIES **@***nahstillsmallfries* **- 45min ago**

aglaea,,,save me,,,aglaea talking abt tribios,,,save me,,,

32 ***298*** ***1.9K***

KerisGQris **@***CowokGergaji* **- 2h ago**

UPDATE!!! I saw him at the panel again but he left before it ended ;–; I was gonna ask for his @ but ohwell…i wonder why he walked out mid panel…

[Attached image: Slightly blurry, blocked out by a crowd, but the man was still visible, standing taller than the rest. He seemed to be turning around, trying to navigate outside of the crowd. In the background, the large LED screens were, apparently, playing recent streamer’s clips and popular weekly TikToks.]

4.3K ***18.2K*** ***64K***

sowhatomfg **@***khiaasem* **- 1h ago**

isnt it weird that yall take pics of this dude w/o his consent js bcs hes hot or am i just # toowoke

3.1K ***5.4K*** ***7.9K***

Biaaa @S*BbeFREE* - 1h ago

he’s literally blurred AND wearing a mask

821 ***6.4K*** ***7.6K***

VermaCelli @*yesthenoodles* - 1h ago

The way ur lowk right tho

349 ***2.6K*** ***4.5K***

Sam is Tired @*samycircles* - 1h ago

The real question is how deliverer is feeling after # THAT clip played on the big screens bro…

981 ***4.9K*** ***10.1K***

For once, he did not wait for Aglaea’s permission. No, he hadn’t even really *asked* for permission at all. Phainon called a cab, one that led straight home, and hadn’t turned back.

He makes it a rule that whenever his streaming persona is in deep shit, he makes sure not to check tweeter. In fact, he doesn’t check his socials at all. But it seems he’s breaking all his rules today, slumped in the back seat of his Uber, he reads and reads all the live-tweets going on at the event, stopping on one post in particular.

A silhouette. A distinctly Mydei shaped silhouette, watching the clip of him actively *ogling his arms,* to be exact.

Phainon groans like a dying animal, shutting off his phone. His driver eyes him warily.

“Tough day?”

“You don’t even *know*, man.”

The driver shakes his head sympathetically. “What, you got broken up with through text or something? Wouldn’t be the first time I’ve driven home heartbroken passengers. You look just like ‘em, you know. Dejected expression. Minutes away from throwing that phone out the window. Please don’t, by the way. I’ve gotten sued for that twice, I know the signs.”

Heartbroken wasn’t even the right word to put it.

“...I didn’t get broken up with,” is all he says, not sure what part of the man’s statement to reply to. He replies something anyway, a vain attempt to keep the conversation going,

anything to distract him from the inevitable. He leans his cheek against the car window, watching the lights pass by.

The driver snorts. “And I’m supposed to believe that? You look pathetic, man. ‘Ya girl must’ve left you. Or your guy. This car’s seen a lot of shit, you know?”

Phainon decides not to lean on any more surfaces after that.

“My guy’s mad at me,” he mutters, “I hope I die.”

“Hoo boy, we’ve got a dramatic one we got tonight. Fun. Tell me ‘bout it, kid. We’ll be stuck in traffic for a bit, and I’m not turning on that radio.”

He doesn’t know why, but for once, he actually does. He spills his guts to a sketchy 3.2 rated uber driver who seems far too nosey about people’s love lives. He tells him all about the love, all about the not-dates and almost-kisses. The things he doesn’t tell Aglaea, or Castorice, or himself even, in the mirror.

He spills it all until he forgets that the backseat he’s sitting on has, apparently, been the spot for many sloppy makeouts and things he doesn’t even want to think about. The driver simply laughs, eyeing him from the rearview mirror.

“You’re an idiot, kid. You’re dumb and in love. Good for you, though. Good for you.”

“*That’s* what you got from all of this?” He stares, conflicted.

The driver simply shrugs, “What more could I say? You love him, he loves you, ya’ll have an apartment together and he’s good with kids and cooks you dinner. All that domestic sappy shit. You talked about his eyes for like, five whole minutes. Aren’t ya’ll dating, already? You even met the guy’s mom, y’know.”

“And? I’ve known him for years. *Years*. He’s never made a move on me. If he really did like me, wouldn't he have confessed?”

“*You* haven’t. And you’ve loved the guy since you met him, basically. Come on now, don’t be dense.”

“It’s not that simple,” he replies, grasping at straws, grasping at *something,* “it *can’t* be that simple. I bring nothing to the table! And he’s, like, at least a full spread of takeout!”

“You seriously suck at describing things, kid. I assure you, that is *not* the kind of thing that would woo anyone. Stick the shitty names to your birds and cats, not to the guy you like.”

“He calls me a scoundrel!”

“In his native language. That is dying, and dear to him. How aren’t you picking up what he’s laying down? He’s totally into you!”

“But-” Phainon…doesn’t really have a reply to that. So he cuts himself off, and lets the words linger.

Honestly, he's never really entertained the idea of Mydei reciprocating in any way. It felt… too good for him.

It felt like too much. How could he bear the affection of the man who's built his whole world? How could he handle the weight of his trust, of his heart, of his smile? He couldn't do that. He- he's not even sure Mydei would let him do that.

"But he's *him.* I'm just me. How'd I know I can make him happy? How'd I know he'd be happy with *me?"*

"You're asking that to me? God, you better tip me for this. All this advice ain't free, hope you know that."

Phainon sighs. "Help a guy out here, man."

"For free? In this economy?"

"Whatever, you stuck into my business in the first place!"

The driver cackles, but doesn't respond. Not until the streets start being familiar again and Phainon recognizes the streetlights, the roads, the shrubs he and Mydei always stop by to play with the stray cats.

"Ah, we're here. See? Told 'ya it's a good way to pass the time."

Phainin blinks, realizing that they had, indeed, arrived at his complex. It's gotten later than he expected, the roads basically all empty, but he knows that Mydei, at least, hasn't gone home yet. He must still be at the convention center, or with his mom.

If he's lucky, he won't have to address any of this tonight. Yet as Phainon motions to open the door, the hinges don't budge. It's locked.

"Um," he pauses, trying to open the door twice more, "This is my stop. You can drop me off now."

The driver paused, looking back at him. "Hey."

Being cornered with a middle-aged man in his uber at whatever hour this was *really* wasn't on his bingo list.

"Hi?"

"I'm not letting you out this car."

"What the *fuck* ?"

"*Until* you promise you're going to kiss that man. Tonight."

What.

“I don’t care if ya’ll date afterwards. I don’t care if he’s weirded out, after. But y'all gotta kiss. Touch lips. The whole shebang, you hear me? You’ll regret it if you don’t. Trust me. He’s not gonna wait forever.”

Phainon can’t believe this is happening. That he’s getting advice from a driver with less than 4 stars on a ride that already costs him a hundred thousand credits.

What the *fuck?*

The driver looks at him, face shadowed in the dark, eyes piercing like he knows more about Phainon than just the anecdotes he’s told him. Phainon’s heart stutters despite himself. If he were any other man, he’s pretty sure he’d be scared shitless.

“I see why you’re rated so low now.” He mutters.

“Heh. And what does that say ‘bout you to be matched with me, huh?”

Phainon grimaces as the driver laughs, full, loud and satisfied.

“Don’t worry, I ask customers to rate me low all the time. People like you don’t really show up for high rated drivers, and I want the gossip more than I want some gold star on my app.” He says as the car door clicks, opening.

“Better make do on that promise, kid. Trust your senior on this, won't you?”

“We’ll see about that,” he says, shutting the car door. “I’ll tip you if we end up kissing. Our chat should still be accessible 24-hours after this ride.”

The driver grins straight at him, like he already knows what’s gonna happen.

“You better tip me regardless, and give me one star if it works out. You best be grateful to me, after, since I helped you snag a pretty damn good boyfriend. Good luck tonight, lover boy. Stay safe.”

And he drives off as Phainon huffs, stepping into his building. He’ll see if he ends up tipping tonight.

Waiting for Mydei to come home is like waiting for the other shoe to drop. The wait of an execution, the countdown for an inevitable doomsday clock.

Okay, maybe nothing that dramatic, but his heart is leaping out his chest while his face is stuck in forced nonchalance.

Phainon is in his room, pacing, thinking of how exactly he’ll explain this. He knows three things:

1. Mydei, unquestionably, has seen Phainon *drool* over his arms on camera. If he's unlucky, Mydei could have also seen the other clip of Phainon blushing at the mere mention of his roommate.

2. Unless Mydei is choosing to be obtuse: he must know that Phainon is attracted to him. The clips are proof. Literal, undeniable proof of this.

3. Whatever reaction Mydei has or had must be strong enough that he'd walk out of the panel immediately. To chase after him? To meet back out with his mother? That part's up in the air, but it was certain that he had some kind of visceral reaction to the news.

Phainon's not sure what exactly that means for *him* , but all spelled out like this, it does make him worry. Is this really the time to confront this?

The door creaks open, and he freezes.

The thing about routines, is that once you've gotten used to them, it's near impossible not to notice the slight differences in one's habits. Their door, for example, has been creaky ever since they moved in. It was heavy, slightly too heavy for the frame, but just costly enough that they'd think twice to replace it.

In the end, it became a permanent fixture of their house.

Whenever one of them comes home, they'd knock the door first, twice, before creaking the door to enter. They'd do so as a prior warning, ensuring that no one would be spooked with the sound of their door scratching against the flooring.

Afterwards, they'd drop their keys by the side of the door, right on the holder they kept there, and the sounds of their shoe cabinet would accompany this routine.

Tonight, Mydei does none of that. What he hears instead is the furious stomping of a man who's never broken routine before.

"HKS," he growls out. "You ran away. *Why?"*

"Before you say anything!" Phainon raises his arms, trying for unthreatening, "you get to punch me. Or we can fight, whatever you want. I deserve it, I know, but-"

Mydei jumps at him. No, he lunges, tackling him to the ground, caging him in.

"Do you really know what you've done? Do you understand what's just *happened?"*

"Um. You saw the clip?"

"*Everyone saw the clip."*

"...And are you mad at what I said?" Phainon tries. He doesn't know if he wants to hear his answer.

“Am I mad*? Mad?* Phainon, you confessed to me via *TikTok.* How the fuck did you expect me to respond?”

Mydei leaned in, the heat of him almost burning from where his hands caged either side of his head.

He could feel the slight warmth of him. Mydei always ran hotter than most, but he was uncharacteristically warm. He must’ve ran up the complex and through the halls to get here, working up a sweat.

He gulps. "I'm sorry if I made you uncomfortable-"

"*Uncomfortable?"*

"If you want to move out. If you *ever* want to move out because of this. I'll help you find a new place. And lease it. And. And whatever. I'll do it, okay? I'm sorry if I weirded you out."

Mydei leans down, slamming his palms on either side of his head once more.

"Don't even *entertain* that idea. You dare? You dare drop such a confession on me and leave me *alone?* I could not reply. I could neither reject nor accept you. What a coward you are, HKS. A *Coward."*

It is admonishment, not rejection. All the blood is rushing to his head, to his heart, pumping fast like a chase, like a hunt, like he's getting close to something once thought as unobtainable.

"Your mother," he says, "has she-"

"I've parted with her. I called a cab. Stop changing the subject and *answer me. Did you mean what you said?"*

“Mydei,” he repeats again. He needs an answer, he needs to know. Even if it burns him, even if he doesn't know what to do with himself after. This is Mydei, this is him. “*Mydeimos.* Are you mad at what I said?” (*Are you mad at what I've done? Are you repulsed by me?)*

“Are you kidding? Are you *stupid?* How much more do I have to spell it out!?” (*Tell me. Tell me, please, while I still have the courage to ask.)*

“And if I do? If I need you to tell me, to remind me, every day. Would you?” (*Would you stay for this? For me?)*

Mydei growls, backing away like he’s been burned. The tension sizzles in the air as Phainon sits up. Waiting. Watching.

“You are an idiot. A *scoundrel*. A Hyena in everything but form . ”

He says, and the punch he throws after feels almost like nothing compared to the weight of his next words. “Fight me. You don’t get to demand anything from me. Not *like this.”*

And Phainon could not do anything but oblige.

This wasn't like the ring. Controlled, spacious. A place made for violence, sleek floors and safety bars and a first aid kit always in reach. Here, in the space they've carved as theirs, on their carpets and beholden to the walls that they call home, they fought, not like fighters, but like strangers.

It wasn't the dance they'd go on when they box. Calculated trades and blows and jabs. Another form of routine, every step, another beat of familiarity.

No, this was wild. Phainon doesn't know how it started, who's thrown the first punch after Mydei's declaration, whose body ends where and whose leg is stuck on whose. They fought like a mess, like they've never fought each other before, not like this.

Sometime during their tousle, Phainon ends up on top of him, a mirror of the last time they'd boxed, both of them panting and tired from the exertion, from the *thinking*.

"Mydei," he starts again. "I haven't heard an answer."

(Please. I don't think I can wait.)

Mydei doesn't respond.

Because this is unlike the gym, unlike the ring.

Mydei never loses, not really. He's a better fighter than Phainon is, he *knows* that. The times when he wins are the times Mydei chooses to submit. And this time, he does not *want to*.

He slams his knee into Phainon's stomach from where he lays on the ground. Phainon had no hope to dodge it at all. He hacks, and coughs, as Mydei tackles him once more, bringing him to the ground, firmly below him.

"A hundred wins." He says. He does not smirk, nor is he triumphant and it dawns on him that this was more than a fight, more than a spar. "Loser takes the winner out," he simply says it as a reminder, a choice.

Phainon blinks dazedly. The side of his lip, he knows, is split. Probably the result of a punch he'd failed to dodge, or a kick he hadn't paid attention to. Mydei, in contrast, looks only slightly out of breath. He's heaving, purple marks on his neck and arms, bruises blooming from where he'd gotten contact.

He's beautiful.

Even like this, Phainon thinks he loves him.

"Mydei," he breathes. Just to say his name. Just to acknowledge that he's here, that this, if nothing else, is real.

Mydei opens his mouth, then closes it, and before he can get anything out, Mydei crashes his lips onto his.

Phainon's eyes widen, scrambling to reach out, to anchor himself, to anything. His hands hover around Mydei's hips, his shoulders, his sides, unsure of where to hold him where his fists haven't already. He doesn't want to agitate his bruises.

Mydei growls against him, slotting himself against Phainon's hands and arms where he hesitates. Phainon tastes like blood. Mydei, like honey. The split of his lip stings from where Mydeis canines scratch against it, but he cannot bring himself to mind.

It is intoxicating, warm, warm heat, from his mouth, from muscle, from his heart. From all of him, it is too much, yet not quite enough. Like the buzz of rum, of pomegranates, just enough to be enticing.

And in a moment too short for infinity yet too long for a second he pulls away. And Phainon is cold, not unbearably so, but cold enough to remember that for now, he is without heat.

"Dinner," Mydei pants from above him, "Your treat, anywhere, anytime. You choose, I don't care. Just take me somewhere nice, then ask me again, and make it *right.* I'll answer yes, everytime, however many times you ask. You know I will– you know I would have."

And he kisses him again, but it's Phainon who pulls him down. And he thinks that this time, he might allow himself to *take it.*

"Wherever I want." He echoes.

Can that be here? Can it be now?

"It's late," Mydei mutters against his lips, the heat of him never leaving his side.

Phainon's hands take his wrist, trailing the tattoos that swirl just by the end of his palm, cool fingers sliding against his forearm onto the line of tendon, skin and muscle. Not unlike a cuff, not unlike a chain. Mydei shivers at the contact, entirely too warm for it. Phainon isn't a selfish man. But maybe, he's been denying this for far too long.

"You promised me anytime, and I haven't eaten anything all day. Get changed. I'll take you somewhere nice."

"Are those your Wario shoes?" Mydei asks, eyeing Phainon's choice in footwear.

"My favourite ones," he smiles.

Mydei scoffs, looking away, a faint blush on his cheeks. "Just because I bought them for you doesn't mean you have to keep them. I bought it as a joke. Aren't you embarrassed?"

"Throwing out perfectly good shoes is unethical, Mydei. And besides, I only wear them on special occasions. Surely this is special enough?"

The only good restaurants that opened this late that'd accept them without reservation were high-end bars and the like. Phainon had googled expensive bars in the area, chosen a spot that had private booths, and decided on that.

When he'd called an uber, and matched with the *same* 3.2 rated man he had before, he had to begrudgingly tip him *twice* to stay quiet. The man's wiggled eyebrows spoke more than any words.

"Nice night out for a date, isn't it?"

"Shut up and drive." Phainon hissed. Mydei raised his brow. "Please?" Phainon tacked on hurriedly.

The driver cackled, saluting, as he resumed their drive. Once they'd arrived, and Mydei stepped out the car, he'd pulled the same door-locking trick as he winked at Phainon, full of smugness.

"I see those bruises on his neck," he wolf-whistled, "I said to kiss him, not maim the guy. You're more forward than I thought, kid. Good job. I knew you had it in you."

Phainon sputtered as a furious blush took hold on his face. "We haven't done that! I only kissed him! Twice!"

The driver looked at him, smirking, before pulling his ear closer. "*I got condoms in the back seat. Reach in if you need anyth-"* And that was when Phainon quickly unlocked the door, left, and slammed it for good measure. He rated him one star, both times, and left a fat couple thousand credits as a tip.

But aside from the car ride, the dinner had been fine.

Mydei had dressed up, wearing a high turtleneck in a vain attempt to cover up his suspicious looking bruises, fitted black slacks and a black coat, to match. He'd tacked on his usual jewelry, bracelets and necklaces, with the addition of his signature, golden earrings.

On the other hand, Phainon was wearing the only truly put together outfit he had, which still looked odd when paired with Mydei's all black ensemble.

He sported a white shirt, brown pants and a white flannel to tie it together. His injuries were mostly around his legs, chest, and stomach, so it wasn't as pressing to wear something high. The most glaring difference, though, was in their choice of footwear, Mydei's black and gold loafers against Phainon's purple-yellow sneakers.

Mydei snorted as the waiter arrived, bringing their drinks. For Mydei, a blood orange spritz and Phainon, a gin and tonic. "You're drinking tonight?" He raises his brow.

"Neither of us are driving," he shrugged, "who knows? It might be an acquired taste."

"What. You handle liquor worse than *children* do. The one time you tried beer in college, you threw up on Hyacine's floor."

“And I’m *still* a broke college student at heart,” Phainon said, hand to his heart, in one of the most expensive bars in Okhema, “but I’d like to think I’ve grown at least slightly since then.”

Mydei doesn’t respond, only shaking his head as he settles back into the booth.

The banter is nice. It’s welcome. A step back into routine, into something, somewhere more familiar. Phainon nudges his ankle, just to get a reaction out of him when Mydei seems to doze off prematurely. He usually doesn’t stay up this late, an early sleeper and early riser a part of the discipline ingrained within him.

Phainon scooches over so they’re sitting shoulder to shoulder, instead of facing each other, a much more familiar position for the both of them. Mydei is an amenable warmth on his right, the heat of him felt even through his layers of clothing.

He nudges him once more, just to get a reaction, and Mydei’s hand falls onto Phainon’s thigh to get him to stop his prodding.

“Aren’t you forgetting what we’re here for?”

“For dinner? For drinks? To spend time with each other, perhaps?”

Mydei gives him A Look, unimpressed, as he flicks his forehead. He leans against him, earring digging into Phainon’s shoulder, but he speaks not a word of protest.

How could he, when the bar’s low, golden lighting makes his eyeliner glitter like the sapphire of his earrings? His eyes, half-lidded and fluttering, stare at him under a sweep of lash. Devastatingly, the light shines warmth on the side of his cheek, his neck, the gold of his eyes and the shine of kiss-bitten lips.

“Quit staring. I can hear your brain from here. Turn it off.”

“I haven’t said anything!”

“You don’t need to. I already know.”

“Yeah?” Phainon challenges, “What could I be thinking of now?”

When mydei gazes up at him, slightly flushed, from the alcohol, from the lights, from the closeness of them this night, Phainon feels his heart leap out of his throat. “Me, of course,” a devastating smile, “likewise, I’m thinking of no one else.”

Tipsy Mydei is a *menace* .

“You’re drunk. Oh, titans, you’ve finished your drink already and haven’t eaten anything– no wonder you’re drunk! Alright, that’s enough of that, yep, okay. Stop- stop clinging to me, wait-”

If Mydei before was a weight on his side, *this* Mydei was a lion clinging on for dear life. Like Mufasa, maybe. And Phainon was Pride Rock.

“Mydei, I have water. Sober up, will you? This. This isn’t good for my heart.”

Mydei hand trails along his cheek, stopping just by his sun tattoo, just by the stuttering pulse on his neck, laughing soft as Phainon shivers. “I’m not nearly as drunk as you think I am, but the concern is touching, nonetheless. Come on now, get on with it. We have an agenda tonight, don’t we?”

“You can’t *seriously* expect me to confess while you’re *drunk* ?”

“Why not? I’ll remember. I know the limits of my body well. Ask me. I’ll still be yours by daylight.”

Who taught him this? Who taught Mydei to be *smooth* ?

Phainon gives in to the teenage urge to put his face into his hands and lie in the fetal position on the booth. He can feel his cheeks burning as he kicks his feet, giddy. He wants the ground to swallow him whole, yet he wants to immortalize this moment all the same.

“You’re a fiend. An absolute *fiend.* You say things that are bad for my heart. Do you not know how much I’ve wanted? How long I’ve waited for this? You can’t just. Just affirm it all, one night, out of nowhere. It’s not fair. I could’ve had this from the *start?”*

“You’ve never asked, and I’ve been waiting, for forever. I’ve told you this, at times, when you’re drunk and amenable. But you never listen. You rarely do.”

“What. What are you saying."

"I've confessed to you. Multiple times, while you were under the affects of alcohol. And you forget, in the mornings, every time."

"What? And you let me *do that?”*

Mydei shrugs, “Your sober self shirks off any acknowledgement of intimacy. What else was I supposed to do?”

“I don’t drink that often. I can’t possibly have done so much.”

“Phainon. My mother has insisted I gift you wine ever since your 21st birthday. Wine that *you* drink in the confines of our home, where no one but I am there to witness you. Believe me, I have tried confessing before. I have not found a way to get you to *remember.*”

“We could’ve been *dating.”*

“We’ve established that, yes.”

“And I’ve only realized that after inadvertently confessing via *TikTok?”*

“Heh. I suppose that’s true as well.”

“*Fuck me.”*

“I would not be opposed.”

“Fuck *you* , you can’t just say that.”

“I would also not be opposed. And I *can* just say that, because I’m sober and for once, *you’re* sober enough to be having this conversation as well. So get on with it, seal the deal, or whatever it’s called. I am a patient man, when it comes to you, but I am *not* waiting until your 26th to have another one of these conversations.”

Phainon gapes.

Mydei is staring at him with all the features of a drunk man– flushed eyes, flushed cheeks, the slight sway of his shoulders, but his eyes are clear as they always are. A trick of the light or a trick of the heart, he doesn’t know. But Phainon considers his options, pondering for a second, before throwing propriety out the window. *Fuck it.*

He kisses him, hard, blood orange and gin on his lips. He doesn’t like alcohol. Never will and never has, but *this* , this is addicting. Intoxicating. He could get drunk off Mydei alone. This is Phainon’s third kiss– all of his kisses have been Mydei, so he doesn’t really know how to compare, but his hands flit about, awkward.

He doesn’t know where to hold, doesn’t know where to look. His eyes? His nose? His lips? Or should he just keep his eyes shut, completely? That would be a waste, though. All of him is beautiful. He wants to treasure this. All of this.

“*Phainon,*” Mydei’s arms loop around his neck, dragging him down. “Ask me, already. *Ask.* With your words, not just your mouth or your tongue. It’s about time, is it not? I’m tired of waiting.”

“You could wait a little longer,” Phainon mutters against his lips. Hungry. He hasn’t eaten anything all day.

“*Animal.”* Mydei’s hisses as his hand comes to cover Phainon’s mouth. “You slobber all over me and you stink of gin. Confess while you’re sober. Anything else could wait.”

Phainon waves the thought away to lick Mydei’s palm, pressing a kiss to it instead, feather-light. “Mydei,” he starts, “Mydeimos. Love of my life.”

A snort.

“Would you do the honours of becoming my one and only?”

“I thought I was, already,” and he kisses him again, and Phainon laughs against his lips.

In the dark of their booth in a bar he doesn't care about, Phainon finally gets a boyfriend, he thinks. Maybe a boyfriend in name, just a label slapped onto what's already there. Maybe nothing much has changed. Not much has to, not much will.

He sighs, dreamy, as Mydei kisses his cheek, playful and satisfied all at once.

Getting to kiss him is a sweet bonus, though.

Chapter End Notes

A/N: [confetti] kiss!

12k words of self indulgence. i love phaidei and i love smash and i love when they kiss. so they kiss a lot. i think im ready to pass out (ive been awake for over 30h now, sorry for the typos) bcs this took me a LONG time to churn out (finals can kiss my ass) so im so so sorry its late!!! thank the long weekend i managed to finish.

this is. probably my favourite chapter ive written so far. it was originally gonna be split in two but i couldnt leave you guys on a cliffhanger. i love yall too much for that. so heres a doubly long chapter instead.

next chapter is their dating arc!! fun. cant promise when it comes out, but once this finishes ill surely be writing more phaidei, so do be on the lookout! it will either be fluffy oneshots or an angst timeloop fic im still working out. tell me which one youd prefer i come out with first haha.

thank you all for the support, you guys are absolutely incredible and im overwhelmed that people actually read my fic. i love yall, hope you enjoyed!

Chapter 6

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"How do you equip items, again?"

"Oh, just press X. Wait- don't- not that one, that button is for crouching, hold on-"

Phainon is in the middle of what could possibly be his shortest stream yet, a do-over milestone he promised to make up for the time he flaked during ComicCon's panel. The streamer is sitting in his usual setup, darkened chair in a hoodie, a webcam to his face.

But there was someone else, another chair, just out of frame. Just enough to show a well-defined, muscled shoulder almost awkwardly gripping the controller.

His goal was to resume his initial promise of clearing Dire Souls, another 24-hour stream since the failure of his first one. Only this time, with a special guest to shake things up. But barely half an hour in and somehow having made more progress than his previous two streams, Phainon thinks he'll run out of content far faster than he thought.

Because, for some ungodly reason-

LocalLateman : no way he just fucking beat nikador ARMORLESS???????

Mydei is unfairly good at games.

The screen flashes gold, white, and every colour of the damn rainbow as shiny holographic text pops up at him, '*Victory Achieved!'* Phainon squints, rubs his eyes, and gapes at the man beside him. He's genuinely forgotten that the screen could *look like that.*

shecticshe : HES LITERALLY T-BAGGING NIKADORKSKFSJSJSJJSESG

LowBloodSugar : r u sure ur roommates never played this before ???

atuilier : ok so hes good with his hands #YEP

lin_ling : so the greek god who just learnt the controls TODAY beats the loser whos attempted this over 200 times…oh deliverer you rlly r pathetic 😭😭😭

SalusTations : we spent 3 STREAMS on this you absolute BUM

ninpoart!yap! : look at our streamer dawg were cooked

arduiNOPE : KEKW KEKW KEKW KEKW KEKW KEKW KEKW KEKW

Bit4U : mr mystery man sir can you make a twitch acc pslsplsplspsl

*[@AddICKted has donated **1,111,111** credits: "IM…FREE…"]*

small_fries : Can i refund my superchats 💔💔💔 My goat is WASHED

NykoN3ko : pack it up yall its delivover 🥀

"How." Phainon says. ' *How did you beat him this easily? How did you win when you've never touched a controller before? How the hell are you good at literally everything you do?'* Phainon means to say.

Mydei, ever observant and fluent in reading between the lines, grins full of faux-innocence yet shit-eating at the same time. "What, like it's supposed to be hard?"

Because he is a *smug* bastard when he wants to be.

Nikador isn't actually the hardest boss, but he *is* one of the hardest and definitely the most challenging boss at this point of the game, where players have minimal items, barely any gear and are still lower leveled. Phainon knows that Casotrice, for example, reattempted Nikador the most out of all the bosses, even more than against The Flame Reaver or any other titans.

Phainon was genuinely fully prepared to reset his goal *again* to beating Nikador within 24-hours, if need be. But Mydei shatters all conventions, it seems, because how does a man who doesn't even have a Tweeter *do this?* It doesn't make any sense.

ruruville : IM CRYING LMFAOOOOOO

2bornawt2b : can someone get this guy off stream hes bad for my heart

*[@gawdDMN has donated **2,000,000** credits: "DROP THE @ DONT BE SHY"]*

Luwakey : @Deliverer how tf did u find this dude wtf… 😂😂😂

emma! : mom can i get a roommate like this too

ana_diva : WHO THE FUCK JUST DONATED 2 MIL ???????

DoorJezus : walks on stream beats the boss weve been struggling against for A WEEK and is smug and hot as hell KING SHITTTTTT 👑

ana_diva : IN THIS ECONOMY ???

*[@KisoroV has donated **80,000** credits: "sm1 get him off stream hes bad for my WALLET"]*

"I've never seen this many donos before," Phainon says, head in his hands as Mydei pokes on his cheek with the controller like a cat vying for attention. Phainon ignores him for the dramatics, "maybe it's high time I retire. You should take my place. Chat loves you more than they do me."

The chat replies, the most unified they've ever been, with a series of thumbs up and agreement. Mydei snorts, poking his cheek again, with his fingers this time.

“You’re being dramatic. Your chat loves you, probably.” He says with a shrug.

*[@ClicK has donated **40,000** credits: “LMFAO. no”]*

Well that was a fast answer.

Phainon smirks almost tiredly as Mydei blinks dumbfounded at the mildly rude superchat.

“You were saying?”

While Deliverer surely receives frequent and plentiful donations, it never was quite to this scale. His screen flashed with superchat after superchat, Google-translate voiceover overlapping. His mods were surely overwhelmed by now, he thought, slightly unbelieving. He should email them after this.

The chat continues on unceasingly.

It wasn’t the first time he’s had a guest over, but there really is something about Mydei that made his chat go ballistic, and it’s ticking him off, somehow. Who is *chat* to be cat-calling his *boyfriend?* Phainon is perfectly fine with fan service so long as he was the one doing the servicing. He does it intentionally, anyway.

But do they really think they could donate their way to getting Mydei’s attention?

Phainon leans back into his chair as the superchats slow down into a more humane speed, only then does he speak, “Chat. Honestly, I feel like you’re just spamming for the sake of spamming here,” he says, grinning just slightly dangerously, “getting this guy on was hard work, you know,” he chuckles.

Not a chance.

“I’ll raise the stakes: 50 mil. Else, he never shows up again.”

*[@HeroDivers has donated **8,000** credits: “CAP”]*

akishakis : this is EXTORTION

KLEPTkept : ??? DONT THREATEN US LIKE THIS

manohman : oh he has BILLS to pay

ZuZuWee : bro what

nightosphere : i mean tbh we did hit 80mil for charity last time

10SOY2 : 50 IS WILD…

Invisible to the camera, Mydei’s eyes narrow at Phainon’s self-assured laugh.

What is he doing? Does Phainon not actually want him to be on streams anymore? What ridiculous kind of demand is this? 50 million credits when all he’s done was press buttons

and make fun of Phainon for half an hour. Mydei says as much, with his eyes.

Through a potent glare and the two's own version of telepathy, Phainon already knows what Mydei is thinking.

He winks, "You underestimate my chat, dear *roommate* . You really think no one's gonna donate to the goal? Trust me, it's just like I said."

*[@SOL1D1FAE has donated **80,000** credits: "not 50 mil but every penny counts 🔥"]*

Thanatoes : andddddd it begins

*[@ooughcha has donated **200,000** credits: "TAKE MY MONEY DAMNIT"]*

*[@RiceToCas✔️ has donated **500,000** credits: "can this be a tax writeoff? ^^"]*

ooughcha : it's for a good cause!!!

KLEPTkept : um?????????????

Gloria_PD : this is an EGREGIOUS amount of money im ngl

InYoDex : @RiceToCas technically, this does qualify as a business write-off, so long as being a streamer is your officially registered occupation, applying for a deduction is not out of the question. You should consult with a taxing pr

*[@AbducTea has donated **90 , 000** credits: "well there goes rent for the month"]*

*[@DittoDitto has donated **30,000** credits: "mystery man know that were doing this 4 u"]*

ninpoart!yap! : LMFAOOOOOOOOOO

thatonecatchling : @GeniusSociety91 when the world needed her most, she vanished…

VeryTasTas : genius society is a woman?????????????

*[@karkawine has donated **69,696** credits: "you can drop more than js ur @ king 🙏"]*

InYoDex : ofessional or the local advisor in your district for personalized advice but you should keep proper documentation regardless so that you may substantiate any claims made on your tax return, additi

"Holy *shit."*

Mydei's eyes widen at the influx of messages and donations rushing in like they aren't the ones actively spending money on free entertainment. What the hell? The internet is *so* weird.

Phainon relaxes into his chair, the tips of his foot prodding against Mydei's own calves. He is wearing shorts, because of course he is, as Phainon is wearing his favourite pair of sweatpants. He prods against the other man's calf before Mydei kicks him under the table.

Phainon laughs partly out of the pain, and partly because Mydei immediately reddens at the contact.

“Aw, you’re gonna get a headache from looking at chat so much. Pay attention to me, won’t you?”

Phainon smiles, sliding into the other’s personal space and slyly wrapping his arms around the other’s shoulders, before grinning straight at the webcam, as if trying to say, *it doesn’t matter how much you donate. I’m the one getting first dibs.*

Mydei huffs, pushing the man’s face away from where he was making kissy faces. Embarrassing. “I’m paying attention to how much you’re extorting your viewers. You’re using *me* for personal gain.”

wifee_y : that’s right tell him off, Mystery Man!

nightosphere : i have a feeling hes not keeping the money ngl

awikwok : possessive much

shecticshe : DUDEEE STOP BEING GAY ON STREAM

“Did you hear that, *Phainon?* Don’t you dare use the money you gained in my name on something stupid.”

*[**@**GagleaR has donated **150,000** credits: “he should use the money to buy a new wardrobe instead tbh”]*

“Okay, that’s just mean. My clothes are perfectly fine!”

“Yeah,” Mydei nods, “it’s just his clothing sense that’s appalling.”

The chat continues on as they eventually near the goal, when Mydei taps his shoulder and looks at him, really, and asks, “Seriously, what are you doing with that money?”

Saving for our wedding, Phainon wants to say. Naturally wants to tease, really. But he holds back.

“I’m not actually keeping the money!” He laughs, “Put the pitchforks down. You and chat both. I’ll donate all of it to a charity of my roommates choosing. There’s a few local shelters and research foundations we frequent, so your money’s going to good causes. Trust,” Phainon grins as Mydei huffs, satisfied, before settling back into his chair as well.

nightosphere : see? Have faith in the goat

*[**@**DittoDitto has donated **100,000** credits: “alright fine”]*

InYoDex : regardless of this being for charity it may still qualify as a tax writeoff insofar as it is noted for the pure business expense of gaining recognition or promotion via donating on a livestrea

wypei_why : AWWW THATS CUTE

TarkleSparkle : why dont the men I KNOW do this

Amarilo : is that actual legal advice

MystVOid : he had me in the first half ngl KEKW

pristinepraying : NAH BUT WHY DID EVERYONE STILL DONATE JUST TO GET MM ON STREAM LMFAO ????????

convincednotconvicted : @InYoDex can i dm u for legal counsel…

"My fans love you, huh," Phainon breathes, "I was joking, but does chat actually prefer you over me?"

"Hah." Mydei scoffs, shoving Phainon's chair away and sending him wheeling into the wall, "I don't think that's a hard line to cross."

"Yet few have crossed it!" Phainon exclaims, wheeling himself back, "You have my congratulations. My chat has all fallen for your inexplicable charm, surprising gaming prowess and sarcasm," he says, shaking his head before pausing, "either that or your biceps. I wouldn't fault them for either."

Mydei's face is still not visible, but from this angle his body takes up part of the side of the frame as he wheels his chair closer to the screen. The black v-neck he's wearing does nothing to hide the build of his body, the sculpted lines of his chest and collarbones, proud and defined, right where the tattoos on his neck end.

He clears his throat, looking away slightly flushed. "What nonsense are you spouting this time? Speak like that again and I'll *show you* why I work out."

"Don't threaten me with a good time," Phainon grins, because he can be obnoxious if nothing else, and is *incredibly* grateful that his boyfriend (boyfriend!) had chosen to remain faceless when he agreed to stream with him.

Because even faceless, his body was already *far* more than enough to qualify him as attractive.

Tattoos are often works of art plastered on skin. A star, a sun, a lover's name in a locket. Ink engraves an image onto the body, muscle and tissue as a canvas for whomever is your muse. Mydei's tattoos however are not, individually, art.

They swirl around his skin like those videos of electricity being run through wet wood. Like fractal burning, a violent clash of the elements, of colour, of the sight of fire burning fiber. Only he is not a decorative tea-table nor the alligator clips hooked up to car batteries, but a man with the most conflicting personality traits he's ever met.

Muscled with tattoos and an affinity for bland colours yet on his skin and in his hair is unadulterated fire , a command for attention. Yet, despite his appearance, old ladies and

children *love* him. He's compiled entire notebooks worth of family recipes the folk at the retirement home pass down to him. The gap moe is insane.

Phainon sighs dreamily, settling against his chair with a smile. He's gotten lucky. So, *so* damn lucky. Mydei wheels back and barely into frame as he shoves an elbow against his shoulder.

"Stop the drivel. You've been doing this for years, and I have multiple day-jobs. Even if I wanted to, which I *don't* , I wouldn't have the time nor energy to stream, not like you do. And besides," Mydei says, leaning back on his chair, arms crossed, "visually, I think you're a far better match for this kind of content."

"Oh?" Phainon grins, a blush on his face and wiggling his eyebrows, he's wheeling his chair closer to Mydei's, close enough that unseen from the cameras, Phainon's leg playfully kicks at the other's calf, once more, "Golly. So you *can* be sweet to me. Go on, continue. What else of me is worthy of your praise?"

Usually, goading compliments from Mydei are a 50/50. Some days, when Mydei is feeling particularly indulgent, he'll answer sincerely with praise so heartfelt that Phainon feels his words echo all throughout the day. Other times, Mydei blushes, slightly flustered from the question as he curses him out for being insufferable.

Both instances are net positives. Which is why Phainon has never shied from being indulgent.

"You."

"Yes? What about me? I asked what parts of me you liked."

"*You."*

"Are your headphones on too tight? Or are you actually ignoring my question?" Phainon says as he takes off Mydei's headphones, sliding them around his neck.

Mydei raises a brow, "You asked me a question, did you not? I doubt you are so obtuse to not understand what I mean. Think of what I've just said. I've answered your question." He says, simply.

Phainon blinks.

Mydei blinks back.

Usually, goading compliments ends up with shocking praise of his character or traits, begrudgingly sincere words that never fail to make him smile. Those words weighed on his mind like a blanket, a swaddle, a reminder of who he fell in love with– who he *falls* in love with, everyday. If those words were a blanket, *these* were the whole damn bed.

Bells ring in his mind. Wedding bells– or funeral bells, he can't tell, but there are bells in his head so damn loud because his boyfriend just gave him the sweetest compliment of his life. How the hell else is he supposed to react?

The chat zooms past them so fast that Phainon's pretty sure his moderators are drafting their resignation letters at this very moment.

Phainon blinks, opens his mouth and closes it, fearing for the dramatic spiel of embarrassingly smitten words that are sure to leave his mouth the second he voices his thoughts. And Mydei– graceful, wonderful man that he is, decides to give him an out by handing him his controller, grinning at the creeping blush on his face.

"Go on now, Aquila's next, is it not? Lead us to victory, Deliverer. Prove what else of you is so worthy of my praise."

The low timber of Mydeis voice sounds close. Painfully, so obviously close, it ghosts the shell of his ear and sends vibrations down from his eardrum and into his heart, kickstarting the pounding. Phainon feels like the luckiest man alive. But also, he's so distracted he feels like he's going to walk off a cliff. Literally.

"You're a sick, sick man," Phainon mutters, dazedly dragging their still armorless character around and through the skies as he navigates to find the Eye of Twilight, just barely remembering to actually move his avatar.

He jolts as Mydei reciprocates his kick from earlier by tangling their legs together, pulling Phainon to the side through sheer strength of his legs, effectively scooting him closer. This close, Phainon can *feel* every bit of his exposed shoulder and arms, even through his own hoodie.

"Focus now," Mydei snaps his fingers in front of Phainon's face, quite literally snapping him out of his reverie, "You're walking off the ledge here. Do I have something on my face, or something?"

"I think you're just naturally conspicuous, dear roommate," Phainon mutters, barely able to think of a comeback as he looks away out of virtue, before looking back.

Mydei raises a brow all the way to his hairline, the silent challenge of '*you were totally ogling at me, weren't you?'*

Phainon shrugs. He *might* have been caught staring, but it's not as though he's not *allowed* to. There are no moral repercussions from loving your boyfriend a bit too much. If he's gonna stare, he might as well stick to it. Averting his eyes only makes him look like more of a guilty man, and Phainon is a great many things, but he will never be the one to first admit defeat.

"Stop hunching over. Your posture suffers enough as is."

"Oh come on, I'm trying to game here!"

"And that is *exactly* why you have shrimp posture, HKS. Sit up straight, or lean back. Just stop doing that thing with your shoulders."

"Fine then!" Phainon huffs, pulling the other's chair closer to him to lean against his shoulder, "There. Now I have something to lean on. Is that better?"

At this angle, the screen only shows Phainon leaning heavily into a body of straight muscle. Mydei sits off to the side to hide his face, and so the whole composition of the shot is unbalanced as Phainon sits way off to the side. Despite most of the screen literally being empty, the two sit together thigh to thigh.

“Hmph,” Mydei scoffs, “you’ll strain your neck if you keep that up.”

Phainon knows that, of course, he’s had to deal with plenty of neck pain due to their difference in height, coupled with his own insistence of leaning against the other.

At the cinemas, while Mydei is cooking or reading a book or even after their spars, when Phainon is feeling especially clingy or if Mydei was feeling indulgent, he’d rest his head against his shoulder and ignore how his neck would cramp 5 minutes in.

“Mm, my neck doesn’t hurt yet though,” he says, resting his chin on Mydei’s collarbone, close enough to be tempted to tug on his necklace with his teeth.

Phainon sighs, nuzzling against Mydei’s neck as he rubs his cheek across the cool metal of his necklace, near the juncture of his collar where it’s warm, where it felt like he belonged there. It was easy, to take up his space, to want to be this close. Because Mydei made it easy. Because it has always been so, *so* easy to be this hopelessly in love with him.

“Brat,” Mydei chides, gently prying his head off his shoulder.

Phainon laughs, leaning against him still, “You love me anyway.”

*[@GeniusSociety91 has donated **6,969,696** credits: “Yeah, bet he does. Gay ass.”]*

Phainon freezes, noticing that the game had been stuck on a death screen for at least three minutes, awaiting confirmation to respawn.

The chat’s been watching him fawn over his roommate for at least three minutes.

And it was like time itself had stopped. The chat didn’t move an inch, nor did Mydei. At first, he thought it was a hallucination. Something his mind had coughed up in a sort of disaster scenario because being in Mydei’s vicinity always meant he was gonna do something stupid.

Then, he realized, it wasn’t that no one was chatting– it was that they were chatting too fast. It lagged *the entire server.*

BRiightmoon : WWWWWWWWW

TheReckoning : ??????????????

neetFREAK : boy ?????????????????////

*[@laneXxX has donated **50,000** credits: “oh NOW YOU REALIZEEGNIGfeaif”]*

nightosphere : my fujoshi heart,,..

RiceToCas✔️ : ...phainon.

WailWhale : yall...did they forget theyre still on stream

*[@TungTung has donated **500,000** credits: "WERE STILL HEREEEEE 😭😭😭"]*

LowBloodSugar : CUT THE CAMERAS

SmallFries : I WAS WATCHING WITH MY MOM WHAT THE HELL

anylayy : does the deliverer is gay...?

Shampoo99 : IM SINGLE AS FUCKKKKKKKKKKKKKKK

NerdLike_Me : we get it yall are dating :////////////

playthatjawn : boy your homosexuality is SO LOUD

*[@Gliterglori has donated **100,000** credits: "SOMEONE CLIP THIS RN]*

12kay09 : when is it my turn...

awkWardoWgel : HOWWDF DID YOU NOT NOITCE

Oh.

Fuck.

Best Friends or Boyfriends: Everything We Know About Deliverer's Mystery Man!

Published XX25 | By O. W. L. Bert

Streamer Deliverer's (real name: Phainon) second ever 24-hour stream ends in a success, reaching a world-record peak at 3,356,075 viewers! However, after the stream, fans remain rapt with a burning question– specifically about Deliverer's on-stream guest: *who really is the Mystery Man?*

After Mystery Man (who will be referred to as 'M', moving forward) had accompanied our dear streamer for the full 24 hours and 19 minutes, fans have started analyzing all the juicy details of our new favourite duo. The prevailing theory is this: M and Deliverer are best friends, but perhaps there is the possibility of something *more* to their relationship!

This theory matches up with what we know of Deliverer, a known ally who came out as Bisexual on XX24's Pride Month. While M's sexuality is currently unknown, it's abundantly clear that he is indeed *comfortable* or *incredibly familiar* and close with our streamer. (*Click here to access our favourite Deliverer clips!)*

From leaving to make dinner to taking over the stream when Deliverer had fallen asleep, it warms our hearts just thinking about the bond these two friends have! Here is a list of 10 of our favourite moments:

1. ***"It's alright. I'm here."***

Comforting words were uttered as Deliverer failed to slay the ' *Flame Reaver',* the final boss of ' *Dire Souls',* in the last 20 minutes before he hit the 24-hour mark of his stream.

Fans were distraught as his avatar (affectionately dubbed ' *oryx'* for his choice of armour) fell to the final attack of the ' *Flame Reaver',* just as it was transitioning to its final phase.

This marked a crushing moment where it seemed like the streamer's goal of clearing the game before his 24-hours were up wasn't going to be reached.

But it was at this moment that M had gripped Deliverer's shoulder, confidently proclaiming his confidence in the other, emboldening our streamer to…

...Read More

#Deliverer #StarDom #StarTube #Streamers #MysteryMan #24hStream #DireSouls

Comments:

user520** commented**:

One of the few articles where theyre not just homophobic as shit lmfao good on you interastral peace media

***user948** replied:*

THISSS ACTUALLY. Its insane how so many ppl deny that these 2 cld be boyfriends like ur fav streamer likes men pls sstfu ://

***user1041 r**eplied:*

they dont wanna admit their goat takes it up the butt

***user9883** replied:*

u think PHAINON is a bottom?

***user3219** replied:*

LOUDERRRR 🗣️🗣️🗣️

user1010 *commented:*

Yooo get me a Mystery Man too like actually

> ***user0594*** *replied:*
>
> do u think this is any less pathetic than a man catcalling a woman?
>
> > ***user1010*** *replied:*
> >
> > im gay and lonely, man, leave me alone
> >
> > > ***user0594*** *replied:*
> > >
> > > im sorry

user417 *commented**:***

so deliverer is hot, rich, famous AND has a hot boyfriend or at the very least a hot roommate. fuck. life is so unfair.

> ***user3012*** *replied:*
>
> god picks favourites,,.
>
> ***user073*** *replied:*
>
> Me next.

user9236 *commented:*

im glad everyones more focused on them being gay instead of like, doxxing the guy

> ***user1230*** *replied:*
>
> Why would we do that? We get all this content for free already.
>
> ***user697*** *replied:*
>
> these two got me rooting for them they are my parents!!
>
> ***user7746*** *replied:*
>
> even mass media is talking about his homosexuality. my goat.

Show 520 Replies

< < **1** 2 3 . . . 47 48 > >

HAS DELIVERER BEAT DIRE SOULS YET? *@DelivererDireSoul3* - 12h ago

YES.

[image attached: a screenshot of the stream at 23 hours, 57 minutes. The final boss, 'Flame Reaver', has finally been slain.

Phainon is seen jumping ecstatically, hugging the man beside him who's holding the controller, sitting down. The Mystery Man remains faceless, but the bottom half of his face just barely shows and he's smiling.]

4.2K ***29.1K*** ***103K***

> **nellyOh_shelly** *@YumFryDough0* - 8h ago
>
> THIS FUCKASS GIMMICK ACCOUNT IM CTFUU
>
> ***835*** ***15.2K*** ***48.1K***
>
> **Daughter of Death 💐 HoloEN ✓** ***@****Castorice_CH* - 7h ago
>
> Congratulations for finally clearing Dire Souls! *@PhainonOElysiaeee*
>
> ***1.2K*** ***32.1K*** ***88.6K***
>
> **Cipher's Wife** *@SapphicandProud* - 4h ago
>
> The way his immediate first reaction is to hug another man. okay 🏳️‍🌈
>
> ***592*** ***8.9K*** ***14.9K***

#1_Phainon_Stan *@DailyDeliverer* - 11h ago

CONGRATS DELIVERER FOR NOT ACCIDENTALLY PANIC ENDING STREAM!! 🎊🥳

💬 ***2.2K*** 🔁 ***10.1K*** 🖤 ***63.4K***

#1_Phainon_Stan *@DailyDeilverer* - 11h ago

Oh and also congrats on the world record, or something

💬 ***928*** 🔁 ***12.1K*** 🖤 ***72.9K***

Prince. *@fatherlessprince* - 10h ago

HOW IS THE WR NOT THE FIRST THING YOU POST ABT LMAOOO

💬 ***182*** 🔁 ***1.2K*** 🖤 ***3.1K***

ling :3 *@yishiling_10* - 9h ago

Or something 🤷

💬 ***16*** 🔁 ***437*** 🖤 ***950***

SkripsiKekKontol *@YangTerhormat* - 10h ago

He couldn't panic end bcs his babygirl was already on stream with him 😂

💬 ***134*** 🔁 ***2.7K*** 🖤 ***8.6K***

ReaororRea *@andwhosREA?* - 10h ago

Even his daily accounts bully him 😭😭😭 oh flopnon…

💬 ***23*** 🔁 ***1.3K*** 🖤 ***7.3K***

Le Lemon *@thatsasourboy* - 11h ago

can someone make a new compilation of deliverer being gay the old ones outdated…

💬 ***182*** 🔁 ***651*** 🖤 ***3.8K***

Avary is GRADUATING *@LowlyFan* - 11h ago

@QUEERnon oomf the people need you…

💬 ***391*** 🔁 ***1.3K*** 🖤 ***4.1K***

HAPPY PRIDE MONTH 🌈 *@QUEERnon* - 9h ago

IM WORKING ON IT OKAY??

💬 ***32*** 🔁 ***874*** ♥ ***1.7K***

Le Lemon *@thatsasourboy* - 11h ago

“erm ackshually he’s bi 🤓☝” who gaf

💬 ***203*** 🔁 ***1.1K*** ♥ ***283***

Kryptakellon *@thermall* - 9h ago

He LITERALLY is tho wdym

💬 ***34*** 🔁 ***203*** ♥ ***987***

FOR MY CUNTRY *@LemINade* - 9h ago

Bi with a preference for men, mybe

💬 ***12*** 🔁 ***198*** ♥ ***759***

MystaMyrtleTMR *@MustDaMyrr* - 13h ago

lowk, top 10 deliverer streams OAT, right up there w his IRL streams and collabs w casto / AE. mystery man gotta be one of my fav guests on here, he’s the goat.

[attached clip: Mystery Man is holding the controller, wheeled slightly closer to the screen than usual in order to focus. His chest is taking up most of the screen, Phainon barely peeking behind him.

“M- roommate,” Phainon chokes, “please, wheel back a bit.”

“Shut it,” the man mutters, locked in, leaning even closer to the screen, “I’m almost done.”

The avatar on screen makes a flashy move, jumping and charging down, slamming Aquilla and knocking it down with grace. Immediately, he pivots to the wings, pointing a well-timed burst against its weak spot.

He clears the boss easily.

“Goddamn,” Phainon mutters, eyes not even looking at the screen.]

💬 ***546*** 🔁 ***1.2K*** ♥ ***10.4K***

Feenix *@OverSalted* - 11h ago

GYATT damn

💬 ***85*** 🔁 ***571*** ♥ ***2.3K***

CREW_SADE *@yeahbetuj3lly* - 10h ago

Nobody was looking at the gameplay dude i was looking at HIM

681 2.1K 13.6K

Natsu *@Kiyaaaamye* - 9h ago

yeah bruh phainon was too

31 391 2.2K

ren! *@redamacy* - 9h ago

…at his heart, right?

34 981 5.2K

CREW_SADE *@yeahbetuj3lly* - 10h ago

At his CHEST, bro. His TATAS.

42 1.5K 6.9K

MamaMiya *@OrAnemia* - 8h ago

This stream was SO dangerous for my lil bi heart

13 104 3.4K

⋆˚꩜ laura is losing it over deliverer ϑϱ˚⋆ *@stupidbakalife* - 12h ago

haven't seen anyone post my favourite clip from the stream yet so here ya'll go

[attached clip: The timer on the stream reads 24 hours, 4 minutes. Phainon has beaten the game, and now he and Mystery Man are sitting side by side, reading and answering superchats to end the stream.

"Chat, you seriously think me saying 'I love you' to this guy is gay?" Phainon exclaims, jutting his finger out at the man beside him, who already seemed to be falling asleep in his chair, "I don't know about you guys, but he and I are just homies. Roommates– best friends, even. He's my brochacho. Saying I love you to my homies isn't gay."

"What the hell are you talking about this time?" The man mutters, voice slightly gravelly from his exhaustion of staying up the full 24 hours, "...You have other 'homies?'"

Phainon gasps, mock-offended. "I have plenty."

“Liar. I’ve seen your friend groups. Even including other streamers, you hang out exclusively with women.”

“Okay, and? You hang out exclusively with me.”

“Yes,” he nods, “In any case, I am a man and you are a man, and unless you’ve started reaching out to that professor from college who always threatened to shoot you with an airsoft, I remain the only person within your casual vicinity who is a man. So what does that say about you?”

“That I’m a feminist?” Phainon offers, a hopeful grin on his face.

Mystery man facepalms. “It means that you are an idiot.”]

4.1K 14.9K 125K

“Phainon, why does the internet call me ‘babygirl’?”

Phainon simply smiles, tight-lipped, “Dear, I think it’s best you put my phone down.”

The two are in bed, just after the stream had ended. Post-stream, Mydei had immediately dragged Phainon into his room, claiming that Phainon’s bed and streaming room stank after the 24 hours they’d spent there, and forced Phainon to sleep in his bed instead. Objectively, Phainon thought it smelt fine, but who was he to judge?

Not that he was complaining, of course. Phainon would never say no to spending more time with his boyfriend.

And so here he is, Mydei laying on his arm, wearing one of his shirts and scrolling through his tweeter and frowning, sporadically asking him what it means when someone on the internet says that his arms look *edible.*

“Are your fans cannibals?” He asks, squinting at the bright light of Phainon’s phone screen, almost blinding in the darkened room but Mydei had insisted he stay on light mode anyway, “They keep saying they want to eat me. That’s terrifying.”

Phainon chokes on his spit, “It-” Does he even *want* to explain this?

“It’s a compliment, Mydei. I promise, none of it’s literal.” His hand twitches. He wants to snag the phone away and just go to bed already. He wants to unlearn this conversation and undo whatever acts he’d done to accidentally allow Mydei to come in contact with some of the horniest specimens on the internet.

He wants Mydei to look at him instead of some stupid tweet on the internet, to turn his phone screen off and just cuddle him already so they can get some well deserved sleep.

As it is, Phainon's one arm is numb from Mydei lying on it, and the other is already firmly around Mydei's waist, and he's warm and the bed is *really* cozy and for some reason Mydei's pillows smell *unfairly* good tonight.

Either way, he's occupied. Too occupied for phone snatching.

"Mydei, baby, love of my life. Please stop reading thirst tweets. I need sleep. *You* need sleep, and tweeter is bad for you. Please, *never* say *gyatt* to me again."

Mydei frowns, looking genuinely distraught as he tilts his head.

"I was simply parroting the sentiment your fans shared about your-"

"My ass, yes. Yours is better, but that's not the point." Phainon sighs, opting to sneak his other, slightly numb arm, to link with his own across on Mydei's waist.

"I'm going to combust if you keep ignoring me for that phone. You don't want your boyfriend to explode do you?"

"Oh hush," he whispers, settling his back onto Phainon's chest to get some distance between his eyes and the screen, "I'm reading, and you're warm. Go to bed if you wish."

The nonchalance in his voice only made Phainon want to goad him further. It was ridiculous, really, how Mydei was treating *tweeter* with the same scholarly devotion he reserves for historical texts and fantasies. He appraises each word on the horrid hellspawn of an app with a keen eye and open heart. Yet at the same time, Phainon truly will implode if he has to hear Mydei reading another tweet about his *thunder thighs*.

"Are my fans more interesting than me?" Phainon sulks, chest to his boyfriend's back as his arms travel upward, winding around Mydei's chest and languidly resting his arms there, "They've already gotten your attention the whole day…"

They've been together all day. All 24-hours, actually. But despite the (unintentional) cuddling incident he hasn't really had time to be *Phainon,* Mydei's boyfriend, instead of *Deliverer,* the streamer.

Mydei raises a brow, "I was with *you* the entire time. What are you on about?"

Phainon thinks back idly to when he'd accidentally snuggled up to Mydei near the beginning of the stream, and the whole fiasco with the infamous *GeniusSociety* donating that ridiculous amount of money.

That was the only real skinship the two had on stream. The two had discussed it before and Mydei was, surprisingly, open to the idea of proclaiming the two of them as boyfriends, considering Phainon's friend group knew of their relations and Mydei's own mother was open to the idea. However, he did request to stay faceless, at the very least, almost not noticing that simply his *body* was recognizable enough. Perhaps he was just embarrassed.

In any case, Myde hadn't minded the skinship. He'd more gotten a laugh out of it instead of pushing away, but still, the clip was probably going to make it into another compilation of

his.

“It’s not the same!” He whines, “We didn’t get to do anything. I barely got to hug you! I didn’t even get to braid your hair this morning, and we haven’t even k-” He paused, blushing, suddenly embarrassed. “We haven’t even kissed today…”

(Mydei laughed, looking all fond and soft, and Phainon wondered if it was from the alcohol, the lighting of the bar or the Kiss.

Just remembering it brought his blush back full force. The heat from the memory lodged in his heart, pumped throughout his veins and up till his head and the ends of his feet. In the bar’s golden light, he must be turning red, increasingly so. Mydei watched him with a raised brow. “What got you so shy now, HKS?”

“You. This. Th-the kiss,” he stuttered. 25 years old and only now kissing someone. And it was after he’d made a fool of himself and punched him in their living room. This was more embarrassing than he'd thought.

“It was your first, wasn’t it?”

“What, gonna tease me for having no game?”

“Hah. We’re tied, actually. It was my first, as well.”

Pause. Rewind. What. The fuck.

“No shot,” Phainon stares, hard, watching for any signs of a lie. Mydei doesn’t lie often, but he can tell when he does most of the time. The tick in his brow, the slight clenching of his jaw, like the truth wants to come out of him, like he’s physically holding himself back.

This time, he sees none of that. Just soft, pliant Mydei, head leaning against the bar booth’s cushion and sipping on his spritz languidly.

“I’m your first kiss?” Phainon mutters dazedly.

He wants to do something embarrassing. He wants to jump in the air and cheer, and tap his legs together, the giddiness almost too much to be sitting still, drinking shitty alcohol. He wants to tell someone, he wants to tell anyone. Because what do you mean, he’s Mydeimos’ first kiss?

Phainon jumps on him, sticking close, embracing his arm and nuzzling his shoulder. Mydei laughs, amused and fond and satisfied. “Your tail is wagging from here, Phainon. Sit down, you’re overexcited.”

“I can’t help it. How could I help it? I think I’ve peaked. I’ve kissed you. What more is there to have in my life? This is it, really. This is as good as it gets.” He says, arms around the others’ neck.

“I sure hope it isn’t,” Mydei grins as he stands, grabbing Phainon’s wrist, inviting him to stand as well, the blunt of his nails scratching against the ins of it.

“Because you’ll still have me for the rest of it, won’t you?”)

An exhale of breath, a slight wheezing of the throat. “Was that a *stutter* ? Phainon, did you truly just stutter saying the word *kiss?”*

“...that was a moment of weakness.”

“That was *adorable.”*

Mydei had said the word ‘adorable’ with the slightest lilt in his voice, half in jest, half sincere. Phainon freezes with mild horror. “You’re being sarcastic now, aren’t you? Did you learn that from chat, too?”

Mydei simply laughs, the quiet shake of his shoulders as he huffs, “The great Deliverer, world record holder and famed streamer, flustered over remembering a kiss. A *peck.* What are you, a child?”

“Okay, it was *not* a peck! Forgive me for being flustered when I made out with my hot roommate on the living room floor after a fight!”

The memory of Mydei’s arms caging him in on the floor as his lip stung from a punch, sluggishly throbbing but not nearly as painful nor as loud as his heart beating thunder in his chest, the blood rushing wholly towards his head, towards his limbs, towards his arms, hungry to grasp, to hold, to fight and *take.*

He’d been high off the adrenaline of the Con, of leaving the panel, of meeting the most stubborn, nosy Uber driver of his life. The little high of rebellion, the blazing dread of *change* in their little, comfortable status quo.

It all came *swinging* at him, wide as the door slammed like thunder, ringing through their apartment as Mydei came in like beautiful, sweet, justice.

He deserved that punch. Whatever, however many punches he threw at him. But Phainon couldn’t back down, either. Allowing himself to be hit like that, only lying there and taking it, would’ve made Mydei stop immediately, never the one to hit someone when they’re down.

So he fought back, because Mydei never takes it when anyone fights half-assed, and he clawed and tousled until he could barely hear the rush of his blood over the panting, the grunts, the hitch of breath as their fight came to a standstill, as his thighs caged Mydei’s hips and pinned him under, hoping, *praying* he’d stay down.

And when he didn’t, when Mydei had flipped him over and reversed their positions and he’d hovered above him, lights framing a halo over the exertion like a God, like victory, like the epitome of honour itself– red glowing on his cheeks, his tattoos and his hair, Phainon could only gulp and hope he remembered how to breathe.

Phainon would never admit it, but that quite possibly could’ve been the horniest he’s ever been in his 25 years of life. And he lives with *Mydeimos.*

“Is that so?” Mydei smirks, wiggling out of his grasp to prop his head up, facing Phainon, “So you’re into that, huh?”

Holy fuck.

“That-!”

“I liked it too.” Mydei grins, cutting him off. “The fighting. Making out. We should do it more often.”

In the low light of Mydei’s bedroom, Phainon could just barely see the outline of his smirk, wild and slightly feral, golden eyes wide and almost *glowing* . The only light of the room being from his phone, still on tweeter, still on light mode, barely illuminating the sharp slant of his jaw, the arch of his cheekbones, the high of his eyebrows and the growing blush on Mydei’s own face even as he grins, hungry and excited.

He looks like he’ll eat him alive.

He looks like every single wet dream he’s ever had.

Phainon pounces.

Like a repeat of their previous position, Mydei’s head between his arms, Phainon’s heart running laps around his body. Only this time there is no advantage, there is no fight– only a choice, only choosing for submission and allowing for it.

Mydei’s arm sneaks around silently gripping his elbow and he grins, slow, sweet and confident, Phainon’s phone long forgotten, screen still blaring.

“You don’t know what you do to me,” Phainon mutters, biting down on his lower lip, hard.

Mydei laughs. “You’re so eager. So *easy,”* he says, but his arms interlock on the back of Phainon’s neck, and by sheer core strength he pulls himself up, slowly, inches away from his boyfriend’s face. “You’re like a dog, aren't you? Just waiting to please.”

Phainon only whines in response, chasing his lips as Mydei pulls back onto the bed, triumphant. “Patience,” he whispers, his hands letting go, “We can do this some other night. But I’m tired, you’re tired, and I’m cashing in on that sleep, come.” He says as he gestures for Phainon to lay back down with him.

Only this time, Phainon frowns. Mydei tilts his head, “What’s wrong?”

A shake of the head. “It’s nothing. I just. I thought we would-” he cuts himself off, “I mean it’s alright, really, if we don’t. I’d never want to rush you if you want to take things slow. I’d love you either way! I just…” he gestures vaguely, “I thought we would. You know.”

Mydei raises a brow, “We would *what*, exactly?”

“...do the devil’s tango? Find bread and butter? *Do the dirty?*”

"*Sex,* Phainon. It's called *sex*."

Phainon gasps, affronted as he leans forward, "Language!"

Mydei snorts. "Oh come *on* you're a streamer, surely you've heard your fans say worse."

"That's the internet! You're *you!"*

"And? What's that supposed to mean?"

"It *means* that you're the furthest entity I can imagine from the internet! I can't handle you giving me dirty talk!"

"Dirty- *what?* I only said sex! Intercourse!"

Phainon faints like a weak-hearted maiden, shaking his head as he tuts. "This is the most vulgar I've heard you talk in the over 5 years I've known you."

"Phainon, I majored in athletic sciences. I know what *sex* is."

"Nope!" Phainon caves, slapping a hand over his mouth, "Not doing this tonight! Nope!"

Mydei stares, then rolls his eyes. "You wanted to maul me just a moment ago and now I can't even say it as is. How are you embarrassed now?"

Phainon groans, distinctly dog-like and with more fluster than annoyance, "Don't say it like that! I got carried away!" He cries out, burying his face in Mydei's chest as he grips his own hair, much to his boyfriend's amusement.

"And what are you doing now?"

"Pretending this conversation didn't happen."

"Then release me at once, HKS," he says, though his hand gently making its way onto Phainon's hair, toying with white-grey strands, "If you fall asleep on my chest you are never to step foot into my room again."

Phainon groans, not wanting to move, but he relents, letting go as he settles on the spot right behind Mydei back, almost cradling him, looping his arms around the other's midsection and pulling him close. The barest hint of Mydei's exposed nape through the wide crewline makes Phainon halt, just a bit.

He pauses, as if reconsidering his options before he gives in, fully letting himself nuzzle into the shorter hairs on the back of the other's neck, soft and fluffy and strongly smelling of him. Mydei shivers, "Stop it- HKS, that tickles. Were you *always* this clingy? It's like I really am dating a dog."

"You'd date me if I were a dog?" Phainon perks up. If not for the darkened room, Mydei imagines that he could already see the dog ears standing tall atop his head and a tail wagging excitedly behind him.

Mydei blinks, and despite himself, can't control the incredulous laugh that escapes his lips.

"I barely got to date you as a person. What makes you think we would date if you were a dog?"

" Well," Phainon says as he pulls him closer, cheek resting atop Mydei's head, "I'm assuming you got turned into a dog, too. Would you date me, then? Please tell me you would. Please?" He says, pleading.

"I'd be some kind of cat, not a dog," Mydei mutters, "and what's brought this about?"

"I just want to know. Can't have you dating me for my fame, you know?"

Mydei scoffs, "Unfortunately, I fell in love with you even before I knew you were a streamer. I think you being a dog wouldn't make much of a difference."

"Is that a yes?" Phainon asks, pulling back so as to see Mydei's face directly as he answers, "You'd love me if I were a dog?"

"I'd prefer you as *you*, but," he pauses, "I think I'd love you in whatever form you are."

"Even if I was a dog?"

"Well- assuming I was an animal as well, I don't see why I wouldn't," Mydei shrugs, "though I imagine kissing would be very different if we weren't people."

Phainon blinks before laughing, slightly, "You're worried it'd be inconvenient to *kiss* me? Mydei, baby, I couldn't care less about that."

Mydei huffs, "That so?"

"Mm. It is indeed." Phainon says, quietly, willing his arms closer, tangling their legs and resting his forehead against Mydei's.

Silently, he marvels at how perfectly Mydei settles, just by the crooks of his elbows. Like this, Phainon's forehead to the top of his head, he could smell the fragrance of his expensive ass bougie pomegranate shampoo, the scent of him making him instinctively tighten his arms around his waist.

Bath oils, particular brands of perfume, lotion, and his own rigorous care routine– Mydei took incredible care of himself. There was no shame in admitting that Mydei objectively smelled *amazing* day in and day out.

It's how Phainon has learnt that the scent of pomegranate suits *everything* . Pomegranates and wine, and honey, pomegranates and sweat and pomegranates and smoke. Mydei smells like the city, stale coffee and oak from the library, essential oils and crayons for when he accompanies children, flowery fragrances and hard candy that the grandmas love to give him.

He smells like Phainon’s own minty soap, even when he steps out the shower and complains about how chemically and artificial Phainon’s choice of bathing gel smells. He smells like the heavy hand of chilies Mydei prefers in his own cooking and the mismatch of detergent they alternate between, because one day they’d both bought a new bottle after they’d run out and had accidentally opened both.

Phainon had realised his fondness for the scent of pomegranates the first time his room was flooded from an upstairs neighbours' disastrous plumbing. His streaming equipment was safe, but his bed was not. And Mydei, kind, sweet Mydei, had allowed him to stay in his room because the heater never reached the living room.

And maybe that was also the first time Phainon realized he preferred staying in Mydei’s room compared to his. Maybe that was when he realised he slept better, smelling pomegranates, buried in sheets of sweet, gentle fragrance– that of warmth and fruit, compared to when he slept alone.

He buries his nose in Mydei’s hair, even deeper, earning him a slightly disgruntled grunt, “And what are you doing now, HKS?”

The grumble of Mydei’s voice vibrates in his chest. So close like this his entire spine tingles at the warmth, at the closeness, every twitch of muscle, built and supple yet soft.

He can’t see much, in the dark, but he can imagine the similarly soft, tired expression on his lover’s face. Relaxed, trusting, and content.

“Shh,” Phainon mutters, drowsy, “I’m resting my eyes. You’ve blinded me.”

“What,” he scoffs, “with your phone screen?”

“Mm, no,” he sighs gently, “with your beauty.”

Phainon fights back a chuckle that turns into a full on wheeze when Mydei elbows his sternum from where he lays in his arms, nearly falling off the bed, before Mydei pulls him back, settling himself into Phainon's arms and this time, hiding his face by the crook of his neck, right next to his sun tattoo.

His breath fans against the soft, sensitive skin by his adam’s apple, lips barely brushing against golden ink. Silently, Mydei intertwines their hands, a promise hidden away in his own sheets, tucked between their chests, their hearts.

And quietly, so quiet, he mutters *goodnight* in the silent sanctity of his room.

And gently, so gently, Phainon huffs, smiles into his hair, pressing a kiss onto his forehead.

Goodnight, he whispers, *sweet dreams.*

“Phainon, my 54 year old mother will *not* challenge you to a duel, or whatever it is you’re muttering about.”

The man in question groans, head in his hands, ruffling Mydei’s attempts to comb his hair down, messing it up again as fluffy white strands fly in all directions. “She’s a museum curator! Your culture is important to her! And your culture dictates that *I* have to be worthy to date you! I’m not!”

Mydei scoffs, “And what part of ‘being worthy’ entails you dueling my family until you’re acknowledged?”

“I-” Phainon pauses, “I read an article…”

“On what? Ancient Kremnoan Courting conventions? From whom?”

“...WikiHow?”

Mydei blinks, facepalming as he sighs, before attempting to smooth out Phainon’s hair once more. “You’re being ridiculous. You are more than worthy, HKS. I would not have dated you if you weren’t.” He says, crossing his arms.

It was a relatively peaceful day.

Once the two had woken up, Phainon’s octopus grip on Mydei’s waist was enough to convince him that his Saturday probably wasn’t going to be spent on anything productive. Post-24 hour stream, Phainon had announced that he wouldn’t be streaming this weekend, and so it was a relatively rare moment of freedom for the both of them.

Phainon would’ve been more than happy to spend their day like that, cuddled in Mydei’s carefully scented milky pomegranate sheets and with Mydei himself, warm and soft and drowsy in his arms, head in the crook of his neck, the greatest comforter in the world.

But of course Mydei, ever the Responsible Adult (he isn’t) had insisted they at least roll out of bed for breakfast. Phainon had declined of course, breakfast was not nearly a suitable replacement for taking time away from a rare moment of true, unhurried peace with his boyfriend, but Mydei had *literally* rolled him out of bed and onto the floor, swaddled in sheets and all, and plopped him on the kitchen counter.

Phainon was far too pleased with being manhandled to complain about it, really.

And so he’d started on breakfast, which led to honeycakes, which led, somehow, to an argument (read as: civil discussion) regarding whether or not chocolate belonged on them. Phainon had advocated, strongly, for chocolate to be eaten with the pomegranate syrup and seeds that were traditionally eaten as a topping and Mydei had unfortunately indulged in the bickering.

Phainon doesn’t know how, or why, but the argument had made Mydei impulsively call his mother for her dissenting Kremnoan expertise and opinion.

That phone call. That *damned* phone call was what's led him to his predicament now.

The two of them, being invited to Gorgo's apartment in Okhema after Mydei had accidentally let slip that the two of them were dating. She'd insisted they come visit and Mydei, ever the faithful son, had agreed immediately. Phainon, ever the faithful boyfriend, couldn't refuse.

But standing here, in front of apartment 7310, Phainon might have to rethink his impulsive decision-making.

"Are you *sure* your mother would approve? The last time we met was at the con.." The con where Phainon had accidentally mistaken her for Mydei and made a fool of himself to the point that she'd asked if he was *concussed.*

Then, he'd proceed to ditch her at the convention center to run away from the possibility of meeting Mydei. All in all, not the greatest first impression.

"What happened at the con?" He tilted his head, "I met with my mother at the museum, and then she'd insisted I go to the main hall to check something out."

"Wait. You hadn't spent any time with her?"

Mydei shook his head, "No, she insisted I go to the con area right after I'd arrived. She was the one who told me about your panel, and then she'd called a cab and went home afterwards."

Phainon blinked, processing.

Did Gorgo set him *up?*

Was he so obvious that upon their first meeting, Gorgo herself had told her son to chase after him, to create some kind of catalyst in their relationship? She deduced that he needed meddling in his love life from the *very first time they met?*

That was the worst part. That had to be. That Phainon was so consistently a *mess* compared to Mydei that even his Mother took notice. What was he to say to Gorgo? That he was a streamer, so hopelessly in love? That he plays video games for a living and mooches off of Mydei's cooking? That he's so reliant on her son to feel secure of himself, to feel okay on a day to day basis?

There was a dependency in how he lived. In how he almost needed Mydei, really. It was pathetic, even before they started dating.

How was he to be a good boyfriend? A good son in law, in her eyes, if all he could offer was a promise that he'll try his *best* for him, as useless as he is now? *What if his best wasn't good enough?*

"Phainon," Mydei says, breaking the silence, "You're overanxious. She simply wants to meet you properly before she leaves Okhema again. And besides," he shrugs, "If she truly hadn't approved, she would've been the one hounding our apartment already."

"*What?"*

The image of a sweet, strong, middle aged woman, full of motherly disapproval, bursting through their apartment to berate Phainon was such a vivid image that he involuntarily shivers at the thought. In the little time he's met her, Mydei's mother had already shown that she was not only *faster* but somehow had more stamina than him. He'd get his ass handed to him.

He doesn't feel ready to face her, not yet. Not when they'd just gotten together so recently and when he's just barely coming into terms with the fact that this is real. That this easy, domestic life, is something that he can have. That he could have *more* than just the wanting, the pretending that he was happy with whatever Mydei allowed him to have.

Because the thing is: Phainon's always been good at pretending.

It was easy to play a part, to play a role. A streamer, sarcastic and entertaining to his chat, a persona to show, a grin to flash, a camera to get on his good side. An earnest son, up and leaving his family in the countryside but still calling monthly, making it big in the big city. A faithful friend, a diligent roommate, doing his share of the chores and contributing his own to the household.

But was it true? How much of it was genuine? How much of it was from his character? How good, how kind, how virtuous a person was he, actually? How much of it was simply *expected* of him? How much of his kindness was from a want to be accepted?

Is any of it real?

Phainon gulps, "She'll beat me up if she disapproves of us?"

"Maybe," Mydei says, shrugging, "But it won't come to that."

Phainon frowns, slightly frustrated.

"You don't know that."

"What. As if I don't know my own *mother?"*

"That's not-!" He paused, sighing, "I'm just saying that there are *precautions* . Preparing for the what-if is important."

"Not if your 'what-if' is ridiculous*."*

Ridiculous to whom? Phainon thinks, and does not say.

Does Mydei not *see?* He's minutes away from imploding on himself, anxiety riddled in his mind, his hands, his limbs. He's this shaken from the prospect of just meeting his mother. How is this not an issue? How does Mydei not see this and see an imperfect, unworthy partner. How does Mydei have confidence in him, still, even when he cannot have confidence in himself?

What part of this is ridiculous? What part of this is worth it?

A beat, then two, then silence.

“Phainon, come on,” Mydei sighs, “are we entering or not? You’re overcomplicating this. It’s not quite that seriou-”

“ *But it is!”* Phainon grits out, accidentally slapping Mydei’s hand away from where he’d tried to reach out. He flinches, his voice coming out harsher than he’d intended, causing Mydei to back away, eyes wide. “I-” he blinks, the words dying in his throat.

“Sorry,” he mutters, when he doesn’t know what else to say.

Mydei breathes, slightly averting his eyes. Phainon doesn't blame him.

Deep breaths, he reminds himself, *you’ve met her before. She didn’t hate you, then. It’ll be fine.* This is a choice. This is *their* choice. Mydei had chosen him– somehow, some way, Mydei had chosen to love him as well. That has to mean something. It *does* mean something. He thinks, but his hands shake regardless.

But what if she does? His mind whispers. The little, still insecure part of him. *What if she realises I’m just a mess?*

He doesn’t know what to think, what to say. It’d all crumbled, or maybe it’s been crumbling and he hasn’t been able to notice.

Was it a mistake? Was it not worth the effort, not worth *Mydei’s* effort to love him? What part of him *did* he love? Which version?

He doesn’t know , a million questions and a thousand doubts and nothing but love, a shaky belief, a trust placed in his beloved’s heart but not in his own.

Phainon breathes, a stuttering breath, stuck in his thoughts and stuck in place and stuck, not being able to knock, even, on the door of a quiet, residential apartment.

Silently, a hand clasps onto his own trembling ones. And another sneaks its way to his cheek, slowly guiding him toward soft, golden amber eyes. “Hey,” Mydei whispers, gently, as if not to disturb the quiet.

Phainon’s throat is dry.

“Hi,” he whispers back.

He doesn’t know what to say, his mind stuck in his own thoughts, stuck in his own what-ifs.

It’s ridiculous. Everything was fine, *is* fine. He must meet Mydei’s mother eventually, anyway, if they were to date long term, if he were to, hopefully, one day marry him. If anything, this was the best course of action, really, to meet her right after they’d started dating. To meet her while she’s here and in Okhema.

So why?

Why can't he just do what he's supposed to, like he always has?

"Do you remember the time I went back to Kremnos?" He mutters.

Phainon blinks at the sudden question. Of course he does.

"...you mean the time that you left and I burned down our kitchen?"

"*Almost* burned our kitchen, yes," Mydei nods, "have I ever told you *why* I went back?"

"For your mother's things, no?"

He doesn't know where this conversation is going, but the soft, subtle smile creeping on Mydei's face brings him comfort, regardless.

"Yes, my mother's heirloom. That's the other reason why she'd insisted we come by today."

Phainon's brows furrow, not quite understanding. "You need to pick it up again?" He'd left it with her, the last time he came back. Something about safety and it belonging to her, anyway.

Mydei laughs, silent, a quiet exhale and a smile. "Yeah. You could say that."

His other palm sneaks up to the other side of Phainon's cheek, gently cradling his face, in both his palms, gentle, always so gentle. "It's just about time she passed it down to me," he smiles. Phainon tilts his head, but he pays it no mind.

"Phainon, I swear on my name that my mother loves you." Mydei says, in that assured, confident voice of his, as if his voice itself would make his words a reality, "And if she doesn't yet, then I'll show her every single thing that I love about you until she does."

Phainon's breath hitches. And despite the situation he laughs, slightly teary, but he laughs nonetheless. "Mydei- dear, what the *fuck?"* He hiccups, "You- you can't say that. You can't possibly promise that!"

"Why can't I?" He tilts his head, thumb gently swiping away a tear. "I love you, and I will continue to. I want my mother to care for you just as I do."

"Not everyone *likes* me, Mydei. You can't guarantee any of that."

"But I can," he says, a gentle kiss against his eyelids, "because it is you, and because it is us, and because, at the very least, I know my mother will agree." And Phainon doesn't have it in him to argue anything back.

They stay like that for what feels like eternity, the warmth of Mydei's palms on his face, he holds him until he feels a bit more like himself.

It’s slow when Mydei pulls him close, a gentle touch of his lips, peppering kisses on his forehead, cheeks and the tip of his nose before finally placing a last, feather-light kiss on his lips. “Do not doubt me, Phainon. If you doubt yourself, then place your faith in me, instead.”

He does not reply. He cannot promise so, but the both of them know that he will.

When they separate, it’s Phainon who pulls him back, desperate and clingy and Mydei indulges him, just as loving, just as kind.

That was the only way to describe him, all of him.

Tender touches, careful kisses, loving words, warm and comforting and thick, laying on him all at once. Phainon wants to cry, wants to scream, wants to love back just as fiercely, just as gently.

As they pull apart, one final time, Mydei huffs at Phainon’s starstruck expression, squishing his cheeks as he grins, boyish and young and in-love all at once, laughing at Phainon’s offended expression.

Phainon rubs at his cheek as Mydei collects himself, gesturing once again to knock on the door and take the first steps towards the doorway, towards his mother. The barest hint of warmth stays from where Mydei’s lips had made contact and, breathing in, Phainon knocks on the door.

Phainon’s relationship with his hometown is…complicated.

He loves Aedes Elysiae dearly, sure.

The golden fields, the bright skies, almost never rainy, never cloudy. Sprawled, twisty red-ocher trees and land, just land, far as the eyes could see. The nearest train station was an hour or two away. So remote that, even with its relatively large size, its name was nearly unheard of. A perfectly idyllic little town, quiet, on the map for textiles and wheat and not much else.

His childhood is a haze of not really doing much and not really being able to do much. There wasn’t much to life back then, and he loved it. At least, he remembers that he does.

He vaguely recalls sheep, fabric, bonfires, and wind, lighting stalks up with Cyrene as the sun sets, the two of them playing out in the yard in the time between tending fields and being called in for dinner. He had a dog, he thinks, when he was younger, or an animal of some kind. He doesn’t really know.

Looking back, maybe that’s the weird part. He remembers his parents, Cyrene, and Aedes Elysiae, but compared to his life in Okhema, so bright and new and *dense* , it just feels like a distant memory.

What he remembers most, truly, might be the day they'd told him to leave.

"There's a family friend in the big city, son. It's an opportunity. You can't stay here forever."

Phainon blinked, young and already unsure of his place in the world at his pa's words.

"Why can't I?" He tilted his head, "I need to take care of the ranch, don't I?"

They were sitting around at the dinner table, sometime when he was young, 17 or 18 and around that age because no one really kept track when the days dragged on infinitely. In a town where nothing ever changed and nothing felt like it had to, Phainon didn't understand why he couldn't stay.

"We have your sister for that already." It wasn't demeaning, or it wasn't supposed to be, but it was true. While the both of them were homeschooled Cyrene, at least, was already long familiar with handling the ranch. She was older, and so she would inherit it. She had been the one to handle most orders with customers already. It made sense.

It didn't to him, though. "What's that supposed to mean?" He frowned.

His pa opened his mouth to reply, but Cyrene cut him off.

"It *means* that you get to go to the city, Phai! You get to live with Agy, you remember her, don't you?" Cyrene smiled from where she sat beside him by the table, "The city's real cool~ you're gonna have so much fun there. Okhema's the biggest of all!"

Phainon didn't quite get it, but he said nothing. There was no dampening Cyrene's mood when she was excited, and she did genuinely seem happy for him. She talked animatedly about the city and opportunities and University and the whole time, Phainon simply prodded at his stew, a complicated expression on his face.

"Phai, there's more beyond the farm, you know?"

Sure. Of course there is. "But I like the farm," he said, quietly.

"I do too!" Cyrene grinned, "The farm's the best. I like the city too, though. You remember that ice cream machine we saw last time in Janusopolis? Okhema's got that. Plenty of it!"

Sometimes, Cyrene still treated him like a child.

"That so?"

Sometimes, he felt like he still was.

His ma sighed, "Phainon, dear, we know it's a lot to ask of you, but we just want you to do well in the city. It'd do you *and* the farm good if you learnt more, right? You've always been so smart," she said, gently brushing his bangs out the way. "You've always been such a good son. We just don't want to hold you back, you know?"

He *doesn't.*

He doesn't know why everyone keeps talking about what's good for him, what he should do and where he has to go. He wants to do well. He wants to make them happy. He wants to stay, but he can't. So what does he do now?

"...do I have to go?" He whispers.

Yes, he expects them to answer.

You must, he expects them to say.

Silence is the only response that he gets.

"Do you want to?" Is the question that Cyrene poses back to him.

"I-"

"Are you *scared* to?" She asks, "They're different things, Phai. You can want something and be scared to chase it. But I don't want you doing things that are bad for you, either." She chides.

Cyrene has always been a good sister like that. She's always been nothing but kind and encouraging. She's been nothing but fun, the responsible sister, the one who tells him stories about everything and anything he wants and teaches him to braid her hair, and cooks for him when ma and pa are away and shows him things around the ranch that always make him laugh.

And he's leaving her.

He's leaving Cyrene and parents and his town. For *what?* For *himself?*

"I don't want to," he says again, petulant, like a child.

"*Phainon-!"*

"Okay then," Cyrene answers, sighing slightly and patting him on the head like he'd just made a hard choice. Like he'd chosen correctly. "You don't have to go, if you don't want to."

And the conversation shifts back to wheat, and cotton, and new orders and old news.

Phainon pokes at his stew and he thinks about Okhema and he doesn't know if he wants to go.

The one to answer the door is Gorgo, long blonde hair, glasses, strong jaw, brows and nose, still just as he remembers her. But she looks different, slightly.

She's sporting a worn beige sweater and cotton pants, slippers on her feet and an excited, bright smile on her face that makes her look timeless. She looks radiant, cmfortable.

"Good afternoon, mother," Mydei greets, a matching smile on his face.

"Afternoon as well, ma'am."

Gorgo tuts, shaking her head, "I don't see a ma'am in this house. Greet me properly, boy. And hello to you, son," she grins, gesturing for him to lean down.

Mydei does, unquestioning, as Gorgo excitedly ruffles his hair, mixing red and gold strands and making it stand out unkempt like a true lion's mane. He blinks, not complaining, just confused, and he opens his mouth once, then closes it. Gorgo laughs heartily.

"Now you match your little boyfriend, both with wild hair!" she grins.

Mydei blushes at once and Phainon blinks at the acknowledgement of him being called Mydei's *boyfriend* by his own mother. The affirmation settles warm on his gut, true and sure, and just like that he can't help the laugh that bubbles out of his chest, relieved and fond and amused, "Mydei, you do look like a lion. That's so *cute* ," he giggles. Mydei huffs but is seemingly relieved at his joy, smiling slightly awkwardly as his cheeks turn pink.

"A lion? He's just a little cub," Gorgo smirks, "my little boy, all grown up, yet you still make your braid every morning, don't you? Just like I did. What a faithful son," she coos.

"Mother…" Mydei says, half embarrassed, half glowing under the praise, instinctively he touches the braid, the very one Phainon had helped him with this morning, drowsy as he was at the kitchen table.

"Aw, I jest," she replies. Smoothing down his hair and patting his head gently, as Mydei leans down further, leaning into her touch, "Let your mother have some fun, alright? It's good for the soul. You too, boy," she continues, pointing at Phainon, "c'mere."

Confused, Phainon mirrors what Mydei had done, leaning down slightly. He's taller than Mydei is, lankier as well, so the angle is a bit awkward, but Gorgo pays it no mind, gently ruffling his hair as well.

Her hands move underneath his chin as if giving him scratches, gently, as she continues smoothing and ruffling his hair. Phainon blinks, initially not understanding but he leans towards the touch anyway, almost starved. Gorgo laughs, amused, "Mydeimos, you're right! He really is quite cute. Like a puppy!"

Mydei clears his throat, blushing furiously. "That. Was not the terminology I used to describe him," he says, at the same time Phainon perks up and looks at him, saying "You told your mother you think I'm *cute* ?"

Gorgo chuckles. "Not just cute, boy," she says as she lets go of his hair, patting his back strongly, "you turn my son into a blabbermouth, you know? It's in every voice call I have with him! I wondered why I hadn't met you any sooner!"

The blush continues, high and red on Mydei's cheeks but he does nothing to stop her, unwilling to step in his mothers fun. But he's stunned near speechless, hands balling at his sides.

Phainon's hand sneaks towards his own, gently opening his fist to tangle with his own fingers, smiling sheepishly at him, before glancing back at Gorgo, smiling bright. "Is that so? Then I'm winning in that department, aren't I? I've been talking about Mydei since college!"

And it's true.

Long before the two had officially decided to move in together, back when Phainon had confidently claimed himself to be Mydei's best friend, he'd already been insufferable to all that would listen to his (very obviously) besotted spiel.

It made him the target of much love and envy, his peers glad to be in on the details and new found anecdotes of their beloved campus prince, while also jealous of the fact that *Phainon* was the one who was allowed to experience it all first-hand.

Mydei huffs, "It's not even a competition."

"Aw, you just don't want to lose, do you?"

"HKS…"

At the two's bickering, Gorgo coos. "How sweet!" She grins, "My boy, I like him already!" She says as she grabs onto Mydei's shoulder, patting him in approval. "Oh right, come now, I almost forgot, do come in you two," she gestures to the door, a warm smile on her face.

She steps aside, revealing the innards of her apartment. From here, Phainon can see the numerous family photos of Mydei and her, Mydei in what he assumes to be Kremnos, much younger than he is now, Mydei with a group of old friends and graduation pictures as well.

"I just made lunch, and you're both joining me at the table!"

Phainon steps in, oohing and awing at the pictures on the wall, at the carefully tended to potted plants, pointing at a rather new picture frame, one that Mydei recognizes immediately.

"Holy *shi-* smokes. Holy smokes. Mydei, is this you wearing a *dress?"*

It is indeed. Mydei, sometime in his young adulthood, wearing a toga, so similar to the dresses he's seen Aglaea make and wear as well, long, white, flowy, and strapped on his shoulders, a wreath of plastic gold leaves around his head, blush high on his cheeks.

The curve of his hip is almost illegal the way the toga ties around his waist not once but *twice,* bringing out the shapeliness of his thighs, the slight dip of his hip.

The fabric hugs his delts as he stands, barely even posing for the camera but looking like a god, no, a *goddess.*

“Are you wearing *makeup?!”*

Devastatingly, his lips are painted just slightly, redder than they usually are, plump and bright and *gorgeous* against his pale skin and crimson tattoos, popping out on the exposed skin, blaring against the faint powdering of foundation or whatever it is that glazes over his already perfect skin. His brows are accentuated, strong yet they frame his face almost delicately as his eyelashes, mascara painted on and *long* , fan over his cheekbones, painted slightly with blush and highlighter.

Holy *shit.*

Unperturbed by Phainon’s newfound awakening, Gorgo simply smiles, “My boy is beautiful, isn’t he? The aunties needed a model to try on dresses for old Krateros’ bachelor party, and it was just our luck that he agreed!”

Mydei crosses his arms, grinning, “What’s wrong, HKS? Like what you see?”

Yes, obviously. I’m calling Aglaea for a new dress as we speak, Phainon thinks immediately, but he does not say anything just yet. His eyes are still transfixed on the photograph, framed so innocently in the walkway of the apartment of a proud mother taking pride in birthing and raising the most gorgeous man on the planet.

Liking the photo doesn’t begin to cover it.

“Dolling you up is such fun, son, everyone complimented your lashes. You best be grateful you got them from me!” Gorgo laughs, patting the man on his back.

He huffs, “I’m grateful for a lot of things I got from you, mother.”

They continue their way through the posh apartment, clearly lived in and homey.

Aside from the pictures, the walls are decked in antiques and relics and tapestries, all old, genuine stuff, as far as Phainon can tell, like a legitimate museum of what he assumes is Kremnoan culture. “It’s beautiful,” he gasps, stopping at the case of a singular, red spear. The tip is large, almost impractically so as it curves and splinters as if made from crystal itself.

Distantly, silently, the image of Mydei wielding such a spear pops into his mind. Something about the curve of the spear, the unyielding brightness of it even without any light, without any magic, or whatever his ancestors used to fight with, makes the spear look deadly, *gorgeous.* It’s poised for destruction yet it holds its own. The crystal splinters, as if it might crack at any moment, but it doesn’t, as if holding itself with willpower alone.

Mydei had always felt that way, to him. An ancient sort of beauty, the kind to revere. The kind worthy of worship– be it from a devotee or from a random fan online.

Another part of him wonders how Mydei would look in that dress, holding such a spear, summoning thunder and vengeance and justice at once and looking *damn good* while doing

it.

Phainon slaps both his cheeks to rid himself of the thought as Gorgo saunters over.

“The Lance of Fury,” she whistles, hands on her hips as she stops by the casing as well, “You have a good eye, boy. This one was passed down long ago in the family. I’m lucky I signed a prenup, I got to keep all this stuff after the divorce.” She says, smiling.

“ *All* of this is ancestral?” He asks, genuinely disbelieving.

She laughs, “We have some royal blood back then, up on the family tree. Kremnoans don’t care so much for lineage, but you may very well be dating a prince.” She winks as she retreats into the dining room.

“Wow,” Phainon grins, a teasing look as he turns to Mydei, still standing, looking at old pictures, “I better treat you like a royal now, don’t I?”

He’d buy it. Maybe royal lineage would explain the poise and grace Mydei exudes on a day to day basis. Maybe blue gold blood is the cause of his looks, his demeanor, his wonderfully kind, fierce heart.

Mydei snorts, “Me? A prince? If I’m a prince then you might as well be a jester.”

“Oh?” Phainon laughs, “So you’d want me in your court?”

“At my beck and call? Sure. So eager to stay by my side, aren’t you?”

“And if I said yes what would you do, *my prince* ?”

Sometime during their banter, Phainon’s legs had instinctively caught up to him, striding over fast to where Mydei stood, smirking. Off from the dining room, the soft clatter of plates sounds quietly, a reminder of his mother still in the other room.

“I’d keep you there, obviously. Members of the court can rise in status, can’t they?”

“They could,” he breathes, “if the prince favors them enough.”

“Maybe.” He parrots, “They’ll do so once the prince becomes a *king.”*

“Hah-” Phainon’s voice is barely a whisper as he leans close, grabbing his collar, his slightly larger frame almost engulfing him, “and you’d want that, wouldn’t you, your highness? Getting bold like this, in your mother’s house.”

“In *my* own home, Phainon *,”* Mydei bites back, teasing, “aren’t you the one being bold, *jester?”*

The two are a ways from the dining room, still down the halls where the acoustics won’t echo their conversation, where they won’t be heard by his mother.

Phainon realizes, subtly, that Mydei had stayed by the front door all this time knowing that their bickering would devolve to this eventually. He'd waited for Phainon to come before he'd been emboldened to do this, to *tease.*

The realization brings a slow grin to his face. Mydei smirks in response, "Finally caught on, haven't you?"

"Bickering as foreplay *? Seriously* ?"

Mydei grins, innocent as he shrugs, pushing Phainon off and walking towards the dining room, sauntering like he owns the place.

"I have *no* idea what you're talking about."

Lunch had been good. Great, even.

Gorgo really did just want to meet the two while she was in Okhema, before she'd left to Castrum Kremnos again for another relics appraisal expedition, another piece of culture to restore, more to learn about, more to keep. Her cooking was homey, similar to what Mydei himself always made.

At some point, Mydei had slipped away to the bathroom, or wherever, when Gorgo turned to him, smile full of pride and good-natured mischief with an offer, "Would you like to look at some baby pictures?"

It'd been a good ten or so minutes of them giggling at how *shit-faced* Mydei looked as a baby.

"IS HE WRESTLING A GROWN MAN?"

And also at how he continued to be *impossible* even as a child.

Gorgo laughs, the kind of laugh that makes you double-over, the one from resurfacing good memories and making new ones, the laugh you only really make when you're comfortable and happy where you are, "That's my boy!" She grins, "Oh, and that one's Krateros," she says, pointing at the young adult that Mydei was performing a single-leg takedown on.

The man looks some part deeply impressed and some part completely taken by surprise, immortalized in an image of him getting his marbles rocked by an 8 year old.

"Krateros was a neighbour of ours, worked in a gym and all that, teaching people to fight. It was good to meet another Kremnoan after we'd moved. My son grew up suplexing him and bringing him treats, afterwards, always insisting sugar would help him recover," she smiled, fond as she flipped the pages, revealing tens of pictures of Mydei in the kitchen baking or

cooking, flour on his cheeks and dough in his hands and looking every bit like the child he was.

“He moved to the outer edges of the city, that old fart, always insisting on peace and quiet. He ought to visit sometime. He knows our address hasn’t changed.”

Phainon traces the pictures gently, like holding an especially dear memory. “Were these all taken in Okhema?”

Gorgo huffs, “Yeah. I’d made the move when he was 7, or thereabouts. He was young, that’s for sure,” she sighs, “He hadn’t even complained back then, not the slightest whine about it all.”

Phainon nods, lets Gorgo ponder in the memory, and he breathes, “Well,” he huffs “that certainly sounds like Mydei.”

“He’s always been this way, hasn’t he?” She laughs, “He was a cute boy. Still is.” And then she goes quiet, fingers idly tracing the edges of a photo of Mydei in a library in his early teens, sporting a pair of glasses, nose buried in a book.

Phainon just looks, eyes following her fingers as they outline the shape of his cheeks, still with baby fat and full, the squint of his eyes and the title of the book, ‘ *As I’ve Written’,* plastered on its front, gold and cursive.

“He grew up well, didn’t he?” Phainon asks, absent-mindedly.

Gorgo hums, shifting her weight to lean back on her chair. “The greatest gift I’ve ever had is being able to see him grow into the man he is now,” she breathes, “and the only thing I could ask is for him to stay like this– a good man. A happy man.” She says, and turns to Phainon, looking every bit like the mother that she is.

Phainon thinks of good sons and sacrifices, imagines a young Mydei and four walls, and books and not people, with a past not pondering his future and he wonders, distantly, how they’d both turned out so differently.

“A happy man, huh?” He muses.

He thinks of Wednesdays and dinners, breakfasts and shared beds, the life they’d built together, one where Mydei isn’t only an onlooker in history, one where he is finally a part of the narrative. He thinks of his role in that life. A friend, a roommate, an annoyance, a rival, a lover and the myriad of in-betweens and he thinks that, maybe, he’s found somewhere to stay as well.

The dining room is silent, the only sound is the quiet thump of footsteps, Mydei’s, descending down the stairway.

Gorgo looks at him and smiles. A small, knowing thing.

The apartment is nostalgic, to say the least.

Mydei has long memorized the layout of the apartment, of their home.

The stairway that led up to his mother's room, his refuge in his younger years, fresh out of Kremnos and with the kind of restlessness only children have in unfamiliar cities and unfamiliar homes.

After leaving his father in Kremnos, saying goodbye to the older kids who lived in their neighborhood and moving to a bigger city, Mydei was relatively well adjusted. He moved after learning what it meant for his parents to separate but before hormones and puberty kicked in, before he could've regretted leaving an old life behind, before he understood the implications of only having a mother, he up and left Kremnos and moved into Okhema.

On reflection, it was the best time to start a new life.

It was on a random day, one of the first weeks after they'd moved and before they'd set up their kitchen, it was after another pacing up and down on staircases and before they'd introduced themselves to the neighbours, that his mother had taught him to cook.

"You're going to scare the dough, treating it so roughly," she huffed, gently prying the mixture of flour, water, butter, sugar and yeast off his hands.

He was frustrated, then, he thinks. A petulant frown on his face that his mother had wiped away, along with the flour. "Don't be discouraged," she'd said, "you can and must be gentle. Our neighbours's first impression will be the results of your labor. You're a kind boy, my son, let them feel it as well."

"...sorry," was all he'd muttered, and then she'd shake her head and then, they'd start again. Kneading dough, but gently– a labor of love through sugar.

It didn't take long for him to be at least decent at it, until his mother would nod in approval and Krateros would finally allow himself to try his baked goods in front of him, confident he would not need to mask his expressions and he learned what it meant to be kind, through food.

Then, baking turned into waking, trying to wake earlier than his mother did or staying later than his curfew, hobbling together a lunch, a snack, something to prepare, something his mother could bring to her new job at the museum for work, on the days that her shoulders seemed heavy from the memory, from discarding an old life, from raising a son, all on her own, in a new city.

At first, she'd scolded him for disregarding his own sleep and rest to do such a thing. But, with a stubbornness only sons have for their mothers, he'd continued, the only act of rebellion he'd really done against his her. And his mother would, eventually, relent. And then scolding would become a gentle, tired, yet appreciative pat on the head, a thank you, a

promise to teach him recipes, what it meant to give, and how to braid hair to get the longest strands away when he cooked, just like she did.

His childhood was relatively normal, all things considered.

His mother worked in the National museum, curating and consulting, keeping track of the culture of Kremnos she'd left behind when they moved. He would go to public school and study, and wait and walk to the city's library until his mother was off work, and on the days she wasn't tired, she'd read to him, in that children's corner: history, *their* history, of heroes and heirs and titans, of wars and sacrifice and most importantly, of love.

Those were the days he liked best.

When his mother's eyes were shining, speaking of the pride they'd ought to have as Amphoreans, as people. She'd speak about a titan of love, of reason, of death, of trickery and of strife. He'd ask, *what good could there be, from a thief, from a reaper?* And she'd answer, wise and patient, as all mothers are with their children, *if you wish to be, even death may be kind.*

On other days, he'd see Krateros to walk him home from school.

He was a neighbour, a fellow Kremnoan, the man he grew up seeing and the man who preferred cookies over cakes and breads over pies because he'd be able give them to the children he trained at the gym, the man whose arm he almost broke when he was 12, trying a new takedown before he'd learned what it meant to spar and not just *fight,* and the man who attended his PTA there when his mother couldn't– family in all but name.

He'd grow up, writing a foreign language and speaking a foreign tongue, confusing Krateros who'd lived in Okhema most his life, but Krateros had indulged him regardless, on the days he babysat while his mother was in the museum.

He read books, asked his mother for phrases, and learnt a language he could only speak to his mother, the language of their old, dying past, the language of Kremnoans. And that was how he grew up: dreaming of a black tide and of triumph, of loss and old languages. He grew up speaking it, not the language of Kremnos, specifically, but the language of his mother.

Of history, food, and culture.

There was nothing missing in that two bedroom apartment in downtown Okhema, close enough to the center to access the city's library by bus but not too residential as to be crowded.

Once he'd grown out of his mother's bedroom a mattress was placed in the spare that'd been filled with bookshelves. They'd installed a desk and a frame, eventually, but the books stayed. And so he'd find a new world there, one between the printed ink on paper, one in writing. His world had been so full that he hadn't been able to see left or right.

They hadn't left much behind in Kremnos. Just old friends, old attachments, and a few sentimental things they couldn't bring back, things they couldn't fit in their four walls and

new life and dense, city living.

His father's journal, for example. An old photograph of their family. An old baby shower invitation.

And his mother's own signet ring.

She'd kept their house in Kremnos after the divorce, but she'd left the ring tucked away, closed in a case in the drawer of her old shared bedroom. It stayed in her old life, because that ring meant old families, and old families meant everything she'd wanted to leave in Kremnos. In any case, they'd left it behind, and it was meant to stay there until there could be new meaning to it, until the ring meant more than a failed marriage, until family meant more than the man she'd just parted ways with.

There weren't a lot of things they'd left behind. But sometimes, still, he remembers.

Mydei had never felt lost. Not in the way he knows Phainon does, lost in his own head, lost in his doubts, lost in insecurity and drowning in it. No, Mydei knows that he's always been steady, somewhat. If anything, he's just been *alone.*

Not debilitatingly so, not devastatingly so, but just enough to feel it. To notice the solitary path he seemed to stride on unflinchingly.

His mother, lovely as she is, had always needed to leave their flat for days, weeks at a time. Mydei didn't mind– Krateros was there, after all. And if he wasn't, then he had himself and he had his books, and he had a whole trove of words and stories to explore and to learn about before his mother came back. His peers, as well, were not unkind to him. They admired him from a distance, surely, they liked him well enough. But there was a separation, a disconnect of the world he'd grown up in and the world they were living in now. He cared for them, but he knew, somehow, that he did not belong.

And so he'd grown up that way, a degree of awkward, somewhat caught up in his own world and just slightly separate from reality.

He thought he'd live on like that.

Then one day, a boy with the most beautiful blue eyes from the Psych department ran into him, black coffee spilled all over his tank, on one of the first weeks in college, and he'd been too surprised to say anything about it.

He'd apologized profusely, scribbling down his number and promising to pay back his dry-cleaning bill but having to leave to get coffee again for his class. And on that same day he'd met him again, anxious and waiting for another black coffee at the cafe Mydei worked part-time at, still in his coffee-stained tee.

Phainon, he'd learned, was his name, and that he was in a rush because his professor, Anaxa or Anaxagoras or Naxy, or something, had insisted each student bring their own drink and some type of food to present as a kind of self-introduction.

Mydei simply stared, somewhat judgemental, because who would choose a basic hot black coffee as the drink to introduce themselves with?

Regardless, Cipher, his coworker, had somehow convinced him to pay extra to use the '*Arabica beans we keep in the back. That's the good shit. Professors love it,'* and so he'd made the coffee and ignored the money Phainon tried to give him to pay for his shirt, and Mydei thought that that was it for the weird encounter with the pretty psych student.

Barely half a day later, the white disaster named Phainon showed up at his doorstep, carrying his luggage and smelling distinctly of familiar, overpriced arabica coffee, brown stains on his pale yellow jacket.

"Your professor didn't like the drink?" He asked, in lieu of a greeting.

Phainon blinked, then laughed, almost self-deprecatingly, "I don't think he liked *me* at all. I got his name wrong. Half the class did, really. I have to think of another drink to self-introduce myself with," he moped.

Mydei eyed the luggage, opened the door wide and stepped aside. "New roommate, right? Come in. I'll help you figure something out."

"You don't have to do that," Phainon said as he stepped in, "I'll get to setting up my stuff and then I'll…concoct something. Or I'll ask your coworker again for tips. She seemed to know about Prof. 'Naxa."

Sure, Mydei had heard a lot about an *Anaxagoras* or '*Naxa'* as Cipher called him. Something about him being an old acquaintance of Cipher's, a friend of a friend. Or was it the enemy of a friend? He doesn't remember.

Regardless, trusting Cipher with favors wasn't something advisable. Especially if you'd already been scammed before. Mydei crossed his arms, levelling him with a look, "Cipher made you pay 10,000 credits for a drink that costs less than a thousand. Are you a nepo baby?"

Phainon wheezed, but didn't deny it. "I thought arabica was just expensive!"

"It might be, but you didn't question it being 12 times more expensive than regular black? Seriously? Do you know *anything* about coffee?"

"It was only 11 times more expensive," he muttered, "I might not drink coffee often but I know that it tastes like *shit* most of the time. And that it stains, bad."

Mydei snorted. "That's partly true." He wasn't too fond of straight black coffee, either. "As for the staining," he paused, appraising the jacket, "it's not too bad. I have bleach with me, I'm cleaning my tee. Might as well soak yours, too. Just hand me your jacket." He said, outstretching his arm.

Phainon's eyes narrowed, "You're not gonna stain it worse for revenge, right? I'm really not a nepo baby, I can't afford another jacket…"

Mydei's outstretched hand turned into a flick of his forehead, dead center between his eyes.

"Ow! What the hell was that for?"

"You were being annoying, HKS." He groaned, "You told me to go to the dry cleaners, which means you obviously can't clean for shit. Give me your jacket. I'm not offering twice."

Phainon grumbled but complied, mumbling *'thanks. teach me how to do it myself next time, your highness'* as Mydei snorted and replied back with a '*sure'*.

Later that night, Mydei had found his new roommate hunched over by their kitchenette, mourning a cup of what seemed like ground up black coffee mixed with milk. Not even steeped coffee, no, just a separate layer of grounds and dairy. With sprinkles on top

Beside him was a bowl of raw dough and what smelled like an undercooked yet burnt pan of…dark brown goop.

"Are those supposed to be brownies?" He asked, eyeing the pan.

Phainon simply looked at him with a horrified expression. "I tried making cinnamon rolls."

Mydei had stared, really stared, and wondered how such a man could qualify for college, and then he'd sighed, and told Phainon that he'd owed him a favor for staying up with him.

And so at 1am, on the first week of college, Mydei found himself making a frappe and cinnamon rolls. And he'd whipped out and put in the effort to sanitize the old dorm's blender to make a monstrosity of sprinkles, cookies and every sweet treat that Phainon had rushed over from their campus' convenience store, with barely any milk nor caffeine to be found.

Phainon had insisted, for some reason, to bring cinnamon rolls because *'I have layers, Mydei. And also, I paid Cipher for another tip.'* Mydei had been too tired to disagree, and so with a heavy heart and even heavier eyelids he rolled his sleeves and kneaded dough over his shitty dorm's kitchenette and if ever asked *why* he had wanted to do so, Mydei wouldn't be able to give a real answer.

Maybe he'd wanted to leave a good impression, to be nice with the man he'd spend the rest of his college life with. He's long learned to act instead of speak, to give and skip the pleasantries. Maybe he'd just wanted to practice baking again. Break into his skills while he was starting anew in his dorm. Or maybe it was because of how pathetic he'd looked, slumped over the kitchenette and halfway through stressing already.

Yeah, he thought, *that must be it.* He ignored the thumping in his chest and how his heart clenched when Phainon had frowned, burdened, a far cry from the almost fakely composed way he carried himself earlier that evening. They sat in silence, then, as the rolls baked and he waited for cream cheese to soften and Phainon stared at him, teary eyed and appreciative across from the kitchen counter.

"Mydeimos. Mydei. Dei. My bro…"

"Please. Never call me that."

Phainon whined, distinctly dog-like, and it looked like he's going to cry again. "I can't help it. I'm moved! Do you have classes tomorrow morning? The rolls are almost done, right? I can watch them bake through. You should rest," he said, fretting.

Mydei sighed. It was a good thing he didn't have any classes tomorrow. Though he *did* have an afternoon shift at the cafe. "I'm free for the morning," he said, "you're the one with morning classes. Go rest. I'll handle it."

"I can't do that," he frowned, "you're the one staying up for *my* assignment. How could I leave you be?"

"I'm just doing you a favor," Mydei shrugged. It wasn't too much trouble.

Sure, it was inconvenient, but Mydei thinks that it's a small price to pay to have a good relationship with his new roommate. Baking wasn't particularly unenjoyable, either. Besides, Phainon had already offered to clean up afterwards *and* he'd paid for all the ingredients. It wasn't too bad a deal.

"This is far more than just a simple favor." He said, a seemingly serious expression on his face.

Mydei snorted, "I'd rather lose a few hours of sleep than get woken up by the scent of burnt cinnamon. Do you know how hard it is to rid a room of the smell of burnt sugar?"

Okay, it wasn't that bad, really. But his new roommate wasn't backing off. Mydei had the feeling that Phainon was always the type to insist on repaying favors, the type to assume he was an inconvenience. Perhaps a bit of exaggeration on his end would help.

"That bad?" Phainon cringed.

"Not if you don't make it worse," he crossed his arms.

Phainon seemed like he wanted to apologize again, but their toaster-micowave-oven rang. "Just leave this to me," Mydei said, getting up and turning away, "you owe me one, that's all. Just take me out for lunch."

The other had just stared, wide-eyed and earnest, looking like he'd just owed Mydei some life-saving debt, and that was when Mydei really did kick him out of the kitchen.

Mydei still remembers the day after. Phainon showed up to the cafe, sporting another horrid combination of bright orange and blue he'd worn, catching Mydei's eye even as he waited patiently with the other customers for his shift to end.

He'd approached him after, a grin on his face as he bolted towards Mydei, bleary and tired and just slightly questioning the sudden closeness with his new roommate, dutifully reporting that his frappe monstrosity and rolls had somehow gotten professor Anaxa (*he even let him call him 'Anaxa', instead of 'Anaxagoras')* to *smile* . Whether it was because of the quality of the food itself or because of Cipher's tip didn't matter, so long as his assignment was done.

Earnestly, Phainon had thanked him, casually hugging him in the staff room and then stepping back just as easily as he asked him out (to lunch). Mydei, caught in the whirlwind of it all, still reeling from the hug, barely blushing but *definitely* flustered, had just enough sense in him left to nod, before he was dumped into reality, sitting at a dingy fast-food restaurant that Phainon had sworn was his favourite.

And that was the first meeting of the two.

There was a symbol on his mother's ring.

The symbol of Strife, apparently. A word that meant war, bloodshed, and death, one that was distinctly Kremnoan. It sat upon his mother's pinky finger like a promise. It sat on her finger as a mark of her family.

And then, the ring was gone.

Mydei had noticed the fact after they'd moved. His mother was always the type to teach instead of instruct. If she wanted him to aid in chores or the like, she would show him how to do so, first. Normally he'd watch her slip off her ring, place it aside like a treasure, and then her hands would be filled with the metaphorical dirt, or the literal suds of soap, of dough and of cooking.

She hadn't done that, after the move. Muscle memory came to slip off a ring made of air and not gold and she'd catch herself in the motion, laughing almost sadly, mourning what she had left behind.

It was an old memory, but one that stuck with him.

Another day, another time, his mother had done it again, and again, and again, the same slightly sad, slightly surprised expression. He'd asked her about it, then, on an off day between the time he'd started middle school and during the time he'd learned how to bleach-clean a shirt.

"My ring?" His mother questioned back, "What about it?"

The two were hunched over a little tub of bleach water. Two shirts, both his, both white, sank slowly in the warm acid water.

"It's in Kremnos, isn't it, mother?" Along with the journals and pictures and letters you used to keep of him, of my father, of your used-to-be husband.

She huffed, "It's at the bottom of the sea, my son," she said, a gentle, ringless hand settling on his head, "why do you ask? Oh, don't touch that. The water's hot."

His mother always asked him that. Not just *what* he was doing but *why*.

“Isn’t it special?” He asked again, petulant, mindlessly sticking his pinky finger in the water.

“It once was, maybe,” she shrugged, “but it’s just a ring, now. Another thing to keep in Kremnos.”

Gently, she lifted his hand out the water, “Look, you’ve left your finger in, now it’s all crummy and wrinkled. We can’t have that. This is why you must use gloves as you wash.” She said, handing him a pair.

Distinctly, his mother’s own hands were bare as she submerged them under water.

“The water’s fine now, son. Come, have a try.”

He did, wordlessly, feeling lukewarm water settle into his skin, the bleach making his fingers shrivel almost as if rejecting him. He fished around to find a shirt, to scrub at it like his mother did.

“You see this?” She pointed, lifting one of the shirts out of the water, “It’s white. Or, well, it used to be.” The shirt was off-white, slightly yellow from age or from an old spill or stain. A usual testament of its time, of casual sign of use.

“Sometimes, things just get old. They’re not broken yet, or unusable. Just old. Just no longer what we need,” she said, submerging the shirt underwater again.

“But we don’t throw them away, dear. We keep them somewhere else, until we make the effort to change them, or until we can spend the hour or so it takes to soak them in bleach. Until someone comes along who makes us want to bring up old things and renew what we thought was lost,” she smiled, once more, looking at him. But it wasn’t quite so sad.

“Can everything be washed like that?” He asked.

“Not with bleach, maybe,” she laughed, softly, “but nothing stays the same forever. Old things have meaning to new people. Old practices mean new things *with* new people.”

Slowly, Mydei lifted his own shirt out of the water, watching the suds slip off, slowly, taking away the stains, the discoloration, the age, the time along with it. His mother grinned as she walked away, washing her hands of the soap.

“I don’t have it in me to clean so often anymore,” she said, drying her hands off and silently looking at her own palms, “my hands are crummy and wrinkled, even without the bleach.”

She sighed, and Mydei didn’t think she was only talking about t-shirts anymore.

“But your hands are new, my son. Your hands have gloves as well. You don’t have to get shriveled up or ugly like mine.”

He tilted his head, frowning. “Your hands are well, mother.”

She grinned, “You think so?” He nodded.

His mother’s palms were large, large enough to knead a batch of dough, to ruffle his hair just so, large enough to cup his cheeks in both hands and pat his shoulder and hold his wrist, just gently, whenever he felt unsure.

Her palms were generous, always upturned and offering to neighbours, to children, to strangers down the street, always prepared to hold a fall when he felt shaky after a spar with Krateros. Warm to offer consolation, ample affection to hold him whenever he needed.

Her hands were strong enough to carry the life they had in Kremnos and rebuild it brick by brick through every relic, every book and waft of a smell. Every bit of furniture and moving box she’d unpacked and settled herself.

Her fingers were gentle as they carded through his hair with a brush or with her own digits, moving aside his bangs from where they fell on his face, or when twisting and braiding his hair. One, a long twist down and through the center or a smaller braid in front, a habit ingrained in his fingers.

But most importantly of all, her hands were *hers* , attached to the lovely, strong mother he’s always known. They could never be ugly or crummy or wrong, because they were his mother’s.

“Your hands are well,” he’d said again, even without a ring to adorn them his mother's hands would always be precious and kind.

Gorgo looked at her son, wide eyes almost indignant at how she’d described her hands, his own palms dutifully scrubbing at some old ratty shirt he hadn’t worn in years and there was no way to describe her heart but *full* , so very full of the love, of the joy of having a boy who loved and loves so much, so fiercely.

Her hand, imperfect, and lost, and no longer bearing the mark of her family, could only offer the barest bit of warmth as she carded through his hair, gentle, appreciative and loving, but he’d leaned into the touch regardless, a boyish, young look on his face.

What a wonderful thing it is, to be loved so gently. She kissed his forehead and his nose and he giggled, in the way sons do with their mothers, muttering ‘ *it tickles!’* as he grinned.

Her hands bore scars and old marks. Regrets and lost, unlovely things.

But if they could hold him, still, her son, her boy. If they were enough to guide him to cook, to clean, to touch and to love.

Then maybe her hands, still, are well.

“You seem to be having fun,” Mydei says, descending the staircase as he leans against the doorframe.

Gorgo is sitting next to Phainon, still, a photobook in her lap. Phainon huffs, “Not as much as you were, up there. Going to the bathroom, was it? You were there for a solid half hour!”

He rolls his eyes, “You exaggerate. I was visiting my old room, as well. Did you miss me that much?”

“Nope!” Phainon replies, grinning wide, “Your mother makes for great company. You can go run off and reminisce in your old bedroom, Mydei.”

Mydei shoves at him playfully as Phainon laughs, Gorgo closes the picturebook, softly, and shakes her head.

“You boys really are too much,” she says, pinching both their cheeks as Phainon flails and Mydei rubs at the reddenned skin. “Mydeimos,” she continues, “have you found what you were looking for?”

He huffs from where he stands by Phainon, nodding gently.

“That’s good,” she grins, “It’s best I leave you to it, then. I’ll be off to the museum. You keep your spare with you, lock the door when you leave.”

Mydei’s eyes soften at the sight of his mother, smiling in approval and bright. She looks happier these days. He thinks they both do. “Be well, mother.”

She laughs, “Of course.”

Before she leaves Phianon strides over, taking both her hands in his. “Gorgo, I-” he pauses, looking back at Mydei, “There are many things that I’d like to say to you. But thank you. For everything. For allowing me your son. I can’t promise much, but-”

“There is nothing,” she cuts, “for you to thank me for, son.”

Gently, she pats his hair, making him lean down, instinctively, unable to see her expression. “I’m the one who should thank you, boy,” her voice sounds old, at once, old and ancient, like she’s lived through multiple lives and loss, “be well, okay? The both of you.”

Softly, she cradles both his cheeks, warm and loving at once and that is when he sees her expression, slightly teary, wholly accepting. Gratitude in the form of love, of care.

“And-” she pauses, almost afraid to ask as she whispers, close to his ear, “make my boy happy, please.”

Phainon’s heart thumps in his chest. Yet, his heart thumps out of it as well. His heart stands, by the dining table still, aching at the scene of his lover and mother and his world and his sun, his home and his other half.

Phainon thinks that he cannot be perfect, that he cannot promise much, but he can promise this, at least. He will swear it.

“For as long as he has me,” he whispers back, “I’ll love him. I promise you that.”

Gorgo huffs, a smile, a laugh, a sob all at once. “That is all I could ask.”

She lets go, patting his cheek, waving a goodbye to the both of them. “And before I forget,” she says as she stands by the doorway, halfway to leaving as she looks at Phainon, “I’d asked Chartonus to forge another spare of the keys. It’s by the drawer. Keep it on you, son.”

And then, the door clicks shut.

Mydei hadn’t been back to Kremnos since their move.

He didn’t hate the city, nor did he leave with any regrets. But maybe that was why he’d never returned. There weren’t even any ghosts to haunt him there.

He had no pull towards the city, towards the neighbourhoods or his old home. He felt for the culture, the history, the language, the things that mattered, still, to his mother, to his life in Okhema. But the old house, the old relics, the things they’d left behind– he didn’t feel the need to mourn a life he barely remembered.

Yet, he stood, still, in front of four walls in a neighbourhood that didn’t recognize him anymore. He stood, still, in front of a house that used to be home. This is the first time, the only time, he thinks, that he’ll ever return to this place.

He gripped the key in his hands, rusted from almost two decades of unuse, and he opened the door, to silence.

He coughed, slightly, a thick layer of dust permeating the house.

Mydei had told Phainon that his trip to Kremnos would take a few days— five, at most. It took about a day to make the trip and check-in to the place he’d rented, at least two days to feasibly move and flip through the house and a day to return to Okhema.

The house looked more packed than he remembered, boxes of old picturebooks and clothing, things she’d kept from the marriage but could not bear to bring.

He doesn’t know if he hates his father for what he's done. Whatever, wherever he might be today, Mydei holds no contempt. He only knows that his father was fined some amount, that he’d lost custody, and had moved away. Whether that meant he stayed in Kremnos or if he moved somewhere else is, frankly, no longer a concern for either him or his mother.

And so he digs through the boxes and the cabinets to look for an old ring, and he thinks of his new person and new memories and old tees. He thinks of washing away a past, of redefining family. He thinks of blue and white and how lovely he’d look with gold, and he thinks of his mother and his father and he prays for love that will last.

His heart thumps, slow, heady, but light, working through dust and through the day.

Stashed away unlike a treasure but more a secret is a ring, with the symbol of war, bloodshed, and death. To Kremnos, a symbol of royalty. To his mother, a symbol of family.

To him, a symbol of what could be. Of meaning stamped in gold, of a promise reforged.

He remembers the conversation that prompted this trip, a call with his mother as she was in Janusapolis looking to aid in another museum's exhibition.

"And you're marrying this boy, yes?" She'd questioned.

Mydei choked on his spit.

"Mydeimos?" His mother asked, worried, "are you alright? Don't tell me you're ill."

"I'm-" he hacked, "I'm quite alright." He blushed on the other end.

As embarrassing as it was to be outing himself to his mother, hiding such a large portion of his life (and hopefully future life) was frankly worse. He's been more open to discussing such…feelings with his mother. It seemed to take the edge off her worry.

"It is my intention, yes, eventually to marry," he admitted, face still hot, "but he hasn't even confessed yet. I'd thought he reciprocated…" he muttered.

His mother hummed on the other end. "He loves you," she says, conclusively, "I can assure that much, my son. Perhaps he's only worried that *you* don't reciprocate."

Mydei frowned. Was that really it?

He'd thought he'd been quite forward with his feelings all this time. His invitations to spar, to dinner, his effort in taking care of the other at all times. It wasn't that his actions weren't enough, it was simply that Phainon didn't *want* to see it as romantic. It was a refusal of acknowledgement, but not a refusal of there being *something* between them.

"And you haven't confessed, dear?" She asked, breezily on the line.

"I haven't," he said, "I won't."

His mother hummed once more, not replying, but he knew she understood.

It was not that he didn't love Phainon, obviously not, it was simply a question of *when* they'd meet in the middle. He loved him, imperfect and unwhole and entirely human. He loved him as a rival, a friend, roommate, an annoyance and everything in between.

He's shown him that. That love. That same, unwavering, devotion. The only thing he's missing is faith. The trust in himself to accept his heart, to allow himself this love, this next step.

He would love the man even if he'd never noticed. He's only ever been waiting for him to ask.

“You intend to find my ring again?”

He breathes. “If you’ll allow me to.”

“Mydeimos,” she says, like reminding a child, like a mother, like he need not even ask, “there would be no greater joy.”

He’d asked for permission to keep it. To dunk it in proverbial bleach and watch as old meaning fell away, to see it give way to something kinder, something new. He hopes to keep it with him, awaiting whenever it is he might need it. Awaiting the day the man he’s already promised himself to will accept.

“You’ll be alone for quite some time,” his mother’s voice lilts, “but you will wait for him, yes?”

Mydei thinks of belonging.

He thinks of kind words and comforting touches, of an intimacy that always felt so casual, so easy. He thinks of a lonely path gaining another pair of footsteps. He thinks of routine, of a life built, of opportunities and companionship and a burden lightened just so. He thinks of hands growing crinkled with his own, scrubbing away suds, making ripples in a basin he thought he’d wash alone, forever.

He thinks of chance encounters, of bright eyes and kind smiles. He thinks of a home carved out in Okhema.

And he thinks, for once in his life, that there will be something he regrets, something he will miss, if he does not seize it.

He thinks that there could never be hesitance in his answer.

“Always.”

“This is…”

“My mother’s ring.”

After Gorgo had left, Mydei had been quiet.

Phainon was about to tease, about to ask him if he was simply suddenly sad once his mother departed but before he spoke Mydei had looked up, golden eyes blazing in a kind of quiet determination, and Phainon had immediately forgotten what he was to say.

He’d sat them both down, face to face at the dining table and slowly, he’d pulled out a velvet box.

The ring inside shone, bright, golden, and polished. Sat atop it was a symbol, one he's seen from the hours he's poured into learning his lover's culture, the diagram of a love he's devoted himself to, ever since they'd met then in college.

"It's beautiful," he mutters, enraptured.

This ring belonged– *belongs* to someone important. To Mydei, to his mother, to his heart.

Mydei looks at him, quiet, "It's yours," he replies, shy of breath.

Phainon's head snaps towards him, almost disbelieving.

A symbol of his culture, of his love, of his mother. What is Mydei doing, giving such a thing away?

"Keep it, Phainon," Mydei pushes the box towards him, innocently glinting in the light. And Phainon would be the only one to say so, but in that moment, Mydei had seemed meek.

Like offering a vulnerability, a weak spot, his greatest boon or weakness.

The box sits atop his mother's table in his old, childhood home. The image of it hits hard. This is the inner sanctity of what he holds most dear. His mother, his past and now, in this box, his future.

It is the intensity of Mydei's love that makes him shudder. Devotion so holistic it would be terrifying if not that he feels the same. That he's loved so intensely for just as long, that he wants to devote himself just as entirely– to his family, to his mother, to the things he loves and cares about. To him. To all of him.

His heart hammers in his chest, loud and erratic. He is not afraid of the commitment. No, he is only afraid of the promise.

It is one thing to be accepted by his mother and it is another to be acknowledged as a *part* of his family. Not simply a worthy lover but a worthy partner, a worthy son, someone worthy to stay, to have and hold his back.

It is one thing to be loved for who he is and what he does. It is another to be loved so entirely.

He wants to deny it. He wants, immediately, to ignore himself. To say, again, that he is unready, unworthy, unlovable, that he is unsure and incomplete and that he wants, to be ignorant, to deny Mydei this love and he wants, to be selfish, and to beg for him to wait a little longer.

But then he looks at Mydei, *really* looks, and suddenly, his mouth is dry.

Because Mydei looks at him with devotion so earnest that he cannot deny it. He looks at him with acceptance so clear that there can be no doubts. Mydei looks at him like he is wholly worthy of love, and Phainon cannot feel anything but small in the face of its enormity.

“Mydei,” he whispers, “ *Mydeimos.* ”

“Phainon,” he replies. “Please. Will you take it?”

He is not offering a ring, Phainon thinks, but he is offering himself.

Devotion packaged in gold, materialized in a promise.

His heart bubbles into his throat.

“You want this.” He says, and does not ask, “You want me,” he whispers, *why?*

“I want you,” he mutters, “even if you do not want yourself.”

I love you, he means, *in your entirety.*

Phainon wants to reply with his own, impossibly cheesy, unbearably sweet confession. But really, his brain is tired of having to think so much. Of so many doubts, of so much waiting, of too many what-ifs and what-nots and all he can think, all he can feel, now, is the wanting.

If Phainon denies this ring, this advance, he knows that Mydei would wait, however heartbroken he might be, until Phainon is better, until he is *worthy.*

Instead, Phainon stands, and kisses him.

And Mydei gasps but there is no hesitation when he responds, a giggle in his mouth, an arm around his neck, laughter, incredulous, beautiful laughter bubbling in his chest that threatens to spill even as his tongue slips past and their teeth clack together.

It bubbles in his chest but he does not release it but Phainon knows, anyway because he moves in closer and picks his lover up, spinning and Phainon allows his own laughter to escape as Mydei blushes but does not let go, arms locked tight around his shoulders.

Mydei smiles like the sun, like a cat, pleased and beckoning, “Phainon,” he breathes with the remnants of a laugh, “ *Phainon* , you haven’t answered my question.”

“What question?” He blinks innocently. Like a dog wagging its tail after causing mischief. Like he’s excited over the prospect of doing as he likes.

Mydei flicks his forehead.

“You’re being dense.”

“I’m being myself.”

“*Exactly* so.”

“And here I thought you loved me as I am.”

“Making jokes, are we?” Mydei’s hands cradle his face as he’s lifted, still, by his thighs in his arms. “I want to hear it from you. I want to hear you say it until you believe it to be true. That

I want you, Phainon. I will always want you and that ring–”

His grip tightens ever so slightly cradling his jaw.

“It is a reminder. From me, to you. That so long as gold glistens and the symbol of strife holds. I will fight for you. I will love you. Whatever, whoever you become.”

“Even if I were a dog?”

Mydei rolls his eyes. “I would love you even if you’d never known me.”

And Phainon laughs, a rich sound that takes up his whole chest, that rises like the sun, like heat and smoke, the motion of his heart and his breath pushing his head back as he spins, cradling the world in his orbit.

“I love you,” he says as they fall on the floor, when his arms have given way but he’s managed to cradle him, still, protecting his heart from most of the fall.

Mydei lays atop his chest huffing, the incredulous kind of laugh that comes only when you’re in love.

“No, listen. I *adore* you,” Phainon says again, hand carding through his hair, his left hand smudging slightly on the pigment of his eyeliner, and his right hand’s thumb dropping down to his bottom lip, prodding, before kissing his thumb with a smirk, “You’re impossible and wonderful and the best thing that’s ever happened to me. You keep me sane. You inspire me to be better for myself and for you. You make me a better man because *you* are so incredible yourself.”

“I love you,” he says, finishing his speech, “and I want you. I want to have you, for as long as you will want me. And because I know you, I hope, that means that you want me forever, too.”

Phainon peers up at Mydei through his bangs, through the framing curtain of white that sweeps over his eyes, the shadows accentuate the boldness of his eyes, the certainty of his gaze and the back light of the kitchen shines on him just so, brightening his smile and the room. Even the light itself makes way for the wonderful man that is his lover. As if the world itself loves his soul.

“I love you,” Mydei replies, “with all the words I know and do not know how to say. With all the time we have spent and will spend together. I love you, and I don’t think anything could ever change that.”

And he kisses him once more. Slow and bright and sweet and it’s like the world itself has finished its orbit, like returning to spring after winter, returning to what’s known and warm and loved because it is its nature to. Because Phainon will always gravitate towards Mydei and because their orbits will always align.

“You haven’t. Answered. The question.” Mydei huffs.

“Have I not praised you enough?”

“That is not what I asked. Flattery will get you nowhere.”

Phainon laughs, “Where else do I need to go? *Yes*, Mydei, love of my life, heart of my body, *yes*, I will accept the ring and cherish it and, if I may, loop a chain around it and keep it around my neck so that I may never have to take it off. *Yes*, Mydeimos. I want you, I want this, forever, too.”

Mydei huffs, satisfied and Phainon sits up, both of his lover’s things straddling his own.

“Can we get back to this, then? I was getting excited making out.” He says, hand resting innocently atop his thigh.

Mydei blinks, incredulous, at the man he’d just sworn himself to, and he combusts, red and heady and embarrassed but wanting all at once.

“Not in my *mother’s* house!”

Chapter End Notes

A/N: I couldn't help but be unserious at the end, forgive me, but this chapter actually does mean a lot to me.

You might've seen but yes, there is one more chapter because I couldn't fit all of it in this one.

When I started writing this I honestly never expected it to grow to this...size. Both in terms of the plot and also in terms of you all, who are somehow here and reading this fic. I wanna apologize for the delays or for going MIA. Thank you for bearing with me.

Also, I added the character study tag because I've been writing more introspection and I sort of like the split. This fic has ended up slightly less lighthearted than I initially planned for so if any tags are missing / don't fit please feel free to tell me in the comments!

Once more, I want to thank every one of you for your support, it means the absolute world to me!

Ps. I have a twitter account @earlgreyingtea for wips and threads and me, I guess. I'm unserious I promise. Come say hi!

I'll also post fic updates at my twt alt @oversteaped!

Till we meet again, thank you for reading!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!